



'ANTI-INCUMBENCY SENTIMENTS'
People will favour UDF in Kerala: KPCC chief
ASSEMBLY POLLS » PAGE 11

'BEAR GRIP'
Benchmark indices fall 2.5% amid West Asia war
BUSINESS » PAGE 13





INFLOWS FALL
Net FDI negative for fifth straight month
BUSINESS » PAGE 13

WORLD TB DAY
Pushing back against TB
A curated set of articles on eliminating the tuberculosis epidemic
EDITORIAL & OPINION » PAGES 8 & 9



'ORANGE ECONOMY'
Centre unveils plans to boost creative economy
NEWS » PAGE 12



Nine convicted of Sattankulam custodial deaths

MADURAI
Nearly six years after trader P. Jayaraj and his son J. Benicks died of custodial torture at the Sattankulam Police Station in Thoothukudi, the First Additional District and Sessions Court in Madurai has convicted all nine policemen accused in the case. » **PAGE 6**

DMK-Cong. rift over Puducherry seats persists

PUDUCHERRY
Differences within the Congress-DMK alliance over seat-sharing continued even on the last day of filing of nominations for Assembly polls in Puducherry. » **PAGE 6**

Trump pauses strikes on Iran, says deal is possible

Attacks on power infrastructure in Iran will be 'postponed' for five days, says U.S. President; major 'points of agreement' reached in 'good and productive talks', he says; Iran rejects Trump's claims

Stanly Johny

U.S. President Donald Trump, who issued a 48-hour ultimatum to Iran on Saturday to reopen the Strait of Hormuz or face strikes on its power infrastructure, said on Monday that he would postpone the attacks for five days after "very good and productive" talks with Tehran.

"I am please[d] to report that the United States of America and the country of Iran have had, over the last two days, very good and productive conversations regarding a complete and total resolution of our hostilities in the Middle East," Mr. Trump wrote in a social media post.

Later in Washington, Mr. Trump told pressper-



Taking hits: A residential building damaged by a strike, amid the U.S.-Israeli conflict with Iran, in Tehran on Monday. REUTERS

sons that the Islamic Republic and the U.S. had "very, very strong talks" and there were "major points of agreement" between the two countries with a "real possibility of making a deal".

Iranian Parliament Speaker Mohammad-Bagher Ghalibaf, however, de-

nied negotiations with the U.S., saying that "fake news is intended to... escape the quagmire in which America and Israel are trapped".

Iranian Foreign Ministry also denied Mr. Trump's claims while the Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps (IRGC) said it

Two more Indian vessels cross Strait of Hormuz

CHENNAI
Two Indian-flagged LPG carriers, *Jag Vasant* and *Pine Gas*, have transited through the Strait of Hormuz on Monday evening. They are together carrying nearly 93,000 tonne of LPG, as per the inter-Ministerial briefing held on Monday. » **PAGE 10**

launched a new wave of missile and drone attacks targeting the U.S. Fifth Fleet in Bahrain and U.S. bases in other West Asian countries.

CONTINUED ON » PAGE 10
LONG-TERM IMPACT: PM » PAGE 10

BJP allotted 27 seats in AIADMK-led NDA in T.N.

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

The BJP, one of the key constituents of the AIADMK-led NDA in Tamil Nadu, has been allocated 27 seats for the 2026 Assembly election, seven more than in 2021.

The PMK, led by R. Anbumani, has been allotted 18 constituencies. The AMMK, led by T.T.V. Dhinakaran, has got 11 seats. AIADMK general secretary Edappadi K. Palaniswami announced the seat-sharing deal in Chennai on Monday.

He told the media that talks were under way with some more parties [such as the Tamil Maanila Congress (Moopanar)], and that the details would be announced shortly.

FULL REPORT ON » PAGE 6
CPI(M)'S DEAL WITH DMK » PAGE 6

Centre signals early delimitation, women's quota for 2029 polls

Nistula Hebbar
NEW DELHI

The Union government has indicated that it will bring an amendment Bill proposing a delimitation exercise based on the 2011 Census to ensure the implementation of the Women's Reservation Act, 2023, ahead of the 2029 Lok Sabha election.

Under the proposed amendments, the number of Lok Sabha seats will increase from 543 to 816, with 273 seats, 33%, reserved for women. The amendments could be brought in the ongoing Budget Session or in a Special Session called for the purpose.

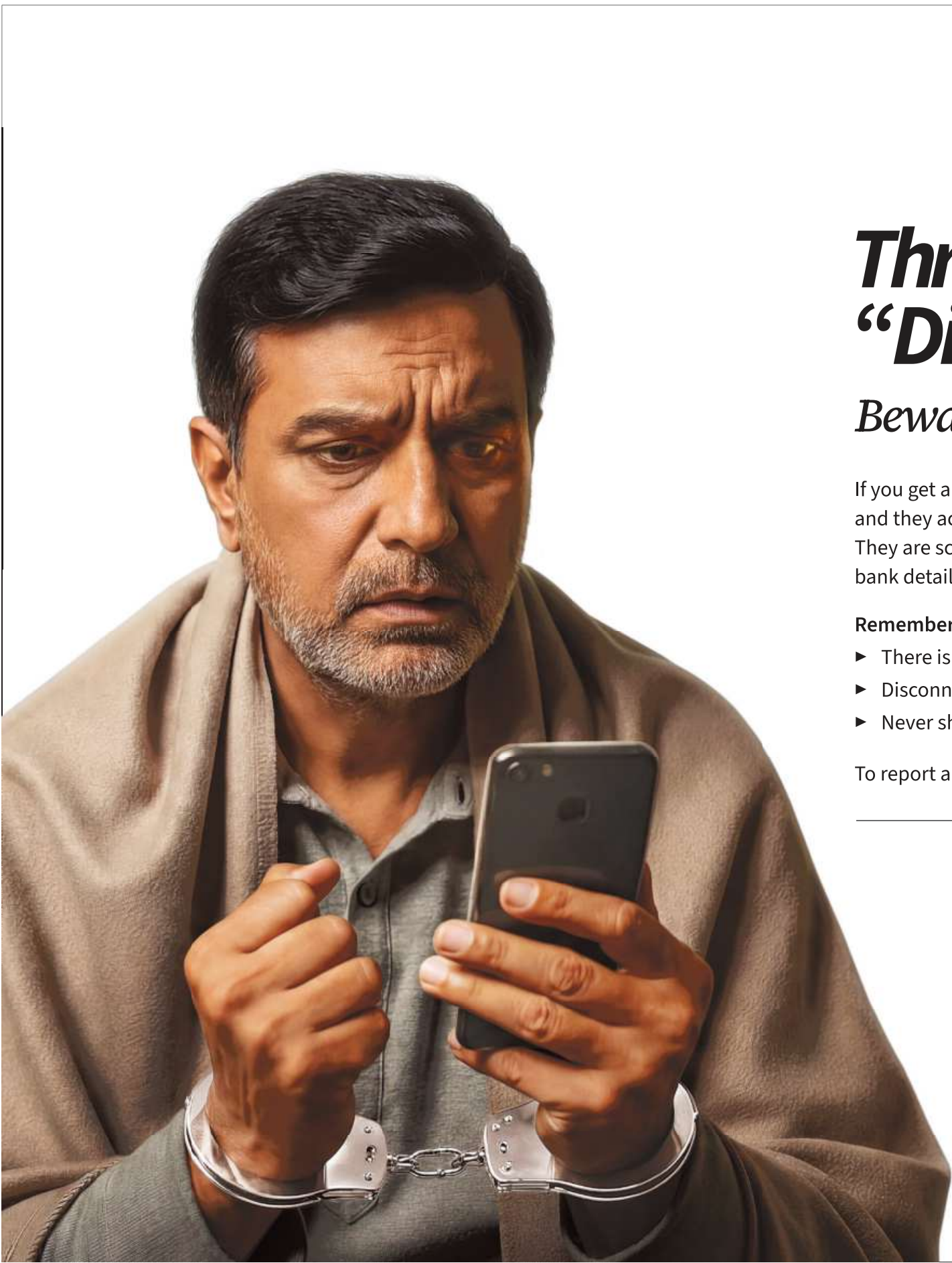
States' concern
Though the draft of the amendments are yet to be circulated, it is understood by sources that care would be taken so that the existing proportion of seats will



The Bill will enable delimitation based on the 2011 Census to implement the 2023 quota Act.

be maintained for all States, amid concerns that States that had showed success in population control programmes would lose out on representation *vis a vis* more populous States. Southern States had in particular expressed this concern. Overall, each State is likely to see a 50% rise in seats, but the pro-rata basis would be maintained.

CONTINUED ON » PAGE 10





Threatened with a “Digital Arrest”?

Beware, it’s a scam.

If you get a video call from someone claiming to be police or law enforcement, and they accuse you of transporting drugs or money laundering, do not worry. They are scammers trying to scare you. Even when they demand money or bank details, **stay calm and do not panic.**

Remember:

- ▶ There is **NO “Digital Arrest”** in India. It’s 100% fake
- ▶ Disconnect the call immediately
- ▶ Never share any personal or bank details, OTP, PIN or passwords

To report a fraud, **call 1930** or **visit www.cybercrime.gov.in**



www.kotak.bank.in

This is an AI-generated image. Any resemblance to real persons is purely coincidental.



A CH-CHE

CM
YK

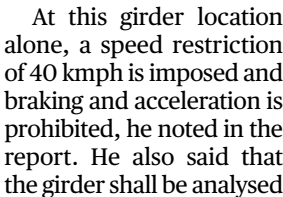
A CH-CHE

THE HINDU
DISCLAIMER: Readers are requested to verify and make appropriate enquiries to satisfy themselves about the veracity of an advertisement before responding to any published in this newspaper. THE PUBLISHING PVT LTD., the Publisher & Owner of this newspaper, does not vouch for the authenticity of any advertisement or advertiser or for any of the advertiser's products and/or services. In no event can the Owner, Publisher, Printer, Editor, Director/s, Employees of this newspaper/company be held responsible/liable in any manner whatsoever for any claims and/or damages for advertisements in this newspaper.

CHENNAI: A 26-year-old advocate was injured after a stray kite string coated with *manja* slashed across his face on the Maduravoyal bypass flyover on Sunday night. Mohammed Rasheed was riding a two-wheeler, when he was struck by the kite string. The Vanagaram police have registered a case.

The real-time monitoring system continuously tracks structural responses during train operations, with automated trigger mechanisms that can capture critical data during passage of trains

The system continuously tracks structural responses during train operations, with automated trigger mechanisms capturing critical data during train passage. Importantly, the portal is not static—it is being continuously en-



The CMRL is likely to open the Poonamallee-Porur-Vadapalani stretch after the Model Code of Conduct is lifted.

The permission is subject to affiliation from the Tamil Nadu Dr. MGR Medical University, Chennai and approval from Rehabilitation Council of India, New Delhi.

The transgender persons have planned to continue protests until the amendment Bill is withdrawn. "If it is passed, we will not rest until it's removed," Sudha stressed.



Planning a holiday to the UK?

Apply for your visa now.

Tower Bridge, London

With the peak season approaching, you can apply for your UK visa up to 3 months in advance of your intended travel dates. You can also choose from a range of additional services provided by UKVI and VFS Global to further enhance your experience.

UKVI Account Creation

VFS Global can assist in creating your UKVI Account and linking your eVisa.

Super Priority Visa

Get a decision by the end of the next working day.

Priority Visa

Get a decision within 5 working days, or 30 working days for Family visa applications.

On Demand Mobile Visa

Submit your visa application with comfort and convenience from your doorstep - home, office or preferred location.

Premium Lounge

For a personalised and enhanced experience while submitting your visa application.

To know more about our optional services, scan the QR code.

Marc Owen
Director for Visa, Status and Information Services at UK Visas and Immigration (UKVI)

UK has remained as one of the top travel destinations of the world over the years, with the demand for UK visas continuously increasing, especially during peak season. At UKVI we are committed to meeting our service level agreements for processing visa applications, however we request our customers to apply early for their UK Visa via a VFS Global Visa Application Centre for a hassle-free visa application experience.

Apply for your UK visa now at VFS Global visa application centres across **18 cities in India**. For more information, please visit: www.vfsglobal.com/united-kingdom

The global leader in trusted technology services, empowering secure mobility for governments and citizens.

24 Years Since Inception	71 Client Governments	167 Countries of Operation	4,080 Application Centres	Over 537 Million Transactions* Processed	Over 229 Million Biometric Enrolments	Over 17,500 Employees	167 Nationalities	
---------------------------------	------------------------------	-----------------------------------	----------------------------------	---	--	------------------------------	--------------------------	--

Disclaimer: Please note that the service(s) is/are currently offered for select locations/countries. Availability and the service charges for the above-mentioned service(s) may vary depending upon the country/location where it is procured. The choice of location for availing the service may also vary. The grant or refusal of the visa is at the sole discretion of UK Visas & Immigration and availing of the above added value service will not affect the processing time or decision of your visa as VFS Global is neither involved in the process nor is VFS Global liable or responsible in any manner whatsoever for the grant or rejection of the visa application of any customer by UK Visas & Immigration. For further information on the same, kindly refer to the terms and conditions on the VFS Global website. The above-mentioned services are optional and will be charged in addition to the visa application fee. The customer hereby accepts and confirms that they, prior to availing the above-mentioned service(s), have read, understood and agreed to be bound by, without limitation or qualification, all of the terms and conditions associated with the service(s). I Statistics as on 28 February 2026. *Comprised of 335.45 million transactions of VFS Global and 201.85 million transactions by CIX Citizen Experience.

Packaged water turns costly as raw material prices rise due to West Asia conflict

The cost of each cap used in bottles has increased from about 10 paise to 30 paise or 40 paise; the price of a 20-litre bubble-top container has been increased by ₹5 to offset rising input cost

WATER WATCH

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Packaged drinking water – both bubble-top containers and bottles – has become costlier across the State, with manufacturers citing rising raw material costs amid the ongoing conflict in West Asia. Prices are expected to rise further in the coming weeks if input costs continue to climb.

The increase in cost of packaged drinking water, now an essential commodity, is set to further strain household budgets.

A. Shakespeare, founder-president, Greater Tamil Nadu Packaged Drinking Water Manufacturers Association, said the cost of the petroleum-derived raw materials and plastic packaging like caps has increased by 60% recently.

The cost of a 20-litre capacity bubble-top containers has been increased by ₹5 to offset rising input cost. Major brands have hiked the price by a minimum of ₹10 per container. A 20-litre capacity bubble-top is priced between ₹35 and ₹50. Though production has dipped by 20%, it has not yet impacted the



Feeling the pinch: Major brands have hiked the price by a minimum of ₹10 per container. FILE PHOTO

market as demand typically peaks from mid-April, he said.

On an average, nearly three crore litres of packaged drinking water are sold across the State every day. Of this, Chennai and neighbouring areas account for nearly 1.5 crore litres. There are nearly 1,486 manufacturers operating across the State.

E. Saravanan, the association's general secretary said the cost of raw materials such as polyethylene terephthalate (PET) and high-density polyethylene (HDPE) used in bottles and

The cost of one-litre bottle has risen to ₹25. Further price hikes are expected if there is a revision in fuel prices

bubbletops, has seen a sharp spike. This has had a cascading effect on packaging components like bottles and caps.

For instance, the cost of each cap used in bottles has increased from about 10 paise to 30 paise or 40 paise now. Similarly, bubbletop container, which

was priced at ₹110, now costs ₹175.

Manufacturers have raised the price of bottled water, with the cost of one-litre bottle revised up to ₹25. Further increases are expected if there is a revision in fuel prices, Mr. Saravanan said.

Residents noted that bottled water is often sold above the MRP, particularly at railway stations. Consumer activist T. Sadagopan called for stricter price regulation and installation of free drinking water dispensers in public places.

Supreme Court asks PMK to approach Civil Court in party symbol dispute

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Supreme Court on Monday said the Madras High Court “appears to be right” in dismissing petitions filed by Pattali Makkal Katchi (PMK) founder S. Ramadoss, seeking a direction to the Election Commission of India to decide the dispute between him and the faction led by his son, R. Anbumani, over the party’s ‘mango’ symbol.

The PMK had appealed to the Supreme Court against the High Court’s dismissal of Dr. Ramadoss’s petition to either let his faction use the party’s symbol during the Assembly election in Tamil Nadu and Puducherry, or freeze the symbol.

“The High Court appears to be right in holding that the dispute re: allocation of symbol among the two rival groups of an unrecognised political party cannot be decided by the Election Commission of India,” a Bench led by Chief Justice of India Surya Kant observed. However, the top court said the aggrieved party must not be left remediless.

The Bench said the petitioner had already filed a civil suit. The court said the petitioner could file an appropriate application raising his demand before the Civil Court. “If such an application is filed by tomorrow, March 24, 2026, we direct the Civil Court to decide the same after hearing the parties and in accordance with law within a period of three days,” the



S. Ramadoss



R. Anbumani

dia,” a Bench led by Chief Justice of India Surya Kant observed. However, the top court said the aggrieved party must not be left remediless.

The Bench said the petitioner had already filed a civil suit. The court said the petitioner could file an appropriate application raising his demand before the Civil Court. “If such an application is filed by tomorrow, March 24, 2026, we direct the Civil Court to decide the same after hearing the parties and in accordance with law within a period of three days,” the

Supreme Court said. The top court said it had not expressed any opinion on merits, leaving the parties to the suit, including those who may seek their impleadment, at liberty to raise all legal contentions before the Civil Court.

The High Court had agreed with the ECI that factional disputes in an unrecognised political party could be resolved only through a Civil Court decree. The civil suit had been filed in the dispute between the father and son over the party presidency.

Decomposed body of 25-year-old man found inside quarry

The Hindu Bureau
DINDIGUL

A 25-year-old man, hailing from Senthurai Pillayar Natham in Dindigul district, was reportedly found dead inside a private stone quarry at Saralaipatti village near Natham on Sunday. Police said the highly decomposed body – which was later identified as that of Karuppasami – was spotted by some workers on Monday morning.

Mental illness

On receiving information, the police sent the body to a government hospital for a post-mortem examination. Family members of Karuppasami had been searching for him for the past few days after he went missing.

He was suffering from a mental illness, a police officer said during a preliminary inquiry.

Demanding the closure of the stone quarry, the villagers sought a detailed investigation into the death.

10 dummy AK-47 rifles seized in Ashok Nagar

CHENNAI: A routine vehicle check by the election flying squad in Ashok Nagar on Monday morning led to the seizure of 10 AK-47 rifles from a mini-

van, briefly triggering security concerns. However, subsequent verification confirmed that the weapons were realistic film props.

AMARAVATI GROWTH and INFRASTRUCTURE CORPORATION LIMITED (AGICL)
PROJECT OFFICE, RAYAPUDI, THULLURU MANDAL, (A.P.)
E Procurement Tender Notice
NIT NO:130/ MAU61-USI0HB(OTH)/493/2025-HB, Dt: 23.03.2026,
Name of the works: Construction of Andhra Pradesh Judicial Academy with Pile Foundation, Super Structure with RC Columns-Beams Framed Structure, Architectural Finishes, Internal Electrical & Plumbing works, HAVC works and IT works including External Electrical, Plumbing, Infrastructure Facilities, Internal Roads, for Andhra Pradesh Judicial Academy, Amaravati, Andhra Pradesh. The bid can be downloaded on AP e-procurement portal from 28.03.2026 to 15.04.2026 up to 14.00 Hrs. Pre-Bid Meeting Date:02.04.2026, Due date for submission of Bid 15.04.2026 up to 15.00 Hrs, Technical bid opening 15.04.2026@16.00Hrs. For further details please refer to www.approcurement.gov.in and www.crda.ap.gov.in
Sd/- Managing Director, AGICL, Project office APCRD, Rayapudi

BENGALURU EAST CITY CORPORATION
Office of the Executive Engineer, Marathahalli Division,
Bellanduru Main Road, Bellanduru, Bengaluru - 560103
No.: BECC/EE/MRH/TN/06/2025-26 Date: 23.03.2026
INVITATION FOR TENDERS (Short Term)
(Only through KPP Portal)
The Executive Engineer, Marathahalli Division, invites item rate tenders from the eligible tenderers for the work details in the table given below. The Tenderers shall be registered in Bengaluru East City Corporation / CPWD / KPWD / Railways / MES / any State or Central Govt. Organization.

Sl. No.	Name of the Work
1	Annual maintenance of footpath, desilting of drains and other allied works of arterial and sub-arterial roads in ward no. 41, MuneKolala. Amount put to tender (in Lakhs) Exclusive of GST: 59.26, EMD (in Rs.): 59,500/-, Eligibility of Contractor and Category: SC.
2	Desilting of ward roads and engaging tipper and labour in ward no. 41, MuneKolala. Amount put to tender (in Lakhs) Exclusive of GST: 101.64, EMD (in Rs.): 1,52,500/-, Eligibility of Contractor and Category: Others.
3	Annual maintenance of footpath, desilting of drains and other allied works of arterial and sub-arterial roads in ward no. 45, Marathahalli. Amount put to tender (in Lakhs) Exclusive of GST: 60.15, EMD (in Rs.): 1,20,500/-, Eligibility of Contractor and Category: Others.
4	Desilting of ward roads and engaging tipper and labour in ward no. 45, Marathahalli. Amount put to tender (in Lakhs) Exclusive of GST: 80.47, EMD (in Rs.): 80,500/-, Eligibility of Contractor and Category: CAT-1.
5	Annual maintenance of footpath, desilting of drains and other allied works of arterial and sub-arterial roads in ward no. 46, Yamaluru. Amount put to tender (in Lakhs) Exclusive of GST: 61.00, EMD (in Rs.): 1,22,000/-, Eligibility of Contractor and Category: Others.
6	Desilting of ward roads and engaging tipper and labour in ward no. 46, Yamaluru. Amount put to tender (in Lakhs) Exclusive of GST: 84.72, EMD (in Rs.): 85,000/-, Eligibility of Contractor and Category: ST.
7	Annual maintenance of footpath, desilting of drains and other allied works of arterial and sub-arterial roads in ward no. 47, Bellanduru. Amount put to tender (in Lakhs) Exclusive of GST: 127.09, EMD (in Rs.): 1,91,000/-, Eligibility of Contractor and Category: Others.
8	Desilting of ward roads and engaging tipper and labour in ward no. 47, Bellanduru. Amount put to tender (in Lakhs) Exclusive of GST: 55.04, EMD (in Rs.): 1,10,500/-, Eligibility of Contractor and Category: CAT-III(A).
9	Annual maintenance of footpath, desilting of drains and other allied works of arterial and sub-arterial roads in ward no. 48, Panathuru. Amount put to tender (in Lakhs) Exclusive of GST: 169.44, EMD (in Rs.): 2,54,500/-, Eligibility of Contractor and Category: Others.
10	Desilting of ward roads and engaging tipper and labour in ward no. 48, Panathuru. Amount put to tender (in Lakhs) Exclusive of GST: 101.62, EMD (in Rs.): 1,52,500/-, Eligibility of Contractor and Category: Others.
11	Annual maintenance of footpath, desilting of drains and other allied works of arterial and sub-arterial roads in ward no. 49, Doddakananahalli. Amount put to tender (in Lakhs) Exclusive of GST: 156.74, EMD (in Rs.): 2,35,500/-, Eligibility of Contractor and Category: Others.
12	Desilting of ward roads and engaging tipper and labour in ward no. 49, Doddakananahalli. Amount put to tender (in Lakhs) Exclusive of GST: 84.70, EMD (in Rs.): 1,69,500/-, Eligibility of Contractor and Category: Others.
13	Filling of potholes in ward no. 41, 45, 46, 47, 48 and 49. Amount put to tender (in Lakhs) Exclusive of GST: 135.58, EMD (in Rs.): 2,03,500/-, Eligibility of Contractor and Category: Others.
14	Annual maintenance of Marathahalli Division of Zone-01 storm water drain in Mahadevapura Constituency. Amount put to tender (in Lakhs) Exclusive of GST: 121.46, EMD (in Rs.): 1,82,500/-, Eligibility of Contractor and Category: Others.

Calendar of events: (1) Tender Documents may be downloaded from Government of Karnataka e-procurement website <https://kppp.karnataka.gov.in>. (2) Last date for submission of queries: 30.03.2026 within 11:00 a.m. (3) Date & time for pre bid meeting: 30.03.2026 at 4:00 p.m. (4) Last date & time for receipt of tenders: 04.04.2026 upto 4:00 p.m. (5) Date & time for opening of Technical bid: 06.04.2026 at 4:00 p.m. (6) Date & time for opening of Financial bid: 07.04.2026 at 4:00 p.m. Further details may be obtained from the above office during office hours or website <https://kppp.karnataka.gov.in>
Sd/- Executive Engineer, Marathahalli Division, BECC

OBITUARY & REMEMBRANCE

DEATH
S. THYAGARAJAN (85), RETIRED ASSOCIATE EDITOR (Sports), THE HINDU, Chennai passed away on 23- March -2026. Address 2, Krishna Avenue, C- V Raman Nagar, Alwarpet, Chennai-600018. Contact: 9884261077

DEATH
OBITUARY

Dr. PREMA RAJAGOPALAN
Asst. Professor (Retd.), IITM
Passed away on 23rd March 2026. Cremation 11:30 am, 24th March, Mylapore Crematorium
Survived by her grieving Sister Rama Rajagopalan
+91 98417 16673

DEATH
SAD DEMISE

K. Rangarajan
1928 - 2026
Retd PA to CMPE. (Rly.) Chrompet
Ph: 044 - 2223 4806

DEATH
SAD DEMISE

POLANI LEELADHARA RAO
Retd. Sr. Audit Officer, A.Gs Office (89 Years) Passed away on 23-03-2026, at 6:30 am.
With Love
Wife P. Indira Kumari
Sons & Daughter
P.S. Balaji Rao, D. Sudha Rani, P. Girija Sankara Rao, P. Venkata Krishna Rao
Ph: 9840044996

DEATH
SAD DEMISE

M. S. Soundararajan
M.Com., B.L., MBA., CAIIB
DOB: 28-4-1957 DOD: 14-3-2026
Advocate (Business & Corporate Laws)
Ex Officer Canara Bank - Circle Office
Subhasweekaram on 26/3/2026 (Thursday 11 to 1 pm)
Commemoration on 29/3/2026 (Sunday)
Deeply mourned by
Wife: Ultra Soundararajan
Daughter : Adv. Sona Priyadarshini Soundararajan
MOB : 94431 49068 82204 68318.

DEATH ANNIVERSARIES
11th ANNIVERSARY

Mr. D. CHANDRAMOHAN
Born on 09/04/1940 Died on 24/03/2015
Fondly Remembering & Continuing Our Journey with Your Blessings
Management, Employees of HYBRID AUTO CAST CHENNAI - 600 098.

DEATH ANNIVERSARIES
11th ANNIVERSARY

Mr. DURAISINGHAM CHANDRAMOHAN
FOUNDER
NIJALAJI
CONTRL. DEARS PVT. LTD
SRI DAYA ENGINEERING INDUSTRIES
Your presence continues to surround us.
In our heart you are always there
We miss you.
BHUVANESWARI CHANDRAMOHAN
CHANAKYA CHANDRAMOHAN
MALARVIZHI CHANAKYA
NANDHINI JAIKANTH
Family Members, Relatives
Management & Staff

DEATH ANNIVERSARIES
In Loving Memory of

K.B. NIRMAL KUMAR (A) RAMESH
Family Members & Baywoods, Chennai
24.03.2025

DEATH ANNIVERSARIES
Tenth Anniversary

S. RAJASEKAR
Loved beyond words and missed beyond measures
We miss you
Dr. Christilda Felicia (Wife)
Children and Grand Children

IN MEMORY OF YOUR LOVED ONES
To dedicate a space in this section, Please contact: 044-28576300 from 10.00 a.m. to 6.00 p.m.
Toll Free: 1800 102 4161 from 10.00 a.m. to 10.00 p.m.
For Placing Advertisements Online log on to www.thehinduads.com
DONATE EYES - GIFT SIGHT



सी.एस.आई.आर.मद्रास कॉम्प्लेक्स

CSIR MADRAS COMPLEX

सीएसआईआर रोड, सीएसआईआर परिसर, तरमंगि, चेन्नै

CSIR Road, CSIR Campus, Taramani, Chennai-600113.

CSIR-NML अधिसूचना सं. NOTIFICATION No.ML/01/2026

वॉक-इन-इंटरव्यू / Walk-in-Interview

पद / Position (s)	PAT-1 (Project Associate-I) - (1 No.) Junior Research Fellow (JRF) (1 No.)
पात्रता मानदंड और अन्य विवरण Eligibility Criteria and other details	Visit website www.csircmc.res.in and click on "careers"
साक्षात्कार की तिथि Date of Interview	09.04.2026

प्रशासनिक अधिकारी / ADMINISTRATIVE OFFICER



UJVN LIMITED

H.O.: "UJJWAL", Maharani Bagh, G.M.S. Road, Dehradun-248006

Telephone: 0135-2763808, Fax: 0135-2763508

CIN No. U40101UR2001SGC025866 Website: www.ujvn.com

Letter No: 233 **Date Extension Notice-03** Date: 23/03/2026

Due to unavoidable circumstances, due dates in respect of online Bid Identification Nos.: (i)T-04/EE(Solar)/2025-26 (ii)T-05/EE (Solar)/2025-26

(iii) T-06/EE(Solar)/2025-26 & (iv)T-07/EE(Solar)/2025-26 are as follows:

Last Date/Time of Receipt of bid on the portal : 28-03-2026 upto 16:00 Hrs.

Last Date/Time of submission of bid in Office : 30-03-2026 upto 12:00 Hrs.

Date of opening of the bid on website : 30-03-2026 from 13:00 Hrs.

All other details and terms & condition shall remain same. Detail of subsequent addendum/corrigendum/cancellation etc. may be obtained from the website.

Further details can be seen from the e-procurement portal <http://ukenders.gov.in>.

Executive Engineer (Solar)

"AVOID WASTEFUL USE OF ELECTRICITY"

CENTRAL RAILWAY

OPEN E-TENDER NOTICE

Open e-tender notice No.CR-DRM(W)BB-2026-14 of 18.03.2026.

Sr. No.1. Name of work: Kalyan yard: Proposed replacement, design, manufacturing, and supplying of existing non standard diamond crossing in KYN Yard. **Approximate Value:** Rs. 144.49 Lakhs, **EMD:** Rs. 2,22,300/-
Completion Period: 8 months. **Sr.No.2. Name of work:** Providing and fixing of land boundary post by released PSC unserviceable sleepers in Sr. DEN (East) BB Section. **Approximate Value:** Rs. 49.45 Lakhs, **EMD:** Rs. 98,900/-, **Completion Period:** 6 months. **Sr. No.3. Name of work:** Testing of welds as per Indian Railway Standard Specification for Ultra Sonic Testing of Rails/welds (provisional) revised 2022 as given by RDSO, in Mumbai Division for 2 years. **Approximate Value:** Rs. 441.81 Lakhs, **EMD:** Rs. 3,70,900/-, **Completion Period:** 24 months. **Sr. No.4. Name of work:** Misc. repairs of bridges by pointing, grouting, gunting, secur filling, side drain repairing, wing wall repairing, floor repairing, bridge numbering & Nalah training etc. under ADEN (West) PNVL. **Approximate Value:** Rs. 146.37 Lakhs, **EMD:** Rs. 2,23,200/-
Completion period: 12 months. **Sr.No.5. Name of work:** In-Situ Reconditioning of CMS Crossing using Robotic Welding Machine under Sr. DEN/SE section. **Approximate Value:** Rs. 136.80 Lakhs, **EMD:** Rs. 2,18,400/-, **Completion Period:** 12 months. **Sr.No.6. Name of work:** A). Schedule for the work of Miscellaneous P. Way work for SSE(Pway) NRL section under ADEN(T)KYN. B). NRL-MAE Schedule for the work of P.Way Miscellaneous work for SSE (P. Way) NG NRL-MAE section under ADEN T KYN. C). Hiring of mulcher with pcdain for clearing of cess grass, vegetation cutting/mulching trimming in KYN-KJT. & KJT-PNVL section under ADEN (Trael) KYN. **Approximate Value:** Rs. 366.53 Lakhs, **EMD:** Rs. 3,33,300/-, **Completion Period:** 12 months. **I). Tender closing date & time of aforesaid tender:** Up to 15:00 hrs. of Sr. No. 1 on 03.04.2026, Sr.No. 2, 5 and 6 on 10.04.2026, Sr.No. 3 on 07.04.2026 and Sr.No. 4 on 14.04.2026 to be opened after 15:00 hrs. **II).** The prospective tenderers are requested to visit the website www.ireps.gov.in for details of tenders & corrigendum, if any. **III).** Tenderer may participate in above e-tender electronically through website www.ireps.gov.in only & submission of manual offers against e-tender are not allowed. Manually, if submitted shall neither be opened nor considered. **IV).** The Bid Security shall be deposited either in cash through e-payment gateway or submitted as Bank Guarantee bond from a scheduled commercial bank of India or as mentioned in tender documents. **V)** For further enquiry, may contact: Divisional Railway Manager (Works) Office, Central Railway on phone. 022-67455323. **VI)** This tender complies with Public Procurement Policy Order 2017 dated 16.9.2017. Complete details of tenders are available at the website "www.ireps.gov.in". The complete details of tenders are also available in the "**Notice Board**" of the Divisional Railway Manager (Works) Office, Mumbai CSMT. **DE-1005**

TRAVEL SAFELY, AVOID FOOTBOARD TRAVELLING



INDIAN INSTITUTE OF SCIENCE

Bangalore - 560012

Corrigendum to Advertisement No. R(HR) 308-2026/1 dated 20/02/2026 for the post of Registrar

It is hereby notified that the last date for submission of application for the post of Registrar is hereby **extended till 04.04.2026.**

The eligibility criteria and other terms and conditions remain the same.

Date: 21.03.2026

**Sd/-,
REGISTRAR**

Your feedback will keep us Cleaner, Sharper and Bolder

Call our toll-free number
1800 102 1878

Or write to us at
customercare@thehindu.co.in



THE  **HINDU**  **businessline.**

FRONTLINE SPORTSTAR You@world THE HINDU

BUSINESS CONNECT

A Business Initiative

GRT's Swarna Ugadi Offers



GRT Jewellers, a trusted name since 1964, celebrates Ugadi with its 'Swarna Ugadi' campaign, marking new beginnings with festive offers across South India. Customers can enjoy Rs. 250 off per gram on gold jewellery purchases, Rs. 100 extra on old gold exchange, 12.5 percent off on diamond value (excluding solitaires), 25 percent off on silver wastage, and 10 percent off on silver jewellery MRP. Mr. G.R. 'Anand' Ananthapadmanabhan said: "We are delighted to present our Swarna Ugadi campaign to our valued customers." Mr. G.R. Radhakrishnan, Managing Director, further added: "We invite everyone to celebrate this Ugadi as a 'Swarna Ugadi' with us and welcome prosperity into their homes.

Girias Expands Across Tamil Nadu



Girias, a leading consumer durable retailer since 1971, continues its growth with the launch of multiple multi-brand showrooms across Tamil Nadu, reinforcing its position as "South India's No.1 Consumer Durable Retailer." Known for customer-centric service, flexible payment options, and a wide product range, the brand aims to make appliance shopping seamless and rewarding. The brand recently opened new showrooms in Sankarankovil, Kattur (Trichy), and Vysarpadi (Chennai), with special inaugural offers including 20 percent cashback on credit card EMI, zero charges, assured free gifts, exchange benefits up to Rs. 25,000, and up to Rs. 31,000 cashback on finance purchases. Customers can also enjoy zero percent interest, extended EMI options, holiday packages on AC purchases, and complimentary gold and silver coins.

Revivo Launches Wellness Programs



Revivo Clinic for Metabolic Health, Alwarpet, has launched Mental Health Counselling and a Sleep Reset Program, expanding its care for obesity, Type 2 diabetes, and related conditions. The counselling program addresses stress, anxiety, and emotional eating, helping patients build resilience without medication. The Sleep Reset Program focuses on improving sleep quality for issues like sleep apnea and disrupted patterns without pharmacological dependency. Founded by Dr. Arun Raghavan and Arvind Ashok, Revivo integrates these with its medical, nutrition, and fitness services. The founders noted, "When we align the mind, sleep, movement, and nutrition under one roof, we give our patients the most complete path to lasting recovery."

VIT Signs MOU With CMC



Vellore Institute of Technology (VIT) and Christian Medical College (CMC), Vellore, have signed a Memorandum of Understanding to advance collaborative research in healthcare. The agreement was signed at the CMC campus by Dr. Solomon Sathishkumar and Dr. T. Jayabharathi in the presence of Chancellor Dr. G. Viswanathan. "This partnership honors CMC's legacy of 'firsts' by looking toward the future of medical science," said Dr. Viswanathan. Dr. Sathishkumar added, "Integrating VIT's technical capabilities with our clinical environment will enable superior healthcare solutions." The collaboration will focus on fostering affordable and cutting-edge advancements in patient care.

Pothys Old Gold Exchange Mela



Pothys Swarna Mahal has announced its Old Gold Exchange Mela across all branches in Tamil Nadu and Kerala, including key outlets in Chennai, Tirunelveli, Tiruchirappalli, Coimbatore, Salem, and Thiruvananthapuram, valid until March 31. Customers can exchange old gold jewellery for new BIS HUID-half-marked designs and avail an additional Rs. 300 per gram. Old diamond jewellery can also be exchanged for new 100 percent natural diamond pieces at attractive values. "At a time when gold prices are reaching new highs, this Old Gold Exchange Mela is a great opportunity for customers to make use of unused jewellery or old gold coins," said Sadaiyandi Ramesh, Director.

Dr. A.V. Anoop Wins Lifetime Award



Dr. A.V. Anoop, Managing Director of AVA Group of Companies, was honoured with the MV Lifetime Achievement Award at MVCON 2026, held in Chennai. The prestigious recognition celebrates his enduring contributions and commitment to excellence in the healthcare sector. MVCON, a leading medical conference, brings together eminent doctors, researchers and healthcare professionals to exchange insights on advancements in diabetes care, research and clinical practices. Dr. Anoop received the award in the presence of distinguished members of the medical fraternity and delegates from across the country, marking a significant moment at the conference and underscoring his impactful role in supporting healthcare initiatives and innovation.



समाहरणालय, नवादा
(मद्य निषेध एवं उत्पाद विभाग)
अल्पकालीन आम नीलामी सूचना

एतद् द्वारा सर्वसाधारण को सूचित किया जाता है कि नवादा जिलान्तर्गत विभिन्न थाना काण्डों / उत्पादवादों में राज्यसात किये गये निम्नलिखित वाहनों को बिहार मद्य निषेध एवं उत्पाद अधिनियम, 2016 के सुसंगत प्राक्धानों के तहत आम नीलामी (Public Auction) दिनांक **07.04.2026** को समाहरणालय, नवादा में 11:00 बजे पूर्वाह्न से की जायेगी। नीलामी योग्य वाहनों की सूची निम्नवत है :-

क्र. सं.	लॉट सं०	थाना का नाम	थाना काण्ड संख्या	वाहन का प्रकार	निबंधन संख्या	निबंधन का वर्ष	इंजन संख्या	चेचिस संख्या	मूल्यांकित राशि	अग्रघन की राशि	वाहन की अवस्थिति	वाहन मालिक का विवरणी
1	36	गोविन्दपुर	D.R.No-1036(A)/23	TVS STAR CITY BIKE	TN28AJ /4511	3/7/2011	AF1BB13 74474	MD625NF19 B1B35588	4500.00	1200.00	गोविन्दपुर थाना	मनोहर पासवान, पिला-आनंदी पासवान, सा०-103 टैंक स्ट्रीट, मशरूम कोवील स्ट्रीट, सोवर्णपल्लम, जिला-कोयम्बटूर, तमिलनाडु, पिन-641028

1. विशेष जानकारी के लिए कार्यालय अधीक्षक मद्य निषेध, नवादा से सम्पर्क किया जा सकता है nawada.bih.nic.in पर देखा जा सकता है।

(कृते समाहर्ता, नवादा)
अधीक्षक मद्यनिषेध, नवादा

उक्त सूचना www.state.bihar.gov.in/prdbihar पर भी देखी जा सकती है।

PR. No. 27042 (Excise) 25-26

बिहार में शराब का व्यापार, विक्री एवं सेवन अथेद्य है। इससे संबंधित शिकायत इस नंबर पर दर्ज करायें, आपकी जानकारी गुप्त रखी जाएगी।
टॉल फ्री नं- 15545 या 1800 345 6268



HON'BLE SUPREME COURT MONITORED HOUSING PROJECTS THROUGH LD. COURT RECEIVER

Executed by NBCC (India) Limited



Bulk Sale of inventory through e-Auction

Aspire Silicon City
Ph-IV, Sec-76, Noida, UP

- 4BHK & Duplex Spacious Apartments with modern amenities.
- Near Spectrum Mall, Noida
- Nearest metro stations are Noida Sec-50 (Aqua Line) & Sec-76 Metro and Anand Vihar ISBT & Railway Station-25 min.

Aspire Leisure Valley
Techzone-IV, Greater Noida (W), UP

- Inventory-3BHK & 4BHK spacious apartments with modern amenities.
- Near D-Mart and Anand Vihar ISBT & Railway Station-35 min.

Aspire Leisure Park
Techzone-IV, Greater Noida (W), UP

- Inventory-3BHK & 4BHK spacious apartments with modern amenities.
- Near D-Mart and Anand Vihar ISBT & Railway Station-30 Min.

Aspire Centurian Park
Techzone-IV, Greater Noida (W), UP

- Inventory-3BHK & 4BHK spacious apartments with modern amenities.
- Near D-Mart and Anand Vihar ISBT & Railway Station-30 min.

Last date of submission of EMD: 27.03.2026

E-auction will be held on: 28.03.2026

EMD Rs.9.70 Cr. to Rs. 20.90 Cr.

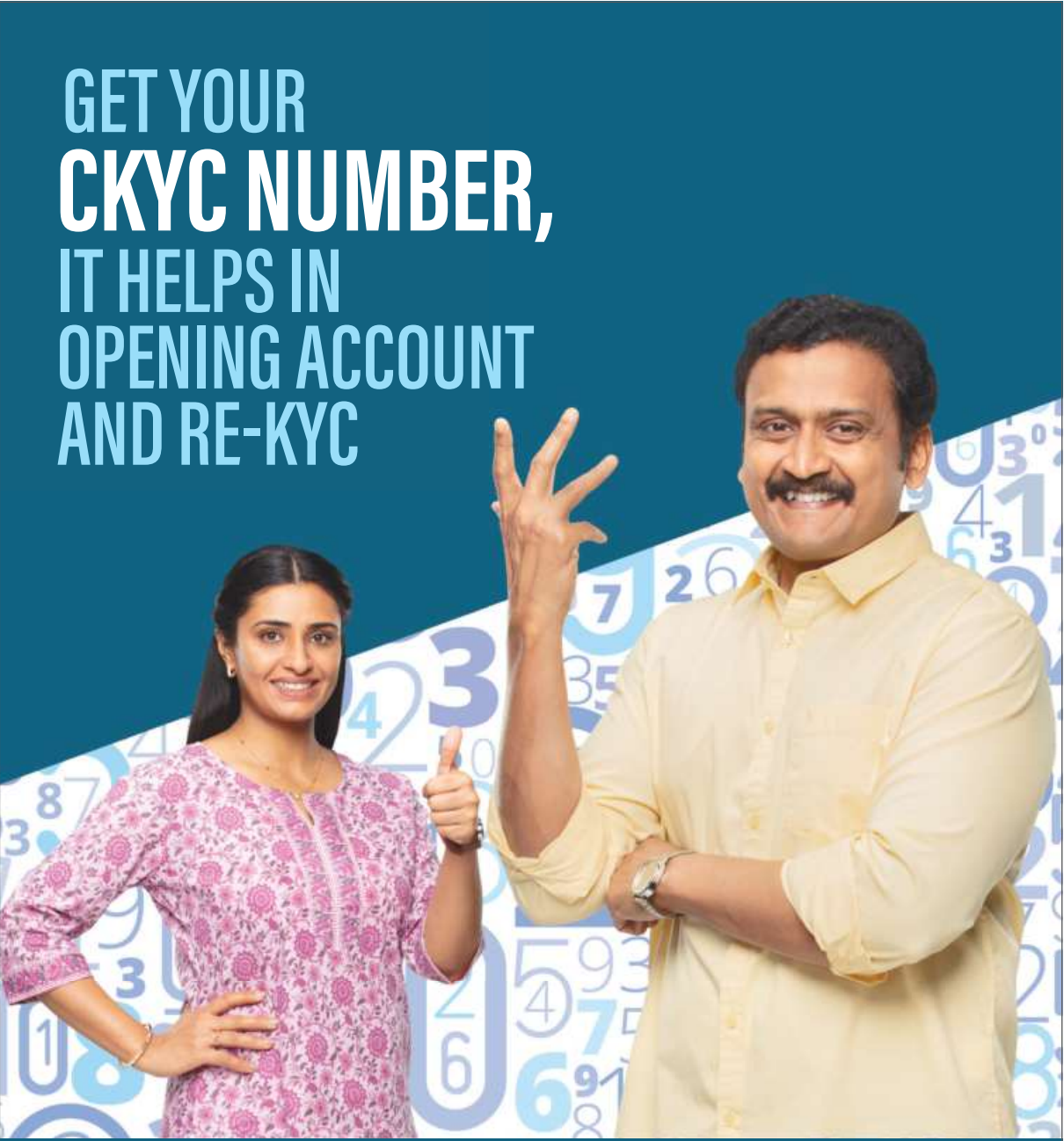
6 Packages Ranging from Rs. 485 Cr. to Rs. 1,045 Cr.

For more details, please visit our website: www.nbccindia.in | www.receiveramrapali.in
Or 📞: 9772907414

Please scan this QR for e-auction document



GET YOUR CKYC NUMBER, IT HELPS IN OPENING ACCOUNT AND RE-KYC



How it works:

- Banks capture and upload customers' KYC information onto the Central KYC Records Registry (CKYCR)
- A 14-digit number is assigned to the customer
- This 14-digit number can be used by other financial institutions to retrieve the customer's existing KYC records for opening an account and Re-KYC

To get your CKYC number:

Contact your Bank OR Give a missed call on 7799022129 OR Visit <https://ckycindia.in>



Issued in public interest by

भारतीय रिजर्व बैंक

RESERVE BANK OF INDIA

www.rbi.org.in



RBI Kehta Hai...

Jaankaar Baniye, Satark Rahiye!





For more information, visit <https://rbikehtahai.rbi.org.in/CKYCR>

Official WhatsApp Nos. 99990 41935 / 99309 91935



A CH-CE

A CH-CHE

INBRIEF



Wayanad to get extra ₹10 cr. from Karnataka government

Ahead of the elections to the Kerala Assembly, the Congress government in Karnataka is set to provide an additional grant of ₹10 crore for the rehabilitation of families affected by the landslide in Meppadi of Wayanad district in July 2024. A provision in this regard has been made in the supplementary estimates of 2025-26 (third and final instalment), tabled in the Karnataka Legislative Assembly on Monday. The supplementary estimates of 2025-26 aggregate to ₹14,767.89 crore.

Kerala High Court stays order disqualifying Yogam leaders

A Division Bench of the Kerala High Court on Monday stayed an order passed by a single judge of the court on March 12 that disqualified general secretary of SNDP Yogam Vellappally Natesan and other office-bearers from their posts in the organisation for failing to file audited accounts for three consecutive years and not having the director identification number issued by the Kerala government. The Division Bench was hearing appeals filed by Mr. Natesan, his son Tushar Vellappally, vice-president of the Yogam, and a few other directors of the organisation challenging the single judge order. The HC on March 16 ordered status quo on the order.

SC restores FIR against IAS officer in 2022 bribery case

The Supreme Court has restored an FIR against IAS officer J. Manjunath in an alleged bribery case, when he was serving as Deputy Commissioner (DC) of Bengaluru Urban in 2022. Now the Lokayukta police can continue the investigation, which was initiated by the erstwhile Anti-Corruption Bureau. The order set aside two separate judgments of the Karnataka HC, which in 2023 quashed the FIR against Mr. Manjunath and Mahesh P.S, a deputy tahsildar working as his Personal Assistant (PA) to the DC. The High Court, while quashing the FIR against Mr. Manjunath in September 2023, had said that “there is neither circumstantial nor direct evidence to substantiate that Mr. Manjunath demanded bribe through other two accused”.

SOUTHERN RAILWAY						
Chennai Division						
E-Auction Notice / Catering / Passenger Amenities / NFR / Parking / E-Auction / 2026						
For and on behalf of the President of India, the Divisional Railway Manager, Chennai Division, Southern Railway calls for bids (commercial) through E-Auction and E-tender for award of Catering stall contracts and Passenger Amenities, NFR and Parking contracts in the following Railway Stations / Locations. The 'E'-Auctions and E-tenders scheduled are as detailed below:						
Sl. No.	Catalogue No.	Sub Category	Location	Auction Date	Tendering Mode	Auction Time
1	MAS-EMR-2026	Emergency Medical Room	TBM	01.04.2026	E-auction	15:00
2	MAS-EMR-2026	Emergency Medical Room	KPD	01.04.2026	E-auction	15:00
3	MAS-EMR-2026	Emergency Medical Room	CGL	01.04.2026	E-auction	15:00
4	MAS-EMR-2026	Emergency Medical Room	MS	01.04.2026	E-auction	15:00
5	MAS-PAUT-177	Pay & Use Toilet	CGL	07.04.2026	E-auction	15:00
6	MAS-PAUT-177	Pay & Use Toilet	MLMR	07.04.2026	E-auction	15:00
7	MAS-BOC-31	Battery Operated Carts	CGL	07.04.2026	E-auction	15:00
8	MAS-BOC-31	Battery Operated Carts	TBM	07.04.2026	E-auction	15:00
9	MAS-MPS-2026-2	Multi-purpose stall	KPD	31.03.2026	E-auction	15:00
10	MAS-MPS-2026-2	Multi-purpose stall	KPD	31.03.2026	E-auction	15:00
11	MAS-MPS-2026-2	Multi-purpose stall	TBM	31.03.2026	E-auction	15:00
12	MAS-MPS-2026-2	Multi-purpose stall	PER	31.03.2026	E-auction	15:00
13	MAS-WVM-CGL	Water Vending Machine	CGL Cluster (15 locations at 10 stations)	31.03.2026	E-auction	15:00
14	Tender No. 26008	Catering stall / General Minor Unit	CGL	10.04.2026	E-Tender	15:00
15	Tender No. 25009	Catering stall / General Minor Unit	PON	10.04.2026	E-Tender	15:00
16	NFR-BSS-VLK	Battery Swapping Stations	VLK	30.03.2026	E-auction	15:30
17	NFR-MAS-GZ-2026	Gaming Zone	MAS	06.04.2026	E-auction	15:30
18	NFR-MAS-BR-26	Supply of sanitized quality bedroll services	16159/160, 12695/696 & 22639/640, 12671/672 & 12685/686	06.04.2026	E-auction	15:30
19	MAS-PARKING-26	Two Wheeler Parking	KVP	06.04.2026	E-auction	15:00
20	MAS-PARKING-26	Two Wheeler Parking	GI	06.04.2026	E-auction	15:00
21	MAS-PARKING-26	Mixed Parking	VLKY Part C and D	06.04.2026	E-auction	15:00

All other details can be viewed in the website - www.ireps.gov.in.
Senior Divisional Commercial Manager / Chennai

Kerala Assembly polls: 1,202 candidates file nominations

Final picture will emerge after scrutiny of nomination papers today and the last date of withdrawal on Thursday; over one lakh complaints have been filed on model code violations

The Hindu Bureau
THIRUVANANTHAPURAM

Election officials here said that 1,202 candidates have filed nomination papers for the April 9 Assembly polls in the State when the deadline for submitting them ended at 3 p.m. on Monday. In all, 2,039 forms have been filed, counting multiple forms submitted by some of the candidates. A final picture on candidates will emerge after the scrutiny of the nomination papers on Tuesday and the March 26 deadline for the withdrawal of candidature. There were 957 candi-



Friendly fight: BJP's Karamana Jayan and LDF's Sudheer Karamana greet each other in the Kerala capital. NIRMAL HARINDRAN

dates in the fray in the 140 constituencies for the 2021 elections in Kerala. As many as 1,39,799 complaints have been filed regarding Model Code of Conduct violations till March 22. Procedures related to the processing of an appli-

BJP seal on EC letter sparks row in Kerala

The Hindu Bureau
THIRUVANANTHAPURAM

The presence of a seal of the BJP Kerala unit on a 2019 Election Commission of India (EC) letter on poll-related guidelines, which was distributed to political parties recently, sparked a row in the State on Monday, the final day for submitting nominations for the April 9 Assembly polls. While the ruling CPI(M) alleged that “seals are being casually swapped” and questioned whether “all pretences” have been dropped by the BJP, Chief Electoral Officer (Kerala) (CEO) Rathan U. Kelkar at-



An Election Commission letter bearing the BJP seal that was shared by the CPI(M) on X.

tributed the issue to a “clerical error” and added that corrective measures had been taken. The CPI(M) had shared on its X handle a copy of a March 19, 2019, Election

Commission letter bearing the BJP seal. The letter, to CEOs of All States and Union Territories ahead of the 2019 Lok Sabha polls, dealt with the EC guidelines on the publicity of criminal antecedents by political parties and candidates. Copies of the letter had been issued afresh to political parties by mistake, according to the CEO's office.

Clerical error, says CEO The CEO issued a clarification attributing the episode to a clerical error and asking everyone to avoid spreading the “wrong message.” According to him, the

ation and adding the name to the electoral roll take up to 10 days. Therefore, only those applications filed on or before March 15 would be treated as eligible for the upcoming Assembly polls, Chief Electoral Officer (CEO) Rathan U. Kelkar said. Speaking at the release of ‘Vottarivu,’ an election booklet published by the Thiruvananthapuram unit of the Press Information Bureau, Mr. Kelkar sought the cooperation of voters to ensure the highest turnout in Kerala's electoral history. The aim is to cross the 85% voter turnout mark this time, he said.

BJP Kerala unit had visited the CEO's office seeking clarification on the EC guidelines.

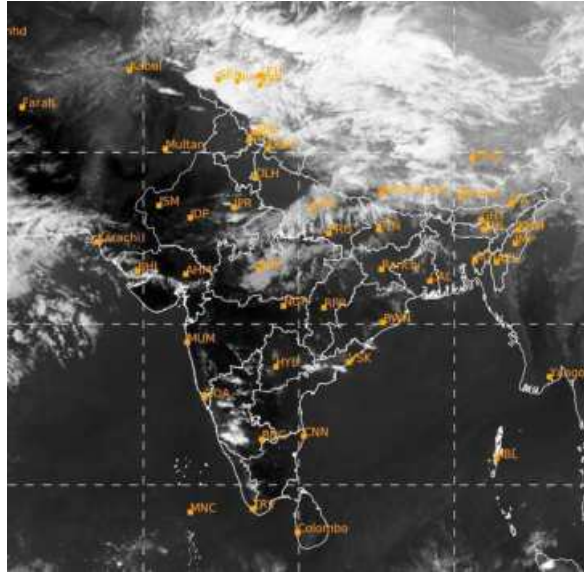
The party seal was on a copy of the EC letter submitted along with the application seeking the clarification.

“The old letter was distributed to political parties due to an oversight,” Mr. Kelkar said.

Once the error was noticed by the CEO's office, all political parties, district election officers, and returning officers were told in writing that the letter was being withdrawn and it should be disregarded, he said.

WEATHERWATCH

Rainfall, temperature & air quality in select metros yesterday



Forecast for Tuesday: Heavy rainfall likely at isolated places over Arunachal Pradesh, Assam, Meghalaya, Sikkim and West Bengal. Thunderstorm with lightning/gusty winds likely at isolated places over Nagaland, Mizoram, Tripura, Andhra Pradesh and Karnataka. Hot and humid weather likely at isolated places over Kerala and Mahe

CITY	RAIN	MAX	MIN	CITY	RAIN	MAX	MIN
Agartala		29.4	17.4	Kozhikode		36.0	27.4
Ahmedabad		36.5	23.6	Kurnool		38.5	25.2
Aizawl		27.2	14.4	Lucknow		31.2	17.4
Allahabad		34.6	16.8	Madurai		38.0	25.5
Bengaluru	0.8	32.9	22.8	Mangaluru		34.0	24.6
Bhopal		33.0	17.0	Mumbai		36.5	21.6
Bhubaneswar		35.8	21.5	Mysuru		33.4	18.8
Chandigarh		29.7	15.0	New Delhi	1.4	29.7	17.8
Chennai		34.4	25.2	Patna		32.0	20.5
Coimbatore		35.4	23.6	Port Blair		32.5	25.2
Dehradun		27.9	14.8	Puducherry		32.7	24.3
Gangtok	19	15.6	9.2	Pune		38.4	21.8
Goa		33.5	24.4	Raipur		35.2	21.6
Guwahati		1	19.5	Ranchi		29.9	14.0
Hubballi		37.0	22.0	Shillong		17.2	9.3
Hyderabad		34.6	24.0	Shimla		21.2	9.5
Imphal		25.1	15.1	Srinagar		19.1	5.5
Jaipur	0.6	28.5	19.2	Thiruvananthapuram	15	33.1	25.5
Kochi		32.6	26.8	Tiruchi		35.5	24.6
Kohima	6	15.3	10.8	Vijayawada		35.8	23.8
Kolkata		32.5	20.0	Visakhapatnam		33.4	25.2

Pollutants in the air you are breathing							Yesterday
CITIES	SO ₂	NO	CO	PM2.5	PM10	CODE	
Ahmedabad		92		67		19	
Bengaluru		13		59		35	
Chennai		16		10		25	
Delhi		16		112		84	
Hyderabad		3		17		4	
Kolkata		19		40		58	
Lucknow		10		35		48	
Mumbai		32		100		41	
Pune		52		26		177	
Visakhapatnam		33		22		38	

(Rainfall data in mm; temperature in Celsius)
Air Quality Code: Poor Moderate Good (Readings indicate average AQI)
SO₂: Sulphur Dioxide. Short-term exposure can harm the respiratory system, making breathing difficult. It can affect visibility by reacting with other air particles to form haze and stain culturally important objects such as statues and monuments.
NO_x: Nitrogen Dioxide. Aggravates respiratory illness, causes haze to form by reacting with other air particles, causes acid rain, pollutes coastal waters.
CO: Carbon monoxide. High concentration in air reduces oxygen supply to critical organs like the heart and brain. At very high levels, it can cause dizziness, confusion, unconsciousness and even death.
PM2.5 & PM10: Particulate matter pollution can cause irritation of the eyes, nose and throat, coughing, chest tightness and shortness of breath, reduced lung function, irregular heartbeat, asthma attacks, heart attacks and premature death in people with heart or lung disease

कार्यपालक अभियंता का कार्यालय,
ग्रामीण कार्य विभाग, कार्य प्रमण्डल, चतरा
शुद्धि-पत्र

ग्रामीण कार्य विभाग, कार्य प्रमण्डल, चतरा के अन्तर्गत जिला खनिज फाउण्डेशन ट्रस्ट (DMFT) मद के तहत ई-अल्पकालीन निविदा संख्या- 13/2025-26/RWD/CHATRA, दिनांक-16.02.2026 (Construction of Road from House of Prem Bhuiyan to Teli Tola via Banjari Tola), शुद्धि-पत्र के अनुसार निविदा प्राप्ति की अंतिम तिथि - 30.03.2026 है, जिसका P.R. No. 374426 Rural Work Department(25-26):D है, उसमें निम्नलिखित संशोधन किया जाता है:-

1. वेबसाइट में निविदा प्रकाशन की तिथि - 02.04.2026
2. ई-निविदा प्राप्ति की अंतिम तिथि एवं समय - 16.04.2026 अपराह्न 5.00 बजे तक।
3. ई-निविदा खोलने की तिथि एवं समय - 18.04.2026 अपराह्न 03.30 बजे।
4. अन्य शर्तें यथावत् रहेंगी।

विस्तृत जानकारी के लिए वेबसाइट www.jharkhandtenders.gov.in में देखा जा सकता है।

कार्यपालक अभियंता,
ग्रामीण कार्य विभाग, कार्य प्रमण्डल, चतरा।
PR.NO.375809 Rural Work Department(25-26):D

NORTH WESTERN RAILWAY

SURVEY & CONSTRUCTION
(No. JU/Const./74-W-15/2025-26/
BOKT/MTS/SDPH-II, Dated: 21.03.2026)
1 CORRIGENDUM TO THE E-TENDER NOTICE
T.NO. JU/Const/74-04-2025-26-BOKT-
PH-II, dated 07.03.2026

In the aforesaid e-tender, the following changes have been made- (1) The Advance Correction Slip (ACS-11) to the Indian Railway General Condition of Contract-2022 has been incorporated in the said tender and the same has been placed on IREPS. (2) The correct total of scheduled 'A' (DSR-2023) is ₹ 37,72,70,086.85, whereas the total of Schedule 'A' (DSR-2023) shown under the breakup in the published NIT, i.e., ₹37,72,50,060.35, may be treated as incorrect. All other particulars of the original Tender Notice will remain same.

Dy. Chief Engineer (Const.)-I
414-DK/26 North Western Railway, Jodhpur

TIRUMALA TIRUPATI DEVASTHANAMS - TIRUPATI
EXECUTIVE ENGINEER -VII e-AUCTION NOTICE

TTD is disposing scrap materials (Iron scrap, Teak wood, plastic, Stainless Steel, Assorted Coir beds and pillows etc., available in the DPW Stores Civil, ITD, Tirupati through E-Auction (Online) to be held on 04-04-2026, 2.00 PM to 5.00 PM on e- KONUGOLU Portal, Govt. of A.P. The registered bidders in "Konugolu" are eligible to participate in the Auction. Further details please log on to <https://konugolu.ap.gov.in> or www.tirumala.org or contact No.7702510006/9701391777

TTD-40021/ 10/2025-PRO SEC(Adv.No.443) Date:23-03-2026 EXECUTIVE OFFICER

BENGALURU WEST CITY CORPORATION
Malleshwaram Zone,
Office of the Executive Engineer, Special Division,
BWCC Building, No.161, 2nd Floor, 19th Main, 2nd Block,
Near Old Navarang Bus Stop, Rajajinagara, Bengaluru - 560010.

No: BWCC/EE/SPL/TEND/05/2025-26 Date: 23-03-2026

INVITATION FOR TENDER (IFT)
(Two Cover System) (Through GOK KPP Portal only)

The Executive Engineer, Special Division, BWCC, Bengaluru invites Tenders from the registered Service Provider / Contractors of GBA - BWCC or equivalent registration with CPWD / KPWD / Railways / MES or any State Government Organizations for the Services detailed below.

Sl. No.	Name of the Work
1	Establishing Control Room in Malleshwaram Zone-2 (Supplying Man Power and Other Equipments) for 12 Months. Amount Put to Tender (Excluding GST) (Rs. in Lakhs): 112.85, EMD Amount (in Rs.): 2,00,000/-

Calendar of Events: 1) Tender documents may be downloaded from the GOK Karnataka Public Procurement Portal Website: <https://kppp.karnataka.gov.in> from 24-03-2026, 17.30 Hours onwards. 2) Last Date for Receipt of Queries: 30-03-2026 upto 16.00 Hours. 3) Pre Bid Meeting will be held on 30-03-2026 at 16.00 Hours in the Office of the Executive Engineer (Special Division), Malleshwaram Zone-2. 4) Last Date and Time for Uploading the Tender Documents: 04-04-2026 upto 16.00 Hours. 5) Date of Opening of Technical Bid: 06-04-2026 at 16.30 Hours. 6) Date of Opening of Financial Bid: Will be intimated to the Technically Qualified Bidders. Further details can be had from the above office.

Sd/- Executive Engineer
Special Division, Malleshwaram Zone, BWCC.

SOUTH WESTERN RAILWAY

Publication of Tender Notice No.
CAO/CN/BNC/177/2026 Dated: 16-03-2026

The undersigned, on behalf of the President of India, Invites E-Tenders for the following work:

Item of work	Approx. Value
Conducting Final location survey for New line between Shivamogga - Sringeri Mangaluru (332 km), Talguppa-Honnavar (95 km), Alamtili -Yadgiri (162 km) and Bhadravathi - Chiklajur (73 km). (Tender Ref. No: SWR-FLS-RATE-CONTRACT-03R)	Rs. 33,52,62,608/-

Last date for submission of bids: Upto 15:00 Hrs. on 09-04-2026

For details log on: www.ireps.gov.in

Deputy Chief Engineer/Construction/Works
Bengaluru Cantonment
PUB/1013/AAF/PRB/SWR/2025-26

Download the RailOne app. RailOne is the all-in-one railway app by Indian Railways. Passengers can book reserved tickets, unreserved tickets, platform tickets, and season passes, check PNR status, order food, and access many more services at their fingertips. Use digital payment to book unreserved tickets through RailOne app, and enjoy up to a 3% discount.

South Western Railway - SWR SWRPR SWRALWHR @ sw_railway

THE HINDU

Air Surcharge as applicable:
New Delhi - Rs. 15/-
Port Blair - Rs. 20/-

Centre For Railway Information Systems
Chanakyapuri, New Delhi-110021

Tender No.: 01265077
Tender Title.: Procurement of Subscriptions for Red Hat Virtualization (Premium) for UTS.
Date of Closing: 09.04.2026 (Thursday) 15:30 hrs.
Tender Documents may be downloaded from Website www.ireps.gov.in. For future modification/extensions pl. see www.ireps.gov.in.

NOTICE DOCUMENT MISSING

Notice is hereby given that as per information given by my client that the property comprised in Survey Nos. 42/6A & 42/7B to an extent of 3.35 Acres & 1.15 Acres respectively, totally 4.50 Acres, situated at Oragadam Village, then Sriperumbudur Taluk, Now Kundrathur Taluk, Kanchi cheppuram District belongs to 1) Mrs. Uma Maheshwari Srinivasan, 2) Mrs. M. Megala Devi 3) Mrs. M. Pushpakanthi 4) Mrs. Anita Krishnan 5) Mrs. C.P. Subbalakshmi. Whereas the (1) Settlement deed in Doc.No.693 of 1962, dated 14.03.1962, registered at SRO- Walajabad (2) Settlement deed in Doc.No.1793 of 1974, dated 27.06.1970, registered at SRO- Walajabad (3) Mortgage deed in Doc.No.1794 of 1974, dated 26.06.1974, registered at SRO- Walajabad, (4) Sale deed in Doc.No. 988 of 1970 dated 04.05.1970, at SRO- Walajabad are mislabeled by my client and not traceable. If any person/persons finds the above mentioned original documents pertaining to the above said properties, they are requested to hand over the said documents within 15 days from the date of publication of this notice to the below Address, failing which, it will be presumed that the documents have been irretrievably lost.

S. SAKTHIVEL,
Advocate & Notary Public
No.63, Ambattur-Vanagaram Road
Ambttur Kuppam, Chennai - 600058
Cell.No. 9841183351

Place: Chennai
Date: 24-03-2026

THE HINDU PRESENTS SCHOOL BUZZ

A Newspaper exclusively curated for School Students

LEADERSHIP AWARD

Olive Tree Group of Schools Correspondent Dr. Joy Leena Isaac was awarded 'Inspirational Leader in Education' by Global Educators Crew for exceptional dedication, creativity and transformative contributions to Early Years Education.

KINDERGARTEN ANNUAL DAY CELEBRATED

Dayasadan Agarwal Vidyalaya celebrated their Kindergarten Annual Day and Convocation with pride. Chief Guest Ms. Vijayalakshmi Seshan and Guest of Honour Ms. Archana Yedanapalli attended the programme. It was held in the presence of President Shri Gopalji Agrawal, Correspondent Shri B. P. Jhunjhunwala, Cultural Secretary Smt. Shilpa Tulsian and Principal Smt. Latha B. The ceremony included prayer, lamp lighting and Annual Report presentation. UKG students received certificates, while Ms. V. Pranitha was felicitated. Cultural performances added vibrancy, and the programme concluded with appreciation from the management and the National Anthem.

STEM CHALLENGE WINNERS

Babaji Vidhyashram emerged winners at the British Council and Formula 1 All India STEM Future Challenge, securing the top prize among 200 schools nationwide. Collaborating with partner school Ysgol Gyfun Gymraeg Llangynwyd, Wales, students addressed global safety concerns. Their innovation, a discreet 3D-printed butterfly-shaped "Safety Pendant", provides instant help during emergencies. Programmed using Arduino and linked via Bluetooth to a custom app, it activates a blinding beam, alerts emergency contacts and shares live location. By integrating STEM concepts, the team developed an accessible life-saving wearable, marking a significant achievement for the school.

For Subscription related queries, please contact Subramaniam P:
Handphone:+91 98408 98088 | Email: subramaniam.p@thehindu.co.in



Battle of Bengal

The TMC is fighting off anti-incumbency sentiment

The West Bengal Assembly election, to be held in two phases on April 23 and 29, is shaping up as a two-party race between the incumbent All India Trinamool Congress (TMC) and the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP). The Left and the Congress have been pushed to the margins in the intense combat. The Bharatiya Gorkha Prajatantrik Morcha (BGPM) is contesting the three Darjeeling hill seats as an ally of the TMC. The TMC, which has been in power for three terms, has replaced 74 sitting Members of the Legislative Assembly to deflect anti-incumbency and bring in fresh faces to the field. In 2021, the TMC won 215 seats with a 48.02% vote share while the BJP secured 77 seats with 38%, a sharp rise from when it bagged just three seats and a 10.2% vote share in 2016. Chief Minister and TMC leader Mamata Banerjee is facing off against Leader of the Opposition Suwendu Adhikari, from the BJP, in Bhabanipur, where she is the sitting MLA. In 2021, she had lost to Mr. Adhikari in Nandigram by a margin of 1,956 votes, even while the TMC won yet another term. The run-up to the election in 2026 has been marred by controversies around the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of the voter list. West Bengal's final electoral roll, which was published on February 28, saw the electorate shrink from 7.66 crore to 7.04 crore, with over 62 lakh names deleted. A further 60 lakh names remain under adjudication even as campaigning is underway, creating unprecedented uncertainty.

The standoff over SIR has overshadowed other debates. Having been in power for three terms, there is much that the TMC should be held accountable for, but SIR turned out to be a gift for Ms. Banerjee, which she has used to amplify her charges against the BJP that it is a party hostile to West Bengal and its voters. The BJP began 2026 with a reasonable case in its favour – the rape and murder of a trainee doctor in Kolkata, in 2024, had shaken public confidence in the Mamata government. But the party's limitations – and even refusal – to negotiate the cultural and linguistic diversity of India are markedly visible in the State, and it is placing its hopes on the trimmed voter list and the manoeuvrability of the electoral process. Its State unit is a house divided, while the TMC appears to have consolidated itself further, with Ms. Banerjee and her nephew Abhishek firmly in command. The BJP's upward trajectory may have hit the ceiling. The Congress is contesting without any alliances. The Left is not a power contender, but its vote share in select seats could influence margins in a tight race. In a long campaign period, there may be some surprises in store in West Bengal, as the BJP and the TMC both fight a battle for survival.

Grim future

India's economic fundamentals need a realistic reassessment

The economy has recently been yielding some discomfiting data, even before the war in West Asia began. The most recent of these was the February 2026 data on the Index of Eight Core Industries. This release showed that growth in the overall Index had dropped to a three-month low in February, half the rate of what it saw in January. This was not a case of a high base effect, either, with growth in February 2025 having been just 3.4%. The sector-wise data reveal further issues. The domestic crude oil industry has been contracting for six consecutive months. In fact, the sector has contracted in 20 out of the last 24 months. The natural gas sector, too, has contracted for the last 20 consecutive months. As context, from about the middle of last year, it had been increasingly clear that there would be some sort of escalation between the U.S. and Iran, even if the exact nature of the war now could not have been predicted then. It is no secret that India is highly dependent on energy imports, especially from the region that would have faced the brunt of any such escalation. As a matter of fact, a large part of the contraction in domestic production was likely because imports were coming cheap. Yet, as tensions increased, it might have been more prudent to have increased domestic oil and gas production over the last eight months so as to at least build reserves, if not to also temporarily reduce import dependence. Permanently reducing such dependence will take time, but a temporary domestic production push – as is belatedly underway – might have considerably alleviated the current supply crunch. Hindsight is 20-20, but that does not excuse a lack of foresight or an inability to learn. The Pradhan Mantri Ujjwala Yojana of 2016 should have triggered a concerted policy to secure LPG supplies and reserves.

This poor core sector performance comes on top of the new series of GDP data showing that the Indian economy is actually smaller than previously thought. Further, between 2022-23 and 2025-26, the contributions to GDP of key engines such as private consumption, capital formation, exports and imports have all fallen. The share of 'change in stocks' has nearly doubled, however, meaning that there is production but not enough sales. Soon, that production too will reduce to fall in line with the subdued demand. All of this leads into the impact of the current crisis. With commercial fuel sources curtailed, oil prices at more than \$100 a barrel, and global economic uncertainty at a high, economists and rating agencies are already downgrading India's growth outlook to about 6.5%. Perhaps, India's much-vaunted macroeconomic fundamentals and resilience need a more realistic assessment.

A curated selection of articles on the Editorial and Opinion pages for World TB Day, March 24

The evolving diagnostic landscape for tuberculosis

Two weeks ago, in the run-up to World Tuberculosis (TB) Day (which falls on March 24), the World Health Organization (WHO) formally recommended the use of new near point-of-care (NPOC) molecular tests for diagnosing TB. WHO also endorsed the use of tongue swab samples for TB testing and sputum pooling strategies to potentially improve testing efficiencies at scale. These are the latest developments in what has been an unusually remarkable decade for the TB diagnostic landscape, a decade when new technologies have not only emerged but have also been tested, swiftly recommended and utilised to advance global efforts to eliminate TB.

Probably the best example is the rapidly expanding use of portable chest X-ray (CXR), in tandem with artificial intelligence (AI) solutions for TB screening. In India, the National Tuberculosis Elimination Programme (NTEP) has made available hundreds of portable CXR machines that are being utilised for the Pradhan Mantri TB Mukta Bharat Abhiyaan, in an effort to take active TB screening into the community.

Until recently, X-ray access was limited to hospital settings and dependent on the availability of technicians and radiologists to record the X-ray and interpret the findings. Today, active case-finding efforts are in full swing through mobile vans equipped with portable CXR with AI, making it more convenient. While this takes diagnostic services into the community, we must ensure on-the-spot collection of sputum samples for those with any CXR findings to significantly reduce attrition in the diagnostic cascade. Further, those with CXR lesions other than TB (for example, lung cancer) must get the referral and treatment services they need. Systematic microplanning will also help to refine these screening efforts to focus on those who are most vulnerable, particularly in urban and tribal settings.

The use of AI also presents a credible option for opportunistic screening. Tens of thousands of X-rays are performed daily across India in public and private clinics and hospitals for various reasons. Installing AI algorithms in digital X-ray machines that can swiftly identify suspicious lesions, whether for TB or other respiratory disorders, can reduce delays in diagnosis. Building health system capacity, particularly at the service delivery level, to use AI effectively is an important first step.

The diagnostic landscape is shifting
India has long relied on sputum smear microscopy as the primary test for diagnosing TB, despite its low sensitivity and inability to identify drug-resistance. In 2016, India began scaling up molecular testing – starting with the Cartridge-based Nucleic Acid Amplification Test



Dr. Soumya Swaminathan

is Chairperson of the M.S. Swaminathan Research Foundation and National Science Chair, Anusandhan National Research Foundation (ANRF)

Strengthening the tuberculosis testing infrastructure with an expanded diagnostic toolbox will improve outcomes and support TB elimination efforts

(CBNAAT) and later adopting the indigenous Truenat in 2020. Today, many more Indian products are available, and decentralised access to molecular testing is central to the TB programme.

However, access to up-front molecular testing remains uneven. To achieve 100% testing through NAAT prior to treatment initiation, we must also strengthen sputum collection and transportation mechanisms, especially for the elderly, people with disabilities, and those who live in hard-to-reach areas. To complete the diagnostic cascade swiftly, we must reduce delays in first-line and second-line drug resistance testing and work with the general health system to leverage diagnostic human resource capacity. Minimising test turnaround time will ensure that people with drug-resistant TB are started on the correct treatment regimen at the earliest.

With WHO's endorsement of near point-of-care Nucleic Acid Amplification Tests (nPOC-NAAT), there are now more options for molecular testing at the primary-care level that are not heavily dependent on infrastructure. The use of non-sputum samples, such as tongue swabs, are especially useful for those who find it difficult to produce a good sputum sample, including children.

It is important to acknowledge that none of these tools is a complete solution in itself. What this growing collection of new tests offers is a comprehensive toolbox for TB diagnosis. Diagnostic network optimisation can help identify which tools to best use, individually and in combination, and where they should be located, to establish a diagnostic cascade that is accessible, affordable and person-centered. India must field-test these tools through robust implementation research that matches the pace of innovation, so that solutions can be tested in specific settings and decisions taken for scale-up.

Indian innovators have made a significant contribution, bringing to the market screening and diagnostic tools for global use, and will continue to play an important role in taking them to scale across the country. Over the years, we must examine the evidence to evolve clear diagnostic algorithms that are operationally feasible, involving the use of both AI-enabled CXR and molecular tests for diagnosing TB and identifying any antibiotic resistance.

Research and innovation priorities
Simultaneously, we must streamline innovation assessment and procurement pathways so that all evidence is rigorously reviewed by the Indian Council of Medical Research (ICMR), comprehensive health technology assessments address clinical, social, economic, and ethical concerns, and only recommended tools are

procured and distributed in both public and private sectors. Several areas still require research and innovation.

First, as India is scaling up testing for TB infection and access to TB preventive therapy (TPT), we need more cost-effective and easy-to-use biomarkers that can identify and predict those at high risk for disease progression. Studies have shown that 'test and treat' approaches are more likely to convince people with TB infection to start on TPT, if they are at higher risk for disease, particularly in the private sector.

Second, the National TB Survey shows that asymptomatic TB is a serious issue, making symptom-based screening alone insufficient. Increased access to chest X-ray is a step in the right direction but we also need faster, less invasive diagnostic tools that use saliva and other non-sputum samples. More feasibility studies are required to understand utility and performance in real-world settings, particularly among individuals with low

bacterial load. Third, diagnosing TB in children remains challenging. Children cannot produce sputum as they often have low bacillary levels. Testing using stool samples has been tried in some countries and we need more implementation research in this area. We need far greater investment – and urgency – in finding the right new tools for diagnosing TB in children.

Finally, diagnosing extra-pulmonary TB (EP-TB) – which is almost a quarter of India's TB burden – remains difficult, often inaccessible and very expensive. Misdiagnosis as well as delayed diagnosis of EP-TB contributes to both catastrophic costs for families and poor outcomes for individuals. There are some pilots being done globally using AI-enabled portable ultrasound devices alongside molecular testing using new tools; we need India-specific evidence on this, including on cost-effectiveness.

Investing in strengthening the diagnostic landscape can be the greatest return on investment for the public health system. The sooner a person with TB is diagnosed, ideally before they are very ill, the more likely they are to recover fully, with fewer long-term post-treatment morbidities. Early diagnosis can not only improve treatment outcomes and long-term lung health but also dramatically reduce transmission within communities. A careful but swift and streamlined public sector expansion of diagnostics can also significantly reduce out-of-pocket expenditure for families affected by TB. An evidence-based, strong and expanded diagnostic toolbox can be a powerful lever to accelerate pathways to TB elimination in India.

A decade of building India's TB Champion movement

In early 2017, at a workshop in New Delhi, Cedric Fernandes, a tuberculosis (TB) survivor and advocate from Maharashtra, said to a room full of other TB survivors, "It has been very lonely having this disease. I am fed up with the loneliness and I hope all of you are too." Addressing the organising team at the workshop, he gently admonished us: "I am so glad that someone is finally bringing us together ... but what took so long?"

India diagnoses and treats over 25 lakh people with TB every year, which means that there are hundreds of thousands of individuals such as Cedric, who are coming to terms with the disease and fighting to overcome it. Their path, from diagnosis to cure, is often fraught with challenges in an ecosystem where stigma and social exclusion continue to thrive within communities. TB remains one of the most stigmatised illnesses in both urban and rural India; stigma and discrimination uniquely impact women, men, transgender communities, children and adolescents, the elderly and other socially vulnerable groups.

Challenging the belief
One of the early criticisms of the global TB response was that it remained stubbornly biomedical, focusing solely on clinical interventions whilst excluding communities and devaluing lived experience. Back in 2016, when we first began to imagine and build our wish list for how TB-affected communities – people with TB, TB survivors and their families – could play a greater role, there were many sceptics. Most of all, we were told that TB survivors, unlike people living with HIV, would want to move on with their lives once they had completed treatment, and would not be interested in becoming peer supporters or advocates. Ten years later, the evolution of the TB Champion movement in India has firmly dispelled this notion. TB Champions are survivors who are passionate, motivated and committed individuals, firm in their conviction



Dr. Nalini Krishnan

is Co-Founder and Executive Secretary of the Resource Group for Education and Advocacy for Community Health (REACH), a non-profit organisation working on tuberculosis (TB) for 27 years and a pioneer of the TB Survivor to Champion model



Anupama Srinivasan

is Deputy Director, Resource Group for Education and Advocacy for Community Health (REACH)

Survivors become 'TB Champions', supporting treatment, awareness and community engagement

that they have an important role to play in India's response to TB.

India's National TB Elimination Programme (NTEP) provides access to high-quality free diagnostics and treatment. Over the last few years, diagnosis and case-finding have accelerated, and treatment outcomes have steadily improved, which means that more people are being cured and mortality has reduced, with fewer people dying of TB. Newer strategies – Artificial Intelligence-enabled screening, active case-finding within communities, shorter and less toxic treatment regimens, expanded nutrition support, differentiated care approaches – have been adopted. But even the most robust health system cannot achieve elimination of any disease on its own, without active community participation. This is where TB Champions are uniquely poised to draw on their own personal experiences of TB to be powerful communicators and advocates for changes.

'Empower, support, educate'
In the early years of working with TB survivors, our focus was on developing the 'Survivor to Champion' training curriculum, which has since been formally adopted by the NTEP.

The involvement of TB Champions has reaffirmed a conviction that we have held from our inception – that a person with TB needs emotional support and motivation to get them through the treatment period, as much as they need high-quality clinical care. TB Champion-led peer counselling, through both one-to-one communication and support groups, has helped to improve treatment literacy and empowered people with TB with the knowledge they need. We have found a greater level of confidence and comfort among people with TB who have been supported by TB Champions and a significant reduction in self-stigmatisation.

Even today, myths and misconceptions about

TB persist. TB Champions have played a critical role in dispelling these and in improving knowledge of TB, the symptoms of the disease and where to seek care. They literally reach the last mile through regular community meetings, where they talk about the disease, share their own stories and reassure people that TB is a treatable and curable disease. This has been a powerful anti-stigma strategy, enabling people to come forward to seek diagnosis and treatment.

Building networks, looking ahead
In addition, over the last decade, TB Champions in several States have come together to form survivor-led networks. These collective entities are naturally designed to be a powerful bridge between those seeking care and those providing services, especially among social vulnerable groups. Importantly, networks have become a source of strength for TB survivors, many of whom continue to experience the physical, social and economic toll of the disease even after being cured. However, the long-term future and sustainability of networks remains uncertain, given that they are dependent on external resources for funding. The next challenge is to test and build self-sustaining socio-economic models for survivor-led networks.

Over the last 10 years, we have been humbled by the trust that thousands of TB Champions from across the country have placed in us. They have travelled long distances to attend our workshops, sharing their TB journeys and stories, their pain and successes. They have become empowered local leaders, unafraid to use the TB Champion moniker to refer to themselves. They remain staunchly committed to working with their communities – supporting people with TB and their families, talking about stigma, meeting their panchayat leaders – and doing all of this for one simple, powerful reason – 'so that no one else should suffer like I did'.



LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Erratic policy

The dramatic post by U.S. President Donald Trump, on a 'five-day ceasefire of sorts', must have stunned Benjamin Netanyahu's Israel. The 'second coming' of Mr. Trump has been marked less by strategic doctrine and more by disruptive impulse. Alliances

once seen as bedrock as NATO, have been treated as transactional, their value weighed against immediate domestic optics rather than long-term geopolitical balance. Trade agreements and multilateral pacts have been entered and exited with disconcerting ease, reinforcing a perception of

the U.S. as an uncertain partner. In conflict theatres, this inconsistency has been stark. Support extended to Ukraine appeared forceful yet episodic, leaving allies unsure of endurance. Europe, once a strategic anchor, has often been addressed with impatience rather than partnership.

Even Israel, a beneficiary of unequivocal backing, has found that patronage can pivot abruptly.
R. Narayanan,
Navi Mumbai

PNG transition issue

I wish to draw the attention of government officials to a troubling issue being faced

by many consumers registered for piped natural gas (PNG) connections with GAIL (India) Limited. Under the recent government mandate (LPG Amendment Order 2026), households with functional PNG connections must surrender their domestic LPG cylinders. However, GAIL

officials and distributors are reportedly asking consumers to surrender their LPG connections before the PNG line has been installed or activated.
Parthasarathy P.,
New Delhi

Letters emailed to letters@thehindu.co.in must carry the postal address.

From disease-specific to person-centred care

By using TB as an entry point, integrated healthcare delivery can optimise and improve public health efficiency



Anupama Srinivasan
Deputy Director of REACH



Dr. Ramya Anantha Krishnan
Director of REACH

Tuberculosis (TB) rarely presents as a standalone disease in an individual. Many people with TB have other comorbidities or disease conditions that they must simultaneously cope with, while being on treatment for TB. Therefore, treating TB alone is not enough. Adopting integrated care approaches by transitioning from disease-specific to person-centred care can accelerate India's efforts to achieve both universal health coverage and TB elimination. Simply put, we must treat the person and not the disease.

Take the example of Divya (name changed), a 48-year-old woman who was diagnosed with TB in 2023. She had been living with diabetes and hypertension for several years and it is highly likely that her diabetes played a role in her contracting TB. Crucially, she had poor glycemic control with a HbA1c over 10, which had a direct impact on her treatment for TB.

Infectious diseases like TB; non-communicable diseases such as diabetes and chronic respiratory diseases; malnutrition; and social and economic vulnerabilities inevitably

intersect in individuals and families, adversely impacting outcomes and the overall quality of life. Recognising the interconnected nature of these multiple vulnerabilities is the first step towards delivering integrated care.

Treating TB and diabetes

As in the case of Divya, an important opportunity for integration is between TB and diabetes, given India's growing diabetes burden. Over 15 years ago, the National TB Elimination Programme (NTEP) identified diabetes as a key comorbidity for TB, and rolled out formal bidirectional screening guidelines for TB-diabetes. Every person with TB must be screened for diabetes and people with diabetes must ideally be screened for TB once a year. Studies have shown that people with diabetes are more likely to develop active TB disease than those without; equally, people with TB who also have diabetes are more likely to have poor TB treatment outcomes.

In Chennai, in a cohort of over 9,000 people with TB for three years, the authors found that over



TB patients seen inside the Govind Ballabh Pant Hospital on March 24, 2025. ANI

one-third (34%) had diabetes, and of this group, 41% had poor glycemic control which is the biggest challenge. Monitoring the blood sugar levels of a person with TB and diabetes throughout the TB treatment period is therefore essential, as is expanding clinical management and the counselling that is provided from TB-specific guidance to also focus on overall lifestyle, physical activity, diet and nutrition etc.

Integrating respiratory care

Another important opportunity for integration is at the intersection of TB and Chronic Respiratory Diseases (CRD) such as asthma or Chronic Obstructive Pulmonary Disease (COPD), at the screening stage itself. Only a fraction of people with respiratory symptoms are eventually diagnosed with TB – the rest are likely to have viral flu, bronchitis, asthma etc. In REACH's ongoing TB-CRD integrated care

pilot in two districts each of Bihar and Tamil Nadu, nearly 3,000 people with COPD and asthma were identified and linked to care, among the 26,000 people who were screened for TB but found TB-negative. In addition, integrated care can also change the course of post-treatment follow-up, given that many people who complete TB treatment continue to have respiratory impairments.

Other areas of intersection include undernutrition and risk factors such as smoking and alcohol use. This multi-disease approach is already envisaged in the framework of the Ayushman Arogya Mandirs for delivering comprehensive care at the community and primary care levels.

Delivering integrated care at scale can have its share of challenges. At the health system level, it is a likely stressor on already strained human resources, with the brunt of the workload falling on community health workers. In addition, many of India's large health programmes are vertical and not always de-

signed to talk to each other, in terms of both human resources and data; this will require both creative and pragmatic solutions.

Integrated care delivery will require adequate and additional human resources, a careful readjustment of the health worker to care recipient ratio and investment in periodic training.



Holistic wellness

Given that the NTEP is among India's more robust, well-structured public health programmes, using TB as an entry point to identify and address closely associated morbidities such as diabetes, CRDs, undernutrition etc. will help optimise healthcare delivery and improve public health efficiency. More importantly, it could reduce delays in diagnosis, minimise the need for visits to several health facilities, and help overcome barriers to accessing a continuum of care. With empathetic person-centred design, integrated healthcare delivery can be a win-win for health systems, individuals and families affected by TB.

The need to integrate nutrition in TB care

For most patients with TB who are severely underweight, nutritional support is an essential and not optional part of treatment



Dr. Madhavi Bhargava

is a public health specialist and teaches at Yenepoya Medical College, Mangalore. Led the RATIONS trial in India



Dr. Anurag Bhargava

is a physician-epidemiologist and teaches at Kasturba Medical College, Mangalore. Led the RATIONS trial in India

In 2026, India still has the highest number of new cases of Tuberculosis (TB) globally and a decreasing but still unacceptable number of about three lakh deaths due to TB. Almost 10% of successfully treated patients have recurrence within two years. An answer to all these challenges may partly lie in addressing a leading cause and consequence of TB in India, which is undernutrition, closely related to poverty, food insecurity and a predominantly cereal-based diet with deficient protein intake.

On the occasion of World TB Day, evidence from the Reducing Activation of Tuberculosis by Improvement Of Nutritional Status (RATIONS) trial could offer insight into the importance of nutritional interventions. RATIONS was done in Jharkhand with support from the Indian Council of Medical Research and was the first such trial of a food-based intervention. It aimed at reducing new TB cases in TB-affected families, and improving treatment outcomes for patients with TB.

Ramlal, a 19-year-old tribal boy in the trial, weighed only 26 kg and was almost bed-bound at the

time of his diagnosis of lung TB. Along with TB drugs, he received a monthly food basket. Over the next few weeks, he started walking and could cycle to work at the end of the treatment, weighing 42 kg. Laxmi, weighing 34 kg, had TB two years ago and had stopped medication after she developed jaundice within two weeks of starting anti-TB drugs. Now, as a result of the trial, she could adhere to the medications and also breastfeed her four-month-old.

Preventing deaths due to TB

Undernutrition, especially severe undernutrition, is common in patients in India. It is a major reversible risk factor for death, drug toxicity, and recurrence after successful treatment. For most patients with TB who are severely underweight, nutritional support is an essential and not optional part of treatment. Poor families are food-insecure and become even more so due to the disease. In the RATIONS trial, a monthly 10 kg food basket of cereals, pulses, milk powder, and oil led to a weight gain of almost 4.5 kg in patients. Even a 5% weight gain in the first two months was protective against



PM TB Mukh Bharath kits, which include basic nutritious food items, distributed to patients in Chittoor, Andhra Pradesh in 2023. FILE PHOTO

death, reducing the risk by more than 60%.

In India, the National TB Elimination Programme's (NTEP) initiatives in addressing undernutrition in TB care are welcome. For example, the monthly direct benefit transfer under the Ni-Kshay Poshan Yojana increased from ₹500 to ₹1,000 and similarly the Ni-Kshay Mitra Yojana, although not universal, provides in-kind support to patients with TB. However, the plan to introduce energy-dense nutrition supple-



ments for two months to underweight patients with TB needs to be considered with caution, given higher expenses, and the mystification of an adequate balanced diet apart from the risk of monotony and poor acceptability. One in 7 patients with TB in India may have diabetes which also needs to be taken into consideration.

A new avenue

While infection with the TB germ is necessary to develop the dis-

ease, it is not sufficient to produce active TB. Almost 90% of those infected, with good immunity, never develop the disease in their lifetime. Undernutrition is the most common cause of poor immunity in India and globally. It contributes to nearly 40% of new cases in India, and improved population-level nutritional status offers an alternative approach to reducing TB incidence.

Diets of the poor in India are particularly deficient in quality protein. TB-affected families experience vulnerabilities of poverty, food insecurity, and undernutrition. The 1.5 kg per month of pulses per family member, along with extra rice, worked like a vaccine in the RATIONS trial, with new TB cases in these families coming down by almost half.

The World Health Organization released new guidelines last year recommending nutritional interventions in settings of poverty and undernutrition, drawing significantly from the evidence of the RATIONS trial.

Improving nutrition security by including pulses in the public distribution system, and expanding the Ni-Kshay Mitra scheme to in-

clude TB patients' households will have long-term benefits in reducing the TB burden in India.

The way ahead

India is a global leader in implementing comprehensive nutrition assessment and support initiatives through the NTEP. Research and evidence from India have influenced global policy. Some of the next positive steps will be to record and report nutritional assessment at diagnosis; at two months; and at the end of treatment. This will help to identify those at risk of death, monitor early weight gain, and assess nutritional recovery. A differentiated TB care model in line with the TN-KET intervention in Tamil Nadu can identify and prioritise severely underweight patients. This will require local contextualisation of food baskets, with due attention given to comorbidities, supported by transport and inpatient care for the sick.

The inverse care law also works in TB and nutrition – the most vulnerable among us such as those in difficult-to-reach areas, the tribals, and the migrant workers, should not be left out.

The views expressed are personal.

Mental health of TB patients should not be overlooked

Studies from India have shown that at least one-third of people with TB experience symptoms of depression or anxiety



Dr. R. Thara

Co-Founder and Vice-Chair of the Schizophrenia Research Foundation (SCARF)

At least one in seven Indians experience a mental health condition at some point in their lives. In people with infectious diseases like Tuberculosis (TB) or HIV, this increases to anywhere between one-third to a half of those affected. TB takes a toll on not only physical but also mental health, either in the form of definite diagnosable conditions like depression, anxiety or psychoses or as emotional suffering worsened by social stigma. TB is fundamentally a disease of inequity, perpetuated by poverty and simultaneously contributing to increasing poverty. Unemployment, the lack of livelihood, food insecurity and malnutrition are social drivers for both TB and mental health conditions.

Studies from India have shown that at least one-third of people with TB experience symptoms of depression and anxiety, which often occur together as well. The mental health burden is estimated to be even higher among people with drug-resistant TB, with upto two-thirds having mental health issues. There are anecdotal accounts from TB survivors on suicidal ideation as well as

documented instances of people with TB dying by suicide. There is not enough evidence about the prevalence of severe mental illnesses such as schizophrenia or bipolar disorders in people affected by TB.

The stigma associated with TB remains pervasive, and includes self-stigma, stigma within families, at workplaces and within communities. Many TB survivors have spoken of the guilt and shame they feel on being diagnosed with TB, despite knowing that it is an airborne disease that can affect anyone. For those with pulmonary TB, the guilt is driven primarily by the fear of transmitting the disease within their families, particularly to children. Those with depression or anxiety and TB must cope with an increased burden of stigma associated with both conditions, which can further worsen mental health.

TB and mental health

Given the high prevalence of common mental health disorders in the general population, it is possible that depression or anxiety could have been pre-existing and unidentified, even prior to the TB diagnosis; there have not been



A doctor offers flowers to a TB patient in Agartala on World TB day. PTI

enough studies on this aspect. Depression or anxiety could delay care-seeking for TB. Long-standing untreated depression can also weaken the body's immune responses which in turn could lead to active TB disease – this is yet another under-researched aspect.

Post diagnosis, untreated mental health conditions can adversely affect TB treatment outcomes. A person with TB who is depressed, and has not received mental healthcare, is more likely to take TB treatment irregularly or discontinue treatment prematurely.

This can lead to treatment failure, relapse, or drug-resistance.

Co-existing alcohol and tobacco use, in the absence of access to de-addiction programmes, are also crucial factors affecting the treatment for TB.

Screening and identifying

Integrating routine screening for all people with TB for depression and anxiety is the starting point. Building awareness about common mental health disorders among healthcare workers, equipping them with the knowledge and

skills to provide mental health first-aid and ensuring early screening at the right point in the TB care cascade are the other essential steps. Primary healthcare workers and community supporters, who are often the first to notice any psychological distress, should be trained to elicit information about sleep, appetite, mood, stress etc. which can help early identification of mental health conditions.

Given that TB itself could trigger depression, mental health screening must ideally be done at multiple time points during the TB treatment period.

From an individual perspective, being treated for TB and depression at the same time can be a stressful experience. While India's TB programme already provides decentralised access to free anti-TB drugs and financial aid for nutrition, strengthening the availability of drugs to treat depression or anxiety through the district mental health programme is vital. While antidepressants or antipsychotics can be used alongside anti-TB drugs, clinicians must monitor for any adverse drug reactions or interactions. Psychological interventions, including cognitive-behavioural therapy and participation in peer support groups, can also help reduce isolation. To provide

these services, qualified and trained mental health professionals are needed, particularly in rural and tribal areas.

Looking out for everyone

Mental health interventions cannot be limited to people with TB. The task of caring for people with TB can place considerable strain on families. Studies in India have shown that up to 80% of caregivers may exhibit high levels of Expressed negative Emotions (EE) and high stress levels due to their caregiving responsibilities. Often, high EE leads to increased caregiver burden and poorer treatment outcomes. In India's family-centred ecosystem, where most of the caregiving needs are met by family members, this can lead to critical or over-involved caregiving because of emotional, financial, and social strains.

Psychoeducation is important not just for persons with TB but also for their families and caregivers.

A blended and syndemic TB-mental health approach that considers mental healthcare as an essential part of TB care, rather than a standalone service, can significantly improve TB outcomes, reduce the burden on caregivers and improve long-term mental health.

From Page One

Trump pauses strikes on Iran, says deal is possible

“Our people demand the complete and humiliating punishment of the aggressors. All officials stand firmly behind their Leader and people until this goal is achieved”, the Iranian Speaker said in a social media post on Monday.

In recent days, friendly countries sent messages indicating that the U.S. had requested talks to end the war, but Iran had not responded, Iran's state news agency *IRNA* quoted its Foreign Ministry spokesperson as saying. “Yes, there have been initiatives from regional countries to reduce tensions, and our response to all of them is clear: we are not the party that started this war, and all such requests should be directed to Washington,” state-run *Mizan* agency cited the Foreign Ministry.

‘Constructive conversations’

“Based on the tenor and tone of these in-depth, detailed, and constructive conversations, which [which] will continue throughout the week, I have instructed the Department of War to postpone any and all military strikes against Iranian power plants and energy infrastructure for a five day period, subject to the success of the ongoing meetings and discussions,” Mr. Trump wrote in his post.

“All I am saying is, we are in the throes of a real possibility of making a deal... We are dealing with the man who I believe is the most respected and the leader,” Mr. Trump said in Washington, without saying who the U.S. was speaking with but added that it was not the Supreme Leader Ayatollah Mojtaba Khamenei. “Look at Venezuela, how well that’s working out... Maybe we find somebody like that in Iran,” he said, adding that the U.S. wants Iran to abandon any nuclear ambitions and give up its enriched uranium stockpiles.

Women’s quota: Centre mulls early delimitation

As per Article 82 of the Constitution, the next delimitation exercise was to be done based on the first Census after 2026, but these amendments could mean that the 2011 Census data will be applied and the remaking of constituencies can proceed without the current Census exercise being concluded. The proposals may include the expansion of State Assemblies as well.

The Act originally passed in September 2023 envisaged the conduct of the Decadal Census, followed by delimitation of seats. The 2021 Decadal Census, which got delayed because of COVID, beginning next month. As per the current timelines, implementation of the Act could be pushed beyond 2030. However, by bringing in fresh amendments, the government is now seeking to bring forward the implementation of the Act.

Government managers, including Union Home Minister Amit Shah, met with leaders of several Opposition parties on Monday, including the Nationalist Congress Party (SP)’s Supriya Sule, YSR Congress Party’s P.V. Midhun Reddy, the All India Majlis-e-Ittehadul Muslimeen’s Asaduddin Owaisi and the Shiv Sena (UBT)’s Arvind Sawant, among others. Trinamool Congress and the Left skipped the meeting.

A separate meeting of NDA partners was held later on Monday evening. The government managers had consulted the Congress and Samajwadi Party earlier. The Congress will be holding a meeting of Opposition floor leaders on Tuesday morning to go through the proposals put forward by the government.

“The amendments will require a two-thirds majority of both Houses, which is why extensive consultations are being held with the Opposition...,” said a government source.

The Women’s Reservation Act, 2023, known as the Constitution (106th Amendment) Act, 2023, mandates a 33% reservation for women in the Lok Sabha and State Assemblies.

Impact of West Asia war likely to be felt for long time, PM tells Lok Sabha

Country should be prepared and united, says Modi as he condemns attacks on commercial ships and obstruction of Strait of Hormuz; India has 5.3 million tonnes of petrol reserves, and govt. is working towards increasing this to 6.5 million tonnes

Sandeep Phukan
NEW DELHI

The situation in West Asia is “deeply concerning”, and the impact of the war is likely to be felt for a long time, Prime Minister Narendra Modi said on Monday, while briefing the Lok Sabha on the steps taken by his government to secure India’s energy needs.

The country should be prepared and united, Mr. Modi said, urging all members to ensure the Indian Parliament sends out a “united and unanimous voice on the issue”.

The government should hold a proper discussion so that other members can put forth their views, Congress MP Priyanka Gandhi Vadra said after the Prime Minister’s speech.

Earlier, making a statement in the Lok Sabha, Mr. Modi said he had spoken to the heads of most West



Every Indian in the war-affected region is being given every possible help, Narendra Modi informed in Parliament on Monday. SANSAD TV

Asian countries, all of whom had assured the safety of Indians.

“India has always raised its voice for peace in the interest of humanity. Dialogue and diplomacy are the solutions to this problem. Our efforts are aimed at reducing tensions and ending this conflict,” Mr. Modi said, amid the thumping of desks by ruling party members.

“I myself have spoken with all relevant leaders in West Asia. I have urged

pliers from various countries to ensure that oil and gas supplies continued from wherever possible, he said, addressing apprehensions of fuel shortages. All power plants in the country have adequate stocks of coal, he added.

India has 5.3 million tonnes of strategic petroleum reserves, and the government was working towards increasing this to 6.5 million tonnes, he told the House.

“The reserves maintained by our oil companies are separate. In the past 11 years, our refining capacity has also increased significantly,” Mr. Modi added.

The country’s farmers had filled the food grain reserves, so India is well prepared in terms of food security, he said, speaking on the war’s impact on agriculture.

“We are also making efforts to ensure that kharif sowing takes place proper-

ly. For this, the government has made adequate arrangements for fertilizers to deal with any emergency...,” he said.

As summer has begun in India, the demand for electricity has increased, but all power plants in the country have adequate stocks of coal, he said.

West Asia is important to India as nearly one crore Indians live and work in the Gulf countries, the Prime Minister added.

Every Indian in the war-affected region was being given every possible help, and more than 3.75 lakh Indians, including 1,000 people from war-torn Iran, had been safely evacuated, Mr. Modi said.

However, several lives had been lost, and some people had been injured during the conflict, the Prime Minister said, adding that their families were being given the necessary help.

India tracking developments, says Centre on Trump pause

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

India is closely monitoring developments, External Affairs Ministry spokesperson Randhir Jaiswal said on Monday shortly after U.S. President Donald Trump announced that he would postpone attacks on Iran’s power infrastructure for five days.

Another senior official termed the move “positive”, while emphasising that the government was keeping an eye on the developments.

On Monday evening, External Affairs Minister S. Jaishankar held talks with the Ambassadors of the GCC countries, namely Bahrain, Kuwait, Oman, Qatar, Saudi Arabia, and the UAE. He said he “thanked them for their continued support to the Indian community in the region”. He also spoke over the telephone to Sri Lankan Foreign Minister Vijitha Herath about developments in the war.

Former AAP Minister’s arrest triggers credit war

The Hindu Bureau
CHANDIGARH

Former Minister in the Aam Aadmi Party government in Punjab, Laljit Singh Bhullar, was arrested on Monday in connection with the death of a State warehousing corporation official, who allegedly died by suicide last week.

Mr. Bhullar will be produced in a court on Tuesday. Gagandeep Singh Randhawa, district manager of Punjab Warehousing Corporation in Amritsar, allegedly died by suicide on Saturday after consuming what appeared to be a poisonous substance as seen in a purported video linked to the incident. In the video, he had accused Mr. Bhullar of harassing him by pressuring to award a tender to the former Minister’s aide.

Opposition parties asserted the arrest came following the pressure built by them on the AAP government, even as the AAP claimed credit for its decisive action against its own Minister in the interest of justice.

(Those in distress can seek help at 011-40769002)

Two more Indian vessels carrying 93,000 tonnes of LPG cross Strait of Hormuz

M. Kalyanaraman
CHENNAI

Two Indian-flagged LPG carriers, *Jag Vasant* and *Pine Gas*, have transited through the Strait of Hormuz on Monday evening. They are together carrying nearly 93,000 tonnes of LPG, as per the inter-Ministerial briefing held on Monday. In addition, a flurry of LPG import shipments that came in the past few days and scheduled for the upcoming week may have eased the cooking gas crisis somewhat.

In a sign of the easing crisis, the government had announced a 20% increase in commercial LPG allocations, taking it to 50% of pre-war levels even while saying the LPG situation continues to be worrisome.

Jag Vasant and *Pine Gas*, owned by Great Eastern Shipping and Seven Island Shipping respectively, are likely to reach Indian ports between March 26 and 28. The government had said that domestic LPG production had increased by 40%, which would mean an additional 18,000 tonnes pro-



People in a queue with empty LPG cooking gas cylinders to avail refilled ones in Prayagraj.

duction a day, bringing down the approximate daily import requirement from 55,000 tonnes. At normal times, India would need at least one Very Large Gas Carrier of some 55,000 tonnes to dock at one of its ports every day and discharge the cargo.

Two foreign-owned and foreign-flagged LPG carriers, *Hellas Gladiator* and *Gas Jupiter*, each carrying 24,000 tonnes are expected to reach Visakhapatnam on March 30.

Hellas Gladiator had loaded in Netherlands. Port sources say that this shipment is part of the strategic decision to source LPG from European markets to bypass the ongoing supply constraints in West

Asia. *Gas Jupiter* loaded its cargo in the U.S.

The cavern project of SA-LPG at Visakhapatnam, which is one of India’s two long-term LPG storage locations, had handled two ships carrying LPG after February 28. Each ship carried and unloaded about 24,000 tonnes. The total capacity of the cavern is 60,000 tonnes and is one of two long-term LPG storage facilities in India.

Globe Polarix, carrying cargo from Houston, Texas, is expected to reach Sandhead, Kolkata, on March 24, according to an official in Haldia port.

It will berth the following day and discharge more than 20,000 tonnes in all.

BW Birch, carrying LPG taken from *Nanda Devi* in Vadinar Port in Gujarat through ship-to-ship transfer, is expected to dock at Haldia on March 29 and discharge cargo.

Gas Jupiter is also expected on April 3 at Haldia. (Inputs from Sumit Bhattacharjee, Sunita Sekar, Anil Kumar Sastri, Satyasundar Barik, Dhinesh Kallungal and Lalatendu Mishra)

Anil Ambani bank fraud case: ‘CBI, ED showed reluctance’

Krishnadas Rajagopal
NEW DELHI



The Supreme Court on Monday said the Directorate of Enforcement (ED) and the Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) must probe the financial fraud allegations linked to Anil Dhirubhai Ambani Group (ADAG) and promoter Anil Ambani in a “transparent, fair and credible manner”, while making a note that the probe agencies’ previous conduct had shown “reluctance” and lack of discipline or structure.

“...your investigative agencies, the way they have shown reluctance and allowed things to go whichever way... that is not acceptable. The investigation should be done in a transparent, fair and credible manner.” Chief Justice of India Surya Kant, heading a three-judge Bench, addressed Solicitor-General Tushar Mehta.

“Your investigation must inspire confidence not only of the court, but of every stakeholder. People should be convinced that you have done a fair and completely independent investigation,” the

‘U.S.-led Pax Silica is a step towards digital colonialism’

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Senior Congress MP Digvijaya Singh on Monday warned the Union government against joining Pax Silica, terming the U.S.-led project a step towards digital colonialism.

The U.S.-led initiative is aimed at building resilient supply chains for critical minerals and Artificial Intelligence (AI) technologies. India joined the coalition in February 2026, during the AI Impact summit held in New Delhi.

Raising the matter during Zero Hour in the Rajya Sabha on Monday, Mr. Singh asked the government to make the terms and conditions of the agreement public.

BJP hails Modi for becoming India’s longest-serving head of government

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) on Monday hailed Prime Minister Narendra Modi for becoming India’s longest-serving head of government, surpassing the 8,930-day record earlier held by former Sikkim Chief Minister Pawan Chamling.

At a press conference, on the party’s behalf, Union Minister Shivraj Singh Chouhan expressed gratitude to the Prime Minister for India’s powerful representation in the changing global landscape, stating that Mr. Modi has taken the country to new heights.

“Narendra Modi ji is not just a leader, but also a visionary and an institution in himself, who has consistently worked for national



Prime Minister Narendra Modi has taken the nation to new heights, Shivraj Singh Chouhan said at a press conference on Monday. PTI

interest both as the Chief Minister of Gujarat and as the Prime Minister of India,” he said.

‘Took key decisions’

Recounting Mr. Modi’s contributions in Gujarat, the Union Minister spoke about initiatives such as re-development of earthquake-hit Bhuj and Kutch, Narmada water manage-

national security.

“Working tirelessly for a larger purpose, reaching the pinnacle of hard work, and constantly pushing the limits of effort such an example has been set by Prime Minister Narendra Modi that it fills one with pride and satisfaction,” he said, adding that he had known Mr. Modi for about 35 years.

“I have worked alongside him as an organisational *karyakarta*, witnessed him in action as Chief Minister, and later seen him as Prime Minister while I myself became a Union Minister. In all these roles, the fundamental motivation Narendra Modi ji displayed has always been patriotism, putting the nation above all, and prioritising the country first,” said Mr. Chouhan.

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Biotechnology graduates are the architects of the next animal science revolution in the country, experts said at a webinar on “Biotech Careers: Food and Nutrition” on Sunday.

The webinar was jointly organised by the Vellore Institute of Technology, Chennai, and *The Hindu* as part of the series titled “Biotechnology: Role in Industry 5.0 – Sustainable Future Pathways”.

“While the growth rate of the food processing market is estimated at 13%, India’s bio-economy rate is projected to be much higher. This means biotechnology students will have enough career opportunities to steer the growth over the next decade,” Anand



K. Jadi, general manager and plant head, ICML Medak, ITC Ltd., said.

G. Jayaraman, Professor and Dean of the School of Biosciences and Technology at VIT, Chennai, spoke about biotechnology’s increasing influence in various sectors, including agriculture, food, healthcare, and research-driven innovation. He said the biotech industry was driving both human and animal nutrition. “It is enhancing the quality and

quantity of food.”

Chakkaravarthi Saravanan, Associate Professor at the National Institute of Food Technology, Entrepreneurship and Management in Kundli, Haryana, pointed out that with an ever-increasing population, shrinking land space, and rising food prices, the significance of biotechnology for food was growing.

Speaking on the role of biotechnology in the livestock industry, R. Balaguru, technical director at V.K. Palappa Nadar Poultry Farms Pvt. Ltd., said 70% of the rural poor in the world depended on livestock. The panellists advocated for establishing a solid foundation for learning new-age technologies.

The webinar can be viewed at <https://newsth.live/THVITFNY>

ASSEMBLY POLLS

Gaurav Gogoi enters electoral fray from Jorhat

Assam Congress president Gaurav Gogoi filed his nomination papers for the Jorhat Assembly constituency on Monday, marking his debut in the State polls.

A three-time Lok Sabha member — twice from the delimitation-devoured Kaliabor and once from Jorhat — he is the chief

ministerial face of the Congress-led six-party Opposition alliance. The alliance has been dubbed the “Three-Gogoi Group”, the others being Rajiour Dal president Akhil Gogoi and his Assam Jatiya Parishad counterpart, Lurinjyoti Gogoi. “The April 9 election is an opportunity to cleanse Assam politics, dirtied by the polarising BJP-led alliance. A Congress-led government will ensure equitable access to welfare schemes, particularly for women,” he said.



Assam Congress president Gaurav Gogoi on his way to file nomination papers. ANI

JMM to go solo, releases list for Assam election

On the last day of filing the nomination, the Jharkhand Mukti Morcha on Monday released the list of 21 candidates for the Assam Assembly election after its talks with the Congress failed. The JMM is contesting the Assam Assembly polls solo. However a regional outfit Jai Bharat Party is backing JMM.

Out of 19 seats reserved for the Scheduled Tribes, it fielded candidates in just one constituency — Bokajan, where the party has fielded Pratap Singh Rongphar. Around 15 constituencies have tea tribe populations which are sizeable in numbers and many have social-cultural links to Jharkhand. Earlier, Jharkhand Chief Minister Hemant Soren had written to his Assam counterpart Himanta Biswa Sarma expressing concern about the plight of tea tribes.



PIYUSH GOYAL
BJP leader

We are very satisfied with the 27 seats, we will sweep the elections as the people of the State are fed up with CM Stalin and Udhayanidhi Stalin

AIMIM to ally with Humayun Kabir's AJUP

All India Majlis-e-Ittehadul Muslimeen (AIMIM) leader Asaduddin Owaisi said that his party will contest the West Bengal Assembly elections in alliance with Humayun Kabir's Aam Janata Unnayan Party. The announcement assumes significance as it indicates a new political grouping of minority forces in the State.



SUKANTA MAJUMDAR
BJP leader

It is not just about saving Bengali Hindus. It is about saving Bengal from turning into Pakistan or Afghanistan. Only BJP can save it



Electoral diet: BJP candidate from Bidhannagar, Sharadwat Mukherjee, canvassing with a fish in West Bengal on Sunday. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

With a catla, BJP candidate has a bone to pick with Trinamool

Shiv Sahay Singh
KOLKATA

Sharadwat Mukherjee held a catla, a freshwater fish, in his hand as he campaigned in Bidhannagar on Sunday. The BJP candidate for the seat has been trying to tell people that the party will never put any restrictions on non-vegetarian food if voted to power in West Bengal.

In a State where fish and meat are a staple, the Bharatiya Janata Party has been trying to convince voters that the party is not opposed to fish eating, fighting the popular notion that it promotes a vegetarian diet.

“Lies are being spread against us. We eat fish and meat. I have come out with fish today to stop this propaganda,” Mr. Mukherjee said. He said the Trinamool Congress had pushed people to such economic distress that they did not have money to buy fish.

BJP State president Shamik Bhattacharya has said on several occasions that Bengalis can continue with their dietary preferences and the party has no plans to promote vegetarianism. “Swami Vivekananda has said that Mother Kali will eat mutton. All Bengalis and Biharis will eat mutton. If anyone comes to stop me, I will break and crush it [the restriction],” he said.

He made the remarks in response to comments by Deputy Chief Minister of Bihar Vijay Kumar Sinha about restricting sale of non-vegetarian food.

The Trinamool Congress leadership has often warned the electorate of the State that if the BJP comes to power, it will stop people from eating fish and meat. Chief Minister and party chairperson Mamata Banerjee said on February 21, “Bengal cannot be occupied by those who come from Delhi. They say that they will stop the consumption of fish and meat because they do not know the culture of Bengal.” February 21 is observed as International Mother Language Day.

Trinamool Congress spokesperson Kunal Ghosh, who is contesting the Manicktala seat, said the BJP candidate campaigning with fish in hand showed that the party was suffering a “panic attack”.

“Their [BJP] Delhi leaders are saying we won't allow people to eat fish and in Bengal the leaders who are certain of defeat, their candidates are campaigning with fish in hand,” Mr. Ghosh said.

Among the several challenges faced by the BJP in West Bengal, the biggest has been the perception that the party is alien to the culture, traditions and food preferences of Bengalis. Mr. Mukherjee and Mr. Bhattacharya are attempting to challenge this perception. BJP leaders often claim that the founder of Jana Sangha, the predecessor to the BJP was Syama Prasad Mookerjee, a dhoti-kurta clad Bengali and the Trinamool cannot paint the party as a ‘party of outsiders’.

It is not only during elections that the debate on food preferences dominates West Bengal politics. In January, a vendor was assaulted in Kolkata Brigade Parade Ground for selling chicken patty during a religious event organised by a Hindutva organisation. The BJP leaders of the State came out in support of those behind attack. Those responsible for the assault were arrested by the Kolkata Police.

Incidents of fish vendors being asked not to sell fish and meat during Navaratri in different parts of the country created political ripples in West Bengal.

IN FOCUS

S. Anandan
C.P.Sajit
PERAVUR

Kerala Pradesh Congress Committee (KPCC) president and Peravur MLA Sunny Joseph has said that the United Democratic Front (UDF) will make the Sabarimala gold theft case and alleged irregularities linked to the Global Ayyappa Sangamam the central issues in the April 9 Assembly election. He has accused the ruling Communist Party of India (Marxist) of shielding the accused and eroding trust in governance.

In an interview with *The Hindu*, Mr. Joseph alleged that despite a court-monitored investigation into the Sabarimala theft, the accused secured bail without even an interim chargesheet being filed. “This is not just a theft; it involves temple property and public faith. The Supreme Court has observed that even gods are unsafe in Kerala,” he said, adding that the Congress would mobilise public opinion and organise protests on the issue. He further alleged financial irregularities in the government-backed Global Ay-

yappa Sangamam event and said such controversies, coupled with what he termed as selective targeting of Congress leaders, would be highlighted before voters.

Rejecting Chief Minister Pinarayi Vijayan's charge that the Congress and its leader Rahul Gandhi were acting as a “B-team” of the Bharatiya Janata Party, Mr. Joseph said the public would not believe the allegation. “It is the Congress under Rahul Gandhi that is leading the fight against the BJP nationally. The BJP's action against Rahul Gandhi and other leaders shows who their real opponent is,” he said, alleging that the CPI(M) has a tacit understanding with the BJP, citing political development in places such as Palakkad.

Strong support

The KPCC chief said the UDF's decision to support leaders who defected from the CPI(M), including G. Sudhakaran, Aisha Potty, T.K. Govindan, and V. Kunhikrishnan, would strengthen the coalition. “These are mass leaders with strong grassroots support. Their entry reflects growing dissent within the CPI (M) against its functioning,” he said.

Dismissing concerns of



Favourable outcome: Senior Congress leaders share sweets with KPCC president Sunny Joseph following the UDF's overall dominance in the State local body elections. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

internal dissent within the Congress over granting electoral berth to former CPI(M) leaders, Mr. Joseph said minor issues at the local level would be resolved through dialogue. “The party is united and committed to ensuring their victory,” he added. He also said that the uncertainty surrounding senior Congress leader K. Sudhakaran had been resolved, with the latter actively campaigning.

Mr. Joseph highlighted his development track re-

cord over the past 15 years in Peravur, stating that administrative restructuring and infrastructure expansion were among his key achievements. He is taking on the Left Democratic Front's K.K. Shailaja in the constituency.

Track record

Mr. Joseph also claimed credit for the elevation of Iritty to a municipality, strengthening of health infrastructure and establishment of an 11-kV substation in Kelakam, facilitated by

land donation from a local trust. He said the bifurcation of the Iritty police station and creation of the Muzhankunnu police station helped address law and order challenges in a large jurisdiction.

Mr. Joseph described human-wildlife conflict as one of the most pressing issues in forest fringe areas like Aralam and Kelakam. He said he had raised the matter multiple times in the Assembly and moved adjournment motions, but discussions were not per-

mitted. “Despite repeated interventions, including adjournment motions in the Assembly, the issue was not discussed seriously. Funds allocated are insufficient and even Central assistance remains under utilised,” he alleged.

‘Mood for change’

Expressing confidence in the UDF's prospects, Mr. Joseph said the coalition's improved performance in local body elections indicated strong anti-incumbency sentiment. The UDF has expanded its presence in Corporations and local bodies. From being in power in one Corporation, the UDF now governs four Corporations, he said, adding that there is visible enthusiasm among workers and a clear mood for change.

On the possibility of the Kerala Congress (M) returning to the UDF fold, he said the decision rested with the party leadership, but noted that the KC(M) had suffered electoral setback in districts such as Kottayam, Idukki, and Pathanamthitta.

“The people of Kerala will assess governance failure, corruption allegation, and development stagnation. We are confident they will deliver a decisive mandate in favour of the UDF,” he added.

Almost half of the SIR cases under adjudication settled in Bengal: CEO

Shrabana Chatterjee
KOLKATA

Almost half of the cases kept under adjudication after the special intensive revision (SIR) of electoral rolls in West Bengal have now been settled, Chief Electoral Officer of West Bengal Manoj Kumar Agarwal said on Monday.

But the CEO did not specify how many of those cases were included in or excluded from the final voter list.

Before the list was published, Mr. Agarwal said that the whole process was centralised and that State officials do not have any additional information.

“At least 29 lakh cases have been disposed of till now [Monday evening]. That is what we can see on our dashboard. We do not have any information on how many have been included or how many left out,” the CEO said. Around 31 lakh cases are still pending.

Political reactions

The development has drawn sharp reactions from political parties. Trinamool Congress spokesperson Kunal Ghosh said, “No legal and genuine voter should be left out. If the Election Commission anticipates that the supple-



Long process: People waiting in a queue for special intensive revision hearing in Kolkata. Nearly 700 judges from West Bengal, Jharkhand, and Odisha have been hearing the cases. PTI

mentary voter list will cause law and order issues in the State, then they already know that people will be removed from the list without due cause.”

Mr. Ghosh further added that the poll panel has transferred several top police and administrative officials across the State after the election schedules were declared, and now, in case of any unforeseen situation, the EC would be responsible.

“In the name of SIR, what is happening in Bengal may cause a huge amount of disenfranchisement of voters,” veteran Congress leader Adhir Ranjan Chowdhury said.

The West Bengal CEO has asked the State Chief

Secretary to provide space where appellant tribunals can conduct their work and listen to people's appeals.

Hearing appeals

People who are excluded from the final voter list even after the hearing may appeal to the tribunal headed by former judges. The judges will hear their case and decide if they may be included in the list or not.

After months of the SIR process, the final voter list of West Bengal was published on February 28. It had 6.46 crore names, while 60 lakh names were kept under adjudication. The cases remained pending for 23 days even as pol-

itical parties traded barbs.

Around 700 judges from West Bengal, Jharkhand, and Odisha have been hearing the cases for the past three weeks.

Of the 1.6 crore people called for hearings, 1.3 crore were under the “logical discrepancy” category, and 32 lakh were classified as “unmapped” voters.

Earlier, when the draft voter list was published, 58 lakh people were removed under categories like deceased, absent, permanently shifted and duplicate. Around 5.5 lakh more were deleted when the final list was published.

West Bengal will go to the polls in two phases on April 23 and 29. The counting will be held on May 4.

Stage set for battle of the turncoats in high-stakes Dispur

Rahul Karmakar
GUWAHATI

The battle for the key Dispur constituency is turning out to be a contest of turncoats, amid a spate of defections ahead of the April 9 Assembly election.

Jayanta Kumar Das, who filed his nomination papers on Monday as an Independent after being denied ticket by the Bharatiya Janata Party, said, “I gave 35 years of my life to the party.” He is one of the senior-most leaders of the saffron party.

Congress candidate Mira Borthakur Goswami and BJP nominee Pradyut Bordoloi follow in political seniority.

Congress and BJP leaders switching parties ahead of the election have given rise to a hybrid term — ‘CongBJP’, specially used by Gen-Z to describe those who have crossed over. At least 30 leaders switched to the BJP after long stints in the Congress, including Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma.

“I came quietly to file my papers to avoid being heckled, attacked or slapped with a case. I am relieved after leaving the party of ‘CongBJP’ leaders, who are torturing people

Congress and BJP leaders switching parties ahead of the election have given rise to a hybrid term — ‘CongBJP’

with their brand of politics,” Mr. Das said.

He said he would soon form a new party, “Trinamool BJP”, and hoped to defeat his rivals with “both BJP and Congress in their DNA”.

‘Greed for power’

Ms. Goswami said she had her reasons to leave the “polarisation specialist” BJP in 2018. She said the people of Dispur would trust her more than Mr. Bordoloi, who secured the BJP ticket “overnight”.

“People do change parties, but his crossover was driven by greed for power,” she said, asserting that people would vote for her because of her consistent welfare work.

Mr. Bordoloi defended his decision to leave the Congress, dismissing claims that rebels would upset the BJP's appellation in Dispur. “I have been given the respect I lost toward the end of my time with the Congress,” he said.

INBRIEF



Did not seek bribe in Aryan Khan case: ex-NCB official

Former Narcotics Control Bureau (NCB) Zonal Director Sameer Wankhede on Monday informed the Bombay High Court that he did not demand a bribe from actor Shah Rukh Khan in connection with the 2021 Cordelia cruise ship drug case involving the actor's son, Aryan Khan. The submission was made during the hearing on Mr. Wankhede's petition seeking to quash a First Information Report (FIR) filed by the Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) against him and four others. The FIR which is based on a report by a Special Enquiry Team alleges a demand of ₹25 crore as bribe was made from those arrested in the cruise case, including Mr. Aryan Khan.

SC disposes of Wangchuk's pleas against NSA detention

The Supreme Court on Monday disposed of petitions filed by climate activist Sonam Wangchuk and his wife, Gitanjali J. Angmo, challenging his detention under the National Security Act (NSA) after being informed that he had been released from confinement on March 14. A Bench headed by Justice Aravind Kumar closed the case on Monday after multiple hearings that spanned over a month. The activist, represented by senior advocate Kapil Sibal, argued that malice on the part of authorities was at the bottom of his detention, which was evident from the fact that they chose to "hide" his public messages calling for peace after the protests seeking Statehood for Ladakh led to violence.

Greater cooperation needed between India and Russia, says Jaishankar

Kallol Bhattacharjee
NEW DELHI

Against the backdrop of the war in West Asia, External Affairs Minister S. Jaishankar on Monday said the "evolving multipolar order" calls for "greater cooperation" between India and Russia both bilaterally as well as multilaterally through groupings such as BRICS, SCO, G-20, and the United Nations.

Mr. Jaishankar addressed a conference on India-Russia relations through video link and said Delhi-Moscow relations over the past decades helped in advancing "regional and global peace" and stability. Speaking at the same event, Russian Foreign Minister Sergei Lavrov said India-Russia ties had "major significance" against the backdrop of the U.S.-Israel war on Iran and said



Foreign Minister S. Jaishankar with Russian counterpart Sergei Lavrov. FILE PHOTO

Russia was "looking forward" to hosting Prime Minister Narendra Modi for the India-Russia annual summit, 2026.

"India, during its BRICS chairmanship with a 'humanity first' and 'people-centric' approach looks forward to closely working with Russia to address shared challenges in a balanced and inclusive manner," Mr. Jaishankar said at

Centre launches AI skilling drive with Google, YouTube

Part of initiatives unveiled by Ashwini Vaishnaw to boost creative economy; a citizen creator platform, and in-built satellite tuners in television sets for access to DD Free Dish launched

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Union Minister Ashwini Vaishnaw on Monday unveiled three new initiatives aimed at strengthening India's media, broadcasting, and digital sector and promoting the "orange economy", or the creative economy.

The creative economy includes industries where economic value is generated primarily from creativity, culture, technology, and intellectual property.

The three initiatives are named the National AI Skilling Initiative in partnership with Google and YouTube through the Indian Institute of Creative Technologies (IICT); MyWAVES, a citizen creator platform on WAVES OTT; and the rollout of advanced Electronic Programme Guide and in-built satellite tuners in television sets for enhancing access to DD Free Dish services.

Key media and entertainment industry representatives, the head of YouTube India along with Senior Ministry officials took part in the event.

Underscoring Prime Minister Narendra Modi's vision of democratising tech-



Union Minister Ashwini Vaishnaw says the initiatives will make technology more affordable and accessible. SUSHIL KUMAR VERMA

nology, Mr. Vaishnaw said the initiatives will make technology more affordable and accessible. He said that with in-built satellite tuners and an advanced programme guide, citizens can now access content easily without additional equipment.

He described MyWAVES as a powerful platform for content creators, enabling them to create, upload, and share content.

Referring to the Union Budget announcements, he underlined the government's commitment to promoting the "orange economy" and supporting the creative sector.

The Union Minister said under the National AI Skilling Initiative, being implemented with the support of YouTube, about 15,000 youth will be trained without levying any fee.

He spoke about the "Creators' Corner" scheme and urged content creators to actively use Doordarshan and platforms such as MyWAVES to showcase India's rich culture and regional diversity.

Speaking about the partnership's impact, YouTube India managing director Gunjan Soni said: "We believe that AI has the potential to open up remarkable opportunities for India's

dynamic creative economy. Through our collaboration with the Ministry of Information & Broadcasting and IICT, we aim to equip creators and professionals with the skills required to master the tools of the future, leverage AI to tell more compelling stories... expand their reach to new audiences, and play a role in shaping the future of media."

The AI skilling programme will be conducted in two phases – Phase I from March 23 to June 30 2026, and Phase II from July to December 2026.

The first phase will focus on foundational AI learning at scale through Google Career Certificates and Google Cloud Generative AI learning paths. Participants will undergo courses such as AI Essentials, Prompting Essentials, Introduction to Generative AI, and Generative AI Leader Path.

The second phase will involve advanced, project-based specialisation for the creative industry. The curriculum will include modules on the art of storytelling, YouTube best practices, and advanced training using AI tools such as Gemini 3 and Vertex AI.

SC gives Centre four weeks to respond to plea against 'arbitrary' hikes in airfares

Krishnadas Rajagopal
NEW DELHI

The Supreme Court on Monday gave the government a four-week leeway to respond to a petition highlighting the need for accountability in the civil aviation sector for "arbitrary" airfare hikes and cancellations, saying "there are bigger problems the government is handling now", in an oblique reference to the potential blowbacks from the ongoing Iran-Israel conflict.

When the case came up for hearing before a Bench headed by Justice Vikram Nath, the government counsel said a draft response was being circulated, but "certain international events" had arisen in the meanwhile. The Bench advised the counsel ap-



The court gives leeway saying that "there are bigger problems the govt. is handling now".

pearing for petitioner, S. Laxminarayanan, to agree to an adjournment and listed the case for April 27.

The petition had sought regulatory intervention in the civil aviation sector to address fare fluctuation, fare transparency, and continuity of essential air services. It said the rollercoaster airfares resulted in

Centre to amend the Foreign Contribution (Regulation) Act

Vijaita Singh
NEW DELHI

The Union government is likely to amend the Foreign Contribution (Regulation) Act in the ongoing session of Parliament session. One of the key changes proposed is the appointment of a "designated authority" to take over, manage or dispose of assets created out of foreign funds by an NGO or association, which has had its FCRA registration suspended, cancelled, or not renewed.

Another proposed amendment is expanding the definition of "key functionary" of an NGO beyond an "office bearer/director" to include directors; partners; trustees; the *karta* (head) of a Hindu Undivided Family; office-bearers or members of the governing body or managing committee of a society, trust, trade union or association; and any other person who has control over or responsibility for the management or affairs of such an organisation.

The amendment also proposes to make key functionaries liable for offences under the FCRA.

Registration under the FCRA is mandatory for an NGO to receive foreign funds. Till now, the 2010 parent Act only had the

The Bill proposes to reduce the maximum imprisonment for FCRA offences from five years to one year

provision to regulate the flow of foreign funds, and not the statutory framework to manage the assets created out of such funds.

The Foreign Contribution (Regulation) Amendment Bill, 2026 also proposes to amend Section 43 of the parent Act, which will require any law enforcement agency or State government to seek prior approval of the Central government for initiation of investigation into FCRA-related complaints.

The Statement of Objects and Reasons of the Bill circulated by Home Minister Amit Shah said that, at present, around 16,000 associations are registered under the FCRA and they receive around ₹22,000 crore annually.

The Bill proposes to reduce the maximum imprisonment for FCRA offences from five years to one year. It also proposes fixed time-lines for the utilisation of foreign funds received under the "prior permission" category, unlike the open-ended provision under the 2010 Act.

Jinnah, Iqbal to be dropped from Jammu varsity syllabi

Peerzada Ashiq
SRINAGAR

The Jammu University's move to consider dropping topics on Pakistan founder Muhammad Ali Jinnah, educator Sir Syed Ahmad Khan and poet Mohammad Iqbal from the post-graduate Political Science programmes on Monday evoked sharp criticism from the ruling National Conference, and Peoples Democratic Party.

This move followed after protests by the Akhil Bharatiya Vidyarthi Parishad on Friday. The activists demanded that a chapter on Jinnah be dropped following which the university's departmental affairs committee (DAC) chaired a meeting on Sunday. A fresh meeting will be held today "to further deliberate on the matter."

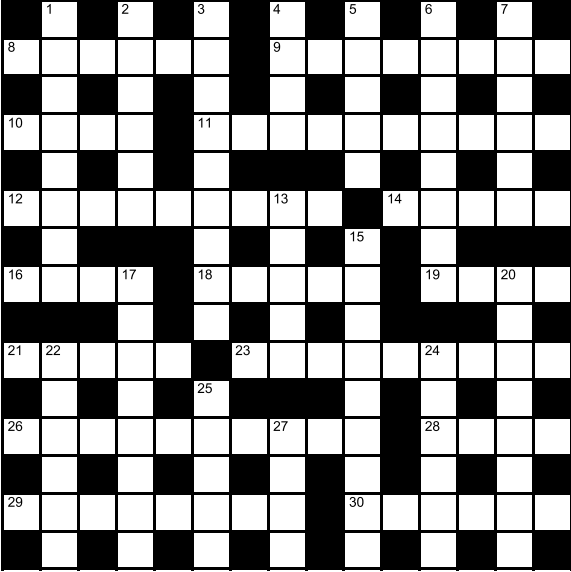


CROSSWORD+14749

(set by Crossant)

Solve this puzzle online and access more puzzles at <https://thehindu.com/crosswords>





Across

8 Dream about getting money, love, bit of sunshine and drink (6)

9 Guys practised after Australian Open (8)

10 Backstage issue? (4)

11 Toppers of the English League may have lost lead perhaps (5,5)

12 Essentially stuffy, air conditioned, vacant lobby (9)

14 Roll Back Support - Amazon's bestseller basically (5)

16 Initially trekked around 50 kilometres say (4)

18 Model appears without clothes daily (5)

19 Somewhat lucky I visited European city (4)

21 Money returned around beginning of previous month (5)

23 Came across poem about a virtual world (9)

26 One sees ad about earning money in Asian region (4,6)

28 Reduce high speed (4)

29 Indian ascetic, for example, assuming new name on a small island (8)

30 One about to enter a far-off land (6)

Down

1 Drink with a bit of rum - Mai Tai perhaps (3,5)

2 Saw boy standing behind (6)

3 Spooner's emergency officers getting coffee and cocoa perhaps (4,5)

4 Indian tribal leaving island returns once more (4)

5 Yankee largely happy in African country (5)

6 Dance - it's easy (8)

7 Say difficulty swallowing morsel eventually comes up in later years (3,3)

13 Vacant space behind leg slip (5)

15 Largest English Academy sporting official Government stamp (5,4)

17 King and knight leaving without queen for recreational activity perhaps (8)

20 Talent's not obvious, needs discerning insight to begin with (8)

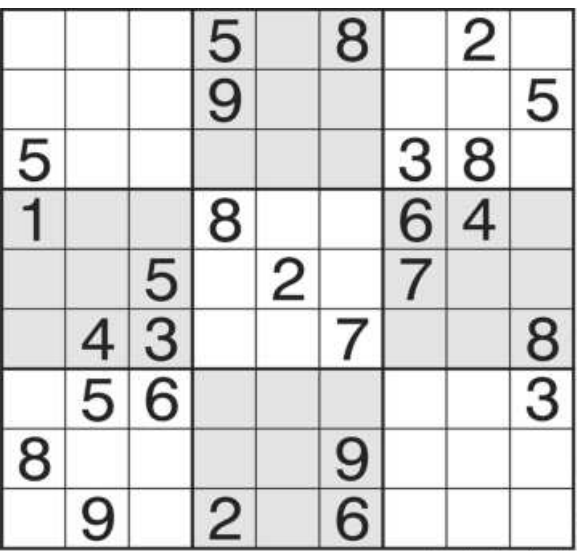
22 Alcaraz ditches car, cycles in extremely populous public squares in Spain (6)

24 Fiery McEnroe blowing his top once again (6)

25 Popular place for decorative work (5)

27 Plant inspectors review industrial safety primarily (4)

SUDOKU



DIFFICULTY RATING: ★★★★★

Solution to previous puzzle

W	O	N	D	E	R	B	A	R	R	E	D
E	D	A	S	T	I	O					
H	A	R	N	E	S	T	O	E	N	A	I
V	A	T	E	L	N	S					
R	E	D	G	R	A	N	I	T	E		
O	S						N	T			
H	I	N	D	I		H	A	N	D	G	R
E	D	A	T								
G	A	R	D	E	N	E	R				
R	E										
B	N	W	S								
E	S	A	N	N	L	S	A				
S	O	M	E								
U	R	D									
T	E	T	R	I	L						

Solution to yesterday's Sudoku

1	5	7	2	6	8	4	3	9
6	4	2	1	9	3	5	8	7
8	3	9	5	4	7	6	2	1
3	9	6	4	5	2	1	7	8
2	8	5	7	1	6	3	9	4
4	7	1	8	3	9	2	6	5
5	6	3	9	8	1	7	4	2
9	2	4	6	7	5	8	1	3
7	1	8	3	2	4	9	5	6

INBRIEF



Oil plunges after strikes on Iranian power plants put off

Oil prices plunged by more than 13% on Monday after U.S. President Donald Trump said he would postpone any military strikes against Iranian power plants for five days, hours ahead of a deadline that threatened further escalation in the conflict now in its fourth week. Brent crude futures traded at about \$104.1 a barrel, or down 7.2%, at 11.30 GMT after sliding as much as 15% to a session low of \$96 a barrel. REUTERS

Centre restores RoDTEP benefits for exporters

The government has restored the complete benefits provided to exporters under the Remission of Duties and Taxes on Exported Products (RoDTEP) scheme. In a notification it said the rates and values applicable on February 22 this year and were reduced by 50% are now being restored to earlier levels from February 23 to March 31. According to GTRI, while the DGFT decision is welcome, the initial reduction is hard to justify as RoDTEP is not a subsidy.

Avoid insinuations without any evidence, says SEBI chief

In the wake of the crisis at the HDFC Bank which was triggered by the sudden exit of Chairman Atanu Chakraborty, Securities and Exchange Board of India chairperson Tuhin Kanta Pandey said on Monday that insinuations without any evidence should be avoided. Speaking at a media briefing post the regulator's Q4 FY26 board meeting, Mr. Pandey highlighted the responsibilities of independent directors in matters of actual or suspected fraud.

SEBI board okays conflict of interest panel's key recommendations

Ashokamithran T.
MUMBAI

The Securities and Exchange Board of India (SEBI) has decided to approve key recommendations of the High Level Committee on Conflict of Interest.. According to the board, the recommendations include bringing the chairperson and whole time board members within the definition of an 'insider', establishing digital systems for conflict-of-interest management and a new office of ethics and compliance to oversee public issues. SEBI also recommended notifying separate regulations for board members and an oversight committee on ethics to oversee board members.



Ease of doing business: FPIs will now be allowed to settle funds on a net basis for stock market transactions. REUTERS

Another major regulatory change approved was to simplify 'fit and proper person' norms for intermediaries, which include depositories, clearing houses and exchanges. Accordingly, members of intermediaries would be disqualified only on conviction for eco-

nom ic offences or securities law violation. However, grounds for disqualification would also include offences involving moral turpitude. The board also decided Foreign Portfolio Investors (FPIs) will now be allowed to settle funds on a net ba-

sis for stock market transactions viz. payment for a stock FPIs buy would be adjusted against the proceeds of the stock it sells. Earlier, FPIs had to pay for the stock they bought in full and receive payment for the stocks they sold.

Cutting cost When FPI outflows had crossed ₹88,000 crore in March alone, SEBI Chairman Tuhin Kanta Pandey assured new FPI registrations continued in response to steps easing their operations and cutting cost. The board also reduced minimum investment value for social impact funds in Alternative Investment Funds to ₹1,000 from ₹2 lakh to boost retail participation.

Wipro expands footprint in South Korea

The Hindu Bureau
BENGALURU

Wipro announced the expansion of its business operations in South Korea. This would include: an enlarged office footprint in Seoul, unveiling a new Innovation Lab as part of the Wipro Innovation Network (WIN), and continued investment in local talent to support South Korean clients locally and globally. This reflected the growing importance of Korea in shaping global innovation and increasing demand from South Korean enterprises for AI-led transformation, said Wipro.

Local LPG output now at 50-60% of consumption requirement: official

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Local production of liquefied petroleum gas (LPG) is fulfilling about 50-60% of domestic demand, Sujata Sharma, Joint-Secretary at the Ministry of Petroleum and Natural Gas (MoPNG) told reporters at the daily inter-Ministerial briefing on West Asia situation. Responding to queries about the geographies India is procuring LPG from, Ms. Sharma held the country was picking up cargoes from wherever available. "We require a whole lot of LPG now, and because earlier 90% of our imports were coming from West



Earlier 90% LPG was from West Asia, Ms. Sharma said.

Asia," she stated. The senior official emphasised domestic LPG supplies were 'normal as before.' "Panic bookings, which peaked to 88 lakh, has come down to about 50 lakhs. So, it has come to

normal," she said. **Migration to PNG** She said about 1.90 lakh consumers had migrated from LPG to PNG. Cumulatively more than 3.5 lakh domestic and commercial PNG connections had been issued or activated in the first three weeks of March. For perspective, amid the escalating tensions, the Union Government had been encouraging for a transition to piped natural gas (PNG) from the cooking gas cylinders. **'Techno-commercial'** On India potentially tapping into market for Iranian crude oil, she held, "I

Lok Sabha sends Corporate Law Amendment Bill 2026 to JPC

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

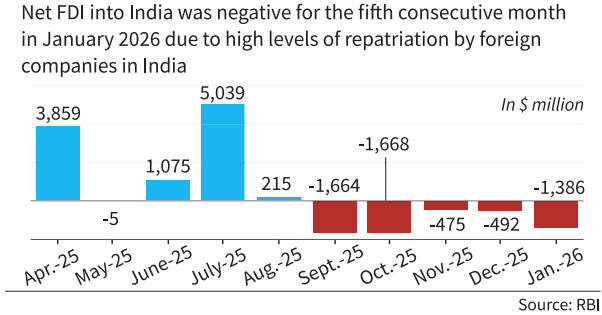
The government introduced the Corporate Laws (Amendment) Bill, 2026 in the Lok Sabha following which the House adopted a motion to send the proposed legislation to a Joint Parliamentary Committee (JPC) for detailed examination. The JPC will comprise members from both Houses of Parliament for detailed analysis and recommendations, Union Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman said while proposing the motion for JPC reference. The motion was adopted by a voice vote. The Bill seeks further amendments to the Limited Liability Partnership



Nirmala Sitharaman

Act, 2008 and the Companies Act, 2013 to facilitate ease of doing business and address the gaps identified by the Company Law Committee in its 2022 report. The proposed amendments are expected to rationalise penalties, shift several minor procedural lapses from criminal liability

Flowing out



Net FDI negative for fifth straight month

T.C.A. Sharad Raghavan
NEW DELHI

Net FDI into India contracted for the fifth consecutive month in January 2026, with outflows exceeding inflows by nearly \$1.4 billion, a three-month high. The data shows this was because inflows into India fell nearly 7% while the amount repatriated out of the country nearly doubled. According to data released by the Reserve Bank of India on Monday as part of its monthly bulletin, the total amount of money entering India as direct investment, or gross FDI, stood at about \$5.7 billion in January 2026. This was 7% lower than in January last year, and only two-thirds of the amount that came in December 2025. The RBI, however, looked at a longer time period to draw some positive conclusions. Last week, gold had dropped ₹13,974, or 8.82%, to close at around ₹1.44 lakh per 10 grams in the domestic market. Globally, gold futures for the April contract depreciated \$474.9, or 10.4%, to hit an intraday low of \$4,100 per ounce.

ceived the highest share of equity inflows, followed by computer services, electricity and other energy, and financial services – these sectors together accounted for over 60% of total inflows." With regard to outflows, the outward FDI by Indian companies increased by 5.4% in January 2026 to \$2.1 billion. This was, however, nearly 30% lower than the outward FDI in December 2025. "Around 75% of the outward FDI flows were directed to the U.S., Singapore, the UK, and the UAE during the [April 2025 - January 2026] period," the RBI said. Repatriation and disinvestment by foreign companies doing business in India, on the other hand, increased by 97.3% to \$4.9 billion in January 2026. But this was nearly 18% lower than the amount in December 2025. As a result, net FDI stood at about -\$1.4 billion, the lowest since October 2025. The central bank noted that portfolio investments again flowed out more than they flowed in in March this year.

ROME

Setback to Meloni as Italian voters reject plans to overhaul judiciary



Italian Prime Minister Giorgia Meloni conceded defeat on Monday in a referendum on justice reform with the “No” camp securing 54% of the vote. The referendum aimed to separate the role of prosecutors, judges, and change their oversight body to ensure impartiality. But critics say it attempts to exert control over independent judges. AFP

ISLAMABAD

Pakistan vows to root out terrorism as Afghan Taliban truce nears end



Pakistan’s Foreign Minister Ishaq Dar said on Monday that the country remains committed to “eradicating the menace of terrorism”, as the clock ticked down to the end of a temporary ceasefire with Afghanistan. Both countries last Wednesday agreed to a temporary ceasefire until midnight on Monday. AFP

WASHINGTON

Statue of Christopher Columbus installed on White House grounds



The White House installed on its grounds a statue of Christopher Columbus in a bid by Trump administration to reshape depictions of U.S. history. During the 2020 Black Lives Matter protests, many U.S. cities took down statues of the Italian navigator, whose voyages paved the way for Europe’s conquests of the Americas. REUTERS

LJUBLJANA

Slovenia headed towards coalition talks after tight election outcome



Slovenia’s President urged parties to start talks on forming a new government after a parliamentary poll ended with no winner. Prime Minister Robert Golob’s Freedom Movement party (28.6%) and the Slovenian Democratic Party led by ex-Prime Minister Janez Jansa (28.2%) failed to secure enough seats needed for a majority. AP

Gulf nations targeted in new attacks; Iran threatens to mine access routes

Israel launches new attacks on Iranian capital, saying it has ‘begun a wide-scale wave of strikes’ on infrastructure targets; Persian Gulf countries Saudi Arabia, the UAE respond to ‘incoming missile threats’; Bahrain urges public to seek shelter

Agence France-Presse
RIYADH/DUBAI

Saudi Arabia and the United Arab Emirates reported coming under fresh attacks on Monday morning, with explosions and sirens sounding over the oil-rich Gulf. The Saudi Defence Ministry said it had detected two incoming ballistic missiles targeting the capital on Monday, “one of which was intercepted and the other fell in an uninhabited area”. The UAE Defence Ministry said it was “currently responding to incoming missile and drone threats from Iran”, explaining “the sounds heard are the result of the Air Defence Systems



War fallout: An excavator clears rubble from destroyed buildings in Tehran. Explosions were heard in the Iranian capital on Monday. AFP

intercepting missiles and drones”. Israel also launched new attacks on Monday on the Iranian capital, saying it had “begun a wide-scale wave of strikes” on infrastructure targets in Tehran

without immediately elaborating. Explosions were heard in multiple locations in the afternoon. Iran warned that it would lay mines to all access routes in the Gulf waters.

“Any attempt by the enemy to target Iran’s coasts or islands will, naturally and in accordance with established military practice, lead to the mining of all access routes ... in the Persian Gulf and along the coasts,” Iran’s Defense Council said in a statement.

Strait subject to risk The widespread use of mines could imperil not only military vessels but scores of commercial ships waiting to pass through the Strait of Hormuz, and a cleanup would last long after the conflict ends. In Abu Dhabi, authorities reported an Indian national had been wounded by falling debris from an

intercepted ballistic missile. Sirens were sounding in Bahrain, with residents instructed to seek shelter. “Citizens and residents are urged to remain calm and head to the nearest safe place,” the Interior Ministry posted on social media. Gulf nations that have long billed themselves as oases of safety and stability in the region have been drawn into the West Asia war as Iran retaliates against U.S.-Israeli strikes. The Islamic republic has taken aim at U.S. assets as well as civilian infrastructure, including landmarks, airports, ports and oil facilities around the Gulf. (With inputs from Associated Press)

Runway collision kills two pilots at New York airport

Agence France-Presse
NEW YORK

A plane carrying dozens of people collided with a fire truck on a runway at New York’s LaGuardia airport, killing the pilot and co-pilot and causing “serious injuries” to others, authorities said on Monday. Due to the crash late on Sunday, U.S. aviation authorities halted all flights at LaGuardia, and the port authority said the airport would stay shut until at least 2:00 p.m. (18:00 GMT) “to allow for a thorough investigation.” The closure follows the collision that left the Air Canada Express plane tilted back on its tail on the tarmac with a smashed cockpit. The pilot and co-pilot were killed in the crash, Kathryn Garcia, the head



An Air Canada Express plane sits on the runway after colliding with a fire truck at LaGuardia Airport in New York on Monday. AFP

of the city’s port authority, said at a press conference. Forty-one people were taken to the hospital, some with “serious injuries,” though 32 have since been released, Ms. Garcia said. The port authority said the aircraft operated by Jazz Aviation, a regional partner of Air Canada, struck one of its firefighting trucks on Runway 4 at around 11:40 p.m. on Sunday as the vehicle drove to a separate incident. Jazz Aviation said the crash involved a CRJ-900 aircraft that had flown into LaGuardia from Montreal as flight AC8646. Emergency response protocols had been “immediately activated,” it said. A preliminary passenger list showed 76 people on board the flight, including four crew members.

Up in the air



An aerial view shows hot air balloons decorated with traditional motifs before their launch during the annual hot air balloon festival held to celebrate Id-ul-Fitr, which marks the end of the Islamic holy fasting month of Ramzan in Wonosobo, Central Java on Monday. AFP

IEA chief warns oil shock worse than 1970s crises

Associated Press
WELLINGTON

The head of the International Energy Agency (IEA) said on Monday that the global economy faces a “major, major threat” because of the Iran war. “No country will be immune to the effects of this crisis if it continues to go in this direction,” Fatih Birol said at Australia’s National Press Club in Canberra on Monday. The crisis in West Asia, he said, has had a worse impact on oil than the two oil shocks of the 1970s

combined, and a worse effect on gas than the Russia-Ukraine war. One major fear is that the war could knock out oil and gas production in West Asia for a long time, which would mean high prices could last a while and cause inflation to rip higher around the world. The U.S. stock market has a history of bouncing back relatively quickly from past conflicts in West Asia and elsewhere, as long as oil prices do not stay too high for too long. The oil crises of 1973 and 1979, he said, lost to-



Fatih Birol

gether 10 million barrels per day, causing “major economic problems around the world, the recessions. And today, only as of today, we lost 11 mil-

lion barrels per day – so more than two major oil shocks put together.” **Growing shortage** After Russia’s invasion of Ukraine, he said, the gas markets, especially in Europe, “lost about 75 billion cubic meters, 75BCM. And as of now, as a result of this crisis, we lost about 140BCM, almost twice (as much).” Mr. Birol said 40 energy assets in nine countries across the region were “severely or very severely damaged.” “Some of the vital arteries of the global economy, such as petrochemical, such as fertilizers, such as sulfur, such as helium – their trade is all interrupted, which would have serious consequences for the global economy,” he said. He said the International Energy Agency, “in order to comfort the markets,” earlier released 400 million barrels of oil, “which is historic. We have never released so much oil to the markets. ... The single most important solution to this problem is opening up the Hormuz Strait as things stand now.”

Taiwan Opposition leader says talks with Xi a ‘bridge’ to peace

Agence France-Presse
TAIPEI

The leader of Taiwan’s largest Opposition party said on Monday she hoped to meet Chinese President Xi Jinping and build a “bridge” to resolve disputes between China and the democratic island, which Beijing has threatened to seize by force. Kuomintang (KMT) chairwoman Cheng Li-wun, who has been a strident critic of President Lai Ching-te’s government, has insisted on meeting Mr. Xi before she makes an official trip to the United States. While the KMT has long supported closer ties with Beijing, Ms. Cheng has been accused by Mr. Lai’s Democratic Progressive Party (DPP) of doing Beijing’s bidding by stalling the government’s defence spending plans.

There are concerns inside the KMT that a Cheng-Xi meeting could trigger a voter backlash in Taiwan’s district elections later this year. But speaking to foreign media on Monday, Ms. Cheng said talks with Mr. Xi would carry “significant symbolic meaning” and could be a “foundation” to peaceful relations across the Taiwan Strait. “I do not believe a single meeting can resolve all the issues that have been accumulating for nearly a century,” Ms. Cheng said. “But... I hope I can successfully build such a bridge.” While the KMT has supported having stronger defences, Ms. Cheng said more military spending alone would not achieve peace with China. “There must also be political efforts. Political efforts are... the key,” Ms. Cheng said.

North Korea’s Kim reappointed as President of state affairs: state media

Agence France-Presse
SEOUL

North Korea’s rubber-stamp legislature has re-elected Kim Jong-un as President of state affairs, state media reported on Monday. Mr. Kim’s reappointment as head of the authoritarian nation’s highest policy-making and governing body, the State Affairs Commission, was announced by KCNA. Critics argue that elections in North Korea are pre-determined and designed to give the country’s leadership a veneer of democratic legitimacy. “The Supreme People’s Assembly of the DPRK re-elected Comrade Kim Jong-un as President of the State Affairs of the Democratic People’s Republic of Korea at the First Session, the first state affairs activity of its 15th term, on March 22,” KCNA reported. The report said the deci-



Hall of power: The first session of the 15th Supreme People’s Assembly in progress at Mansudae Assembly Hall in Pyongyang. AFP

sion to re-elect Mr. Kim to the “top post” reflected “the unanimous will and desire of all the Korean people”. Mr. Kim is the third-generation ruler of the nuclear-armed state founded by his grandfather Kim Il-Sung in 1948. He has ruled the country since his father’s death in 2011. The election is a “highly choreographed event with a pre-determined outcome”, said Lee Horyung of the Korea Institute for

Defense Analyses. **‘Anachronistic’ Japan** Meanwhile, Kim Yo-Jong, the powerful sister of the North Korean leader, said on Monday a summit between her brother and Japanese Prime Minister Sanae Takaichi will not happen if Japan sticks to “its anachronistic” approach. Ms. Kim Yo-Jong’s statement came after Ms. Takaiichi told reporters last week that she had informed U.S. President Donald Trump

during a summit in Washington that she had “a very strong desire” to meet Mr. Kim. “But this is not the one that comes true, as wanted or decided by Japan,” Ms. Kim Yo-Jong said. “In order for the meet, Japan should first be determined to break with its anachronistic practice and habit.” Ms. Kim Yo-Jong, who is also a senior official, did not explicitly say what Japan’s “anachronistic practice and habit” are. However, in 2024, she said in a statement that North Korea’s acceptance of a reported offer for a meeting by one of Ms. Takaichi’s predecessors would depend on Japan tolerating the North’s nuclear weapons programme and ignoring its past abductions of Japanese nationals. The meeting eventually did not occur. (With inputs from Associated Press)



TELANGANA CO-OPERATIVE MARKETING FEDERATION LTD.
Email: proc.tsmarkfed2018@gmail.com, Ph.No: 040-2460 7108
Rc.No.P&M/Disposal of Maize/2025-26 Date: 23.03.2026

TENDER NOTIFICATION FOR GODOWN-WISE ONLINE E-AUCTION FOR THE SALE OF MAIZE VANAKALAM 2025-26 PROCURED BY TG MARKFED.
Tender notification for godown wise online e-auctions on disposal of Maize Vanakalam 2025-26 procured by TG MARKFED for the quantity of 3,77,669 MTs without a base price through e-procurement.telangana.gov.in or <https://auction.telangana.gov.in/> i.e. Telangana e-procurement (Applications in e-procurement portal will be available from 24.03.2026AM). 1. Online e-auction-I starts on dated 01.04.2026, from 10:30 AM to 12:00 AM. 2. Online e-auction -II starts on dated 01.04.2026, from 12:00 PM to 01:30 PM. 3. Online e-auction-III starts on dated 01.04.2026, from 01:30 PM to 03:00 PM. 4. Online e-auction - IV starts on dated 01.04.2026, from 03:00 PM to 04:30 PM. For online registration and further technical support please contact Service providers Mobile No: 7337445545 / 6309339690 / 7337445546/9912756216. For further details please contact Ph: 7288979806 and 7288979829.
DIPR R.O.No.17447-PPCL/ADVT/1/2025-26 Dt. 23.03.2026 Sd/- Managing Director



RAICHUR POWER CORPORATION LTD.
(Yermarus Thermal Power Station)
(Joint venture of KPCL and BHEL)
CIN : U40101KA2009PLC049582

No: KPCL/2025-26/AUCTION 134 Dated: 16.03.2026

SHORT TERM AUCTION NOTIFICATION
RPCL invites auction through GoK e-procurement portal www.kppp.karnataka.gov.in under “Auction” category for **Sale of Mill Reject Waste Coal (MRWC) for a period of Two years excluding monsoon period. EMD: Rs.13,20,345/-**. Last date & time for submission of the query: 26.03.2026 upto 17:30 hrs. Further details can be had from office of the **Executive Engineer (M-2)**, RPCL/ YTPS, Yermarus - 584 134, Raichur Dist., Karnataka. Mobile: +91 82775 02840.



**GOVERNMENT OF ANDHRA PRADESH
ROADS & BUILDINGS DEPARTMENT**

INVITATION FOR BIDS
IFB.No.1/ENC(R&B) MDR&NDB/PIU/2025-26 Dt:16-03-2026.

1. Online Bids are invited from eligible individual consultants for appointment as (1) **Finance Management Expert** & (2) **Environmental Expert** in the Project Implementation Unit (PIU) for the **APBRBP** and **APMCRCIP** projects, implemented with loan assistance from the **New Development Bank (NDB)**.
2. The Request for Proposal (RFP) document can be downloaded from the Central e-procurement place i.e., “<https://eprocure.gov.in/eprocure/app/>” from **25.03.2026 from 3.00 PM** onwards. The last date and time of submission of bids is on or before **24.04.2026 up to 3.00 PM**.
3. Further details can be seen on Central e-procurement market place i.e., “<https://eprocure.gov.in/eprocure/app/>”
DIPR 4928BP/CL, Dt:23/03/2026 Sd/- for Engineer-in-Chief (R&B), MDR & NDB

ROLE CLARITY

Rahul will open the batting, says Delhi Capitals captain Axar



FILE PHOTO: SHIV KUMAR PUSHAKAR

Delhi Capitals captain Axar Patel said that the versatile K.L. Rahul will open the batting in the upcoming IPL season. “Last year, Rahul was playing in the middle-order because of our team combination. He has always been good in the opening slot, he has hit a lot of runs. I think we will keep him as an opener,” said Axar on Monday.

TOUGH LUCK

Disappointed to lose a player of Curran’s calibre: Sangakkara



AP

RR head coach Kumar Sangakkara expressed disappointment at Sam Curran missing IPL 2026. “We are disappointed to lose a player of Sam’s calibre so close to the start of the season. Sam brings immense value with both bat and ball. However, we are pleased to have found an ideal replacement in Dasun Shanaka,” he added.

READY TO FIRE

Fit-and-raring Rohit will really take it on in IPL 2026, reckons Ashwin



FILE PHOTO: R.V. MOORTHY

I think this is going to be a season where Rohit (Sharma) will really take it on. He is getting enough breaks. His mind is fresh. He is physically in a good space. He looks really fit. This could well be a season where Rohit is going to bring back his T20 batting in the IPL — R. Ashwin.

CELEBRATORY MOOD

Gujarat Titans sets the tone for the season ahead in a gala event



VIJAY SONEJI

Gujarat Titans set the tone for the upcoming IPL season as its players, staff, franchise owners, partners and fans came together for ‘Shubharambh 2026’, a gala event in Ahmedabad on Monday. Shubman Gill, the team’s captain, was recognised keeping in mind the broader narrative of consistency, growth, and ambition.



Distinguished career: Thyagarajan joined *The Hindu* on June 6, 1962, rose through the ranks, and retired as the Deputy Sports Editor on December 21, 2013. THE HINDU ARCHIVES

S. Thyagarajan, doyen of sports journalism, passes away

Sports Bureau
CHENNAI

S. Thyagarajan, 85, veteran sports correspondent, who worked with *The Hindu* for more than five decades, passed away here on Monday.

A multi-sport writer, who eventually specialised in covering hockey, Thyagarajan, “Thyagu Sir” for many, was the spine that held *The Hindu’s* sports department together for many years.

He joined the organisation on June 6, 1962, rose through the ranks, and retired as the Deputy Sports Editor on December 21, 2013. For an additional year, he also worked as a consultant with *The Hindu* Group. Through his career, he wrote extensively in *The Hindu* and *Sportstar*.

Known for an alliterative style, Thyagarajan weighed his words, and reported sport, ranging from the hyper-local to the Olympics, with accuracy. He was a regular presence in most press boxes across the globe, and always ready with a quick repartee.

Having reported multiple Olympics and Asian Games, he also covered almost all hockey matches that involved India for decades. His analysis had depth and his criticism was always linked to the sport and the way it was played, and never got personal. Right from the junior athlete to a champion like



S. Thyagarajan.

Dhanraj Pillay, from a local club official to senior sports administrators, Thyagarajan’s connections spanned a wide range and in all these circles, he was held in high regard.

Even after retirement, he kept a watch on *The Hindu’s* sports pages. If he liked a feature or report, he would text a warm message. And if there was a new byline, he would be curious to know about the writer. Accessible and a fount of innumerable anecdotes, he would often delve into the past and recount tales with gusto.

Thyagarajan is survived by wife and two daughters. Hockey India, the Sports Journalists Federation of India (SJFI) and the Tamil Nadu Sports Journalists Association (TNSJA) condoled his demise. He was the SJFI president in the 1990s. Thyagarajan was also one of the founding members of the TNSJA and served honourably as its president.

SNAPSHOTS

Arundhati, Farhan win ICC Player-of-the-Month awards for February
India medium-pacer Arundhati Reddy won the ICC Player of the Month (women) award for her fine performances in the T20I series in Australia. Pakistan opener Sahibzada Farhan bagged the men’s award for his record-breaking show in the T20 World Cup.



Arundhati.
FILE PHOTO: NIRMAL HARINDRAN

Stokes and McCullum to remain in charge
England coach Brendon McCullum will keep his job despite the team’s Ashes debacle, with cricket chief Richard Gould insisting he can “adapt and evolve”. The

ECB promised a “thorough review” after Ben Stokes’ team was demolished 1-4 on its five-Test tour of Australia. Captain Stokes, McCullum, and England managing director of men’s cricket Rob Key will all keep their jobs.

Playing with ‘defending champion’ tag the biggest challenge for RCB

Kohli headlines a formidable batting unit; uncertainty over the availability of Hazlewood and Dayal a concern in the pace-bowling department

IPL-19 COUNTDOWN

Royal Challengers Bengaluru

OVERALL NUMBERS

M

W

L

NR

271

134

133

4

BY OPPONENT

	M	W	L	NR
CSK	35	13	21	1
DC	33	20	12	1
GT	6	3	3	0
KKR	35	15	20	0
LSG	6	4	2	0
MI	34	15	19	0
PBKS	37	19	18	0
RR	33	17	14	2
SRH	25	11	14	0

Royal Challengers’ remaining matches were against Deccan Chargers (11), GL (5), PWI (5), RPS (4) and KTK (2)

RCB’S 2026 LEAGUE CAMPAIGN*

March 28	vs. SRH	Bengaluru	7.30 p.m.
April 5	vs. CSK	Bengaluru	7.30 p.m.
April 10	vs. RR	Guwahati	7.30 p.m.
April 12	vs. MI	Mumbai	7.30 p.m.

*announced so far

JACOB BETHELL

MIRACLE MAN

Jacob Bethell: A breathtaking 48-ball 105 from Bethell nearly helped England pull off an impossible chase against India in the T20 World Cup semifinal earlier this month. The knock showcased Bethell’s immense value in the shortest format. The 22-year-old played only two games for RCB last season, but the southpaw is primed to lead RCB’s PowerPlay charge this year.

THE SQUAD

Rajat Patidar (Capt.), Jordan Cox, Tim David, Virat Kohli, Devdutt Padikkal, Phil Salt, Jitesh Sharma, Jacob Bethell, Kanishk Chouhan, Venkatesh Iyer, Vihaan Malhotra, Mangesh Yadav, Krunal Pandya, Romario Shepherd, Abhinandan Singh, Satvik Deswal, Jacob Duffy, Josh Hazlewood, Bhuvneshwar Kumar, Vicky Ostwal, Rasikh Salam, Suyash Sharma, Swapnil Singh, Yash Dayal, and Nuwan Thushara.

COMPILED BY G. PRASAD & ASHWIN ACHAL



The King takes strike again: Kohli will look to get going at the top for the Bengaluru outfit. K. MURALI KUMAR

Ashwin Achal

Royal Challengers Bengaluru (RCB) steps into new territory with the start of IPL 2026. Having been the nearly men for the longest period, RCB now enters the arena wearing the coveted tag of ‘defending champion.’

Unsurprisingly, RCB found no good reason to tinker with the proven template which led to the title last season. The majority of the squad has been

retained while there has been a couple of notable inclusions — all-rounder Venkatesh Iyer and pacer Jacob Duffy — from the auction.

Strong middle-order

The side boasts of a powerful batting line-up, capable of maximising friendly home conditions at the M. Chinnaswamy Stadium. The depth in batting poses some welcome selection challenges for the team management.

Fan favourite Virat Kohli

is a shoe-in as opener, with Phil Salt and Jacob Bethell in the race to take up the second slot. Captain Rajat Patidar, Devdutt Padikkal and Tim David form a strong middle-order. Patidar did not find form in the recent domestic season, and needs a quick turnaround when he puts on IPL colours.

It is a toss-up between Padikkal and Venkatesh for a spot in the eleven. Venkatesh does offer an additional bowling option, but with the impact player likely to

be spinner Suyash Sharma, this may not tilt the scales in his favour.

Hometown batter Padikkal, meanwhile, has been in fine form for Karnataka in recent months.

Jitesh’s crucial role

Jitesh Sharma, who came into his own in the previous IPL season, is a crucial presence as finisher and wicketkeeper. Romario Shepherd, Krunal Pandya and David can provide the fireworks in the death overs.

EBFC puts seven past Mohammedan

Amitabha Das Sharma
KOLKATA

East Bengal FC returned to winning ways with a commanding 7-0 victory over a 10-man Mohammedan Sporting Club in their ISL-12 encounter at the Salt Lake Stadium here on Monday.

Mohammedan Sporting struggled to cope with East Bengal’s attacking intensity, and its defensive weaknesses were quickly exposed. The pressure resulted in three penalties as Sporting defenders repeatedly faltered inside the box.

East Bengal moved up to fourth spot with 11 points from six matches while Mohammedan Sporting remained rooted to the bottom without a point.

The result: East Bengal FC 7 (Anwar 7, 78, Ezzejjari 13-pen, 54-pen, Crespo 37-pen, Vishnu 74, Nandhakumar 90+3) bt Mohammedan Sporting 0.

‘I had no option other than pulling out of Candidates’

C. Shyam Sundar
CHENNAI

India’s top player Koneru Humpy said that she didn’t have an option to explore for competing in the FIDE Women’s Candidates tournament, scheduled in Cyprus from Saturday.

Having made the decision to pull out of the eight-player event on Sunday, Humpy stressed that she had no choice but to do so. “After having prepared so hard for the tournament, it was a tough call. I didn’t have a choice, I had to withdraw,” Humpy, who had safety concerns in the wake of the situation in West Asia given Cyprus’ proximity to the conflict zone, told *The Hindu* on Monday.

“If it was held in some safe country, why would I do that (withdraw)?” the Grandmaster asked, adding that the FIDE could have postponed the tour-



Humpy isn’t worried about being penalised by FIDE. PTI

nament. Humpy is unfazed about the possibility of being penalised for choosing not to play in the marquee competition. “I am not worried about fines... they don’t stop me from speaking out or expressing what I feel,” Humpy didn’t mince words.

She said that it wouldn’t be “pleasant” to play an event in West Asia when there is so much happening there. “Many sporting events are getting cancelled. A poker tournament which was supposed to be

The FIDE is the only body which is hosting a tournament now. They are saying that it is safe... that is the problem

held in Cyprus from April 25 has been cancelled. So, it makes sense to postpone it (Candidates). Or if you want to hold it on the exact dates, you have to shift to another country.

“The FIDE is the only body which is hosting a tournament now. They are saying that it is safe... that is the problem,” Humpy, who has been replaced by Anna Muzychuk in the Candidates, said. “Actually, I took time so that I could make the right decision because I know it’s a very important tournament. But at the end of the day, it’s important to take care of my family first.”

Nominees for HI awards announced

Sports Bureau
NEW DELHI

The eighth annual Hockey India awards will be held here on Friday to recognise and reward outstanding performances during the 2025 season.

The nominations were announced on Monday. The men’s team dominated most of the categories except those that had separate sections for men and women, in line with the National team’s performances through the last year. Hardik Singh, Sukhjeet Singh, Sanjay and Abhishek are nominated for male Player-of-the-Year, while Navneet Kaur, Salima Tete, Lalremisiami and Savita Punia will vie for honours in the women’s section.

Hardik, Sukhjeet, Sanjay and Navneet have been nominated in multiple categories. Prince Deep Singh has been nominated for both the goalkeeper and

Upcoming
Player-of-the-Year.

The event will also have special recognitions for Outstanding Achievement and Umpire/Umpire Manager-of-the-Year, among others. Asia Cup-winning men’s team and the bronze medallist Junior men’s team will be felicitated during the function.

The nominees: Player (men): Hardik Singh, Sukhjeet Singh, Sanjay, Abhishek; **Player (women):** Navneet Kaur, Salima Tete, Lalremisiami, Savita Punia; **Goalkeeper:** Prince Deep Singh, Krishan Bahadur Pathak, Bichu Devi Kharibam, Suraj Karkera; **Defender:** Sanjay, Amit Rohidas, Jugraj Singh, Harmanpreet Singh. **Midfielder:** Hardik Singh, Sumit, Raj Kumar Pal, Nilakanta Sharma; **Forward:** Sukhjeet Singh, Abhishek, Navneet Kaur, Shilinand Lakra; **Upcoming Player (men):** Prince Deep Singh, Manmeet Singh, Anmol Ekka, Arshdeep Singh; **Upcoming Player (women):** Sakshi Rana, Jyoti Singh, Sunelita Toppo, Kanika Siwah.

INBRIEF



Man City trumps Arsenal for League Cup honours

Pep Guardiola hailed Manchester City’s 2-0 win against Arsenal in the League Cup final as a “special” moment after a difficult period that threatened to derail its season. Nico O’Reilly capitalised on a blunder from Arsenal goalkeeper Kepa Arrizabalaga to head City’s second-half opener and he struck again moments later.

The result: Final: Arsenal 0 lost to Manchester City 2 (O’Reilly 60, 64).

Indian archers progress in Asia Cup Stage-1 tournament

Sukhchain Singh and Devaang Gupta (recurve men) and Chikitha Taniparthi, Raj Kaur, Tejal Salve and Swati Dudhwal (compound women) made the individual pre-quarterfinals in the Asia Cup Stage-1 archery in Bangkok on Monday.

Qualification round: Recurve: Men: Devaang Gupta (third, 613), Sukhchain Singh (eighth, 657). **Compound: Women:** Chikitha Taniparthi (fourth, 697), Raj Kaur (fifth, 695).

SDAT-Dolphin Swimming Academy’s camp from today

The SDAT-Dolphin Swimming Academy will conduct a two-month long summer camp from Tuesday as part of a talent-identification initiative under the Mission Olympic Scheme. Contact: 94449 06878, 94449 55878, 044-26534211.

ENGAGEMENTS

Cricket: TNCA 1 div. league, MRC-A vs. Globe Trotters (A.M. Jain); Nelson SC vs Alwarpet (Wahe Guru-A); Jolly Rovers vs. Sea Hawks (Tagore); Singam Puli vs. Vijay (Guru Nanak); Grand Slam vs. Young Stars (SRMC, turf); SKM vs. Jupiter SC (Viveka-nanda), day two, 9.30 a.m.

Vimal’s century puts Rovers in command against Sea Hawks

The left-hander adds 116 with Andre for the fourth wicket as the team reaches 300 for six; Sasidharan strikes back after the Ganesh-Rahil show

TNCA FIRST DIVISION

Sports Bureau
CHENNAI

R. Vimal Khumar (133 batting, 263b, 10x4, 1x6) and C. Andre Siddarth (64) added 116 for the fourth wicket to put Jolly Rovers in command against Sea Hawks on the first day of the TNCA first division league at the Tagore Medical College ground on Monday. Rovers ended the day at 300 for six.

Left-arm spinners M. Ganesh Moorthi (five for 19) and Rahil Shah (four for 40) helped SKM CC skittle out Jupiter CC for 106 in its first innings at the RKM Vivekananda ground.

Exciting contest However, Jupiter’s left-arm twaker R. Sasidharan returned figures of eight for 49 as SKM was bowled out for 105, thereby securing his team a crucial one-run first-innings lead.

The scores:
At A.M. Jain: Globe Trotters 151 in 66.1 overs (A.B. Dhiyash 31, P. Saravana Kumar 4/33, Bhargav Bhatt 3/13) vs. MRC ‘A’ 74/2 in 16 overs (S.R. Athish 38 batting).
Toss: MRC ‘A’
At Wahe Guru-A: Alwarpet 136 in 42.4 overs (Manav Parakh 39, Parth Bhut 31, Shoab Mohd. Khan 5/55) vs. Nelson 140/6 in 45



Vimal (Rovers, 133 batting); Sasidharan (Jupiter, 8/49).



Ganesh (SKM, 5/19); Shoab (Nelson, 5/55).

overs (Shivam Singh 48, P. Vidyut 4/41).
Toss: Alwarpet.
At Tagore: Jolly Rovers 300/6 in 92 overs (R. Vimal Khumar 133 batting, B. Indrajith 49, C. Andre Siddarth 64) vs. Sea Hawks.
Toss: Rovers.
At Guru Nanak: Singam Puli 223 in 81.5 overs (K. Aashiq 44, Ch. Jitendra Kumar 35, U. Mukilesh 63, M. Affan Khader 30, A. Aswin Crist 3/36, S. Mohamed Ali 3/26) vs. Vijay.
Toss: Vijay.

Vinicius-inspired Real edges Atletico; Inter slips at Fiorentina

Agencies
MADRID

Vinicius Junior struck twice as Real Madrid shaded Atletico Madrid 3-2 in a thrilling derby on Sunday to stay on Barcelona’s tail at the top of LaLiga.

After the Catalan giant edged Rayo Vallecano 1-0, Real ensured the gap to the defending champion stayed at four points by

beating Diego Simeone’s side. In the Serie A, Inter Milan drew 1-1 at Fiorentina, as Cher Ndour scored a second-half equaliser to cancel out Francesco Pio Esposito’s first-minute opener and dent the visitor’s title charge.

Top results: LaLiga: Celta Vigo 3 (Jutgla 19, 37, Alvarez 27) lost to Alaves 4 (Martinez 45+3, 74, Perez 50, Rebbach 78); Bilbao 2 (Vivian 25, Sancet 45) bt Betis 1 (Fornals

75); Real Madrid 3 (Vinicius 52-pen, 72, Valverde 55) bt Atletico Madrid 2 (Lookman 33, Molina 66). **Serie A:** Bologna 0 lost to Lazio 2 (Taylor 72, 82). Fiorentina 1 (Ndour 77) drew with Inter Milan 1 (Esposito 1); Roma 1 (Vaz 57) bt Lecce 0.

Bundesliga: Augsburg 2 (Rieder 57, Kade 71) lost to Stuttgart 5 (Undav 12, 58, Tomas 29, Nartey 31, Demirovic 83); St. Pauli 1 (Sinani 24) lost to Freiburg 2 (Matanovic 65, 78); Mainz 2 (Nebe 6, 89) bt Frankfurt 1 (Brown 20).

AROUND THE CITY

Arjun bowls Egmore RC to big victory Off-spinner Arjun S. Nair scalped six for nine and bowled Egmore RC to a thumping 173-run win over Crombest in the TNCA second division league match held recently.



Arjun (Egmore RC, 6/9); Thyagarajan (Chatnath, 105 n.o.); Sathish (PUC, 5/16); Yukesh (MRC-B, 5/26); Nayef (UFCC, T. Nagar, 108).

Dharun 86, A. Baskar 4/49) bt Southern Railway Institute 251/8 in 50 overs (S. Sanjay 53, S. Raghunath 68, R. Venkatesh 3/44). Komaleeswarar 265 in 50 overs (Nitin R. Ramanan 74, G. M. Gokul 71, V. Abishek 38, Pratham Santosh Salunkhe 3/39) lost to Swaraj CC 268/7 in 49.4 overs (R. Anirudh Seshadri 81, L. Ramnath 64, I.S. Akash 43). Bunts CC 162 in 42 overs (Hunny 56, N. Aakaash Sharma 38, C. Sarath Kumar 37, Prashant Bhandari 3/13) lost to Coromandel SC 165/9 in 35.1 overs (Siddarth Prakash 74, B. Sivaramakrishnan 4/43). **IV-C:** Unicorn CC 194 in 46 overs (P. Tamilarasan 49, C.S. Mithun 35, E. Jaivanth 4/43) bt SBI 159 in 44.5 overs (B. Mohan 41, Y. Tushar 3/44, A. Rithan Kumar 3/58). KMC 113 in 30.5 overs (M. Sathish Kumar 5/16) lost to PUC 115/3 in 16 overs (K. Raja 31 n.o.). Vigneswara CC 187 in 50 overs (P. Venkatesan 67, J. Vanchinathan 3/51) bt Kumbhat CC 124 in 38.2 overs (P. Venkatesan 3/10). Book Sellers XI 228/9 in 50 overs

(M. Abisek 44, S. Prathamesh 79 n.o., C. Thivakar 3/68) lost to Chennai Port SC 231/5 in 45.2 overs (P. Girish Prabhu 87, C. Karthick Kumar 86 n.o.). Bharat Petroleum 154 in 34.5 overs (V. Naveen Kumar 41, A. Prabudeva 65, A. Moksh Bhaiya 4/27) lost to Triplicane CC 156/1 in 38.4 overs (S. Sathyanandh 81 n.o., S. Akshay Barath 44). BRC 241/7 in 50 overs (S.P. Ragul Rithick 66, G. Saran Prethium 41, B. Sachin 35, S. Gowri Sankar 33, S. Sanjith 31 n.o., T. Srijith 3/49, G. Selvakumar 3/55) lost to Chatnath RC 245/2 in 44.3 overs (B. Rahul 95, M. Thyagarajan 105 n.o.). **V-C:** MRC-B 198 in 48.5 overs (V. Harish Bharath 67, B. Ashok Kumar 57, K. Vishnu Kumar 4/32, R. Kiran 3/65) bt GTUC 164 in 45.2 overs (S. Ravikumar 33, E.R. Bharath Raj 35, B. Ravi Shankar 3/38, P. Yukesh 5/26). Magnet CC 199/9 in 50 overs (R.M. Tharun 34, A. Vaitthyanathan 34, M. Jayadevan 32, Abhishek Kumar 3/50) bt Saidapet Gymkhana 141 in 39.2 overs (G. Sharma 41, R. Sarvin Raj 4/23).

Cherie Chevalier tipped for the Telangana Plate

HYDERABAD: The four-year-old Cherie Chevalier, who ended second in his last start, should make amends in the Telangana Plate, the chief event of Tuesday’s (Mar. 24) races.

1. BUSINESS TYCOON PLATE (1,400m), 6-y-o and upward, rated 20 to 45 (Cat. III), 3.00 p.m.: 1. Catchme If You Can (6) Mukesh K 60, 2. Winning Attitude (7) Afroz K 60, 3. Take A Breath (2) Ajay K 59, 4. N R I Skypower (3) H.M. Akshay 58.5, 5. Smart Boy (5) B.R. Kumar 55, 6. Sadiya (4) P. Ajeeth K 53.5, 7. Exclusive Luck (1) Akshay K 52.5, 8. Sucker Punch (9) Rafique Sk. 52.5 and 9. Politics (8) G. Naresh 51.

1. CATCHME IF YOU CAN, 2. EXCLUSIVE LUCK, 3. SADIYA

2. RISING STAR PLATE (1,200m), (Terns) Maiden 3-y-o only (Cat. II), 3.30: 1. Advait (1) Antony Raj 56, 2. Ashwa Vivegam (II) P. Sai K 56, 3. Diamond King (II) B. Nikhil 56, 4. Excalibur (5) P. Ajeeth K 56, 5. My Way My Rules (4) Afroz K 56, 6. Ojas Maximus (1) I. Chisty 56, 7. The Last Avtar (9) Akshay 56, 8. Weseethesamesun

(3) B.R. Kumar 56, 9. Wind Castle (2) Kuldeep Sr. 56, 10. Aakarshaka (8) Md. Ismail 54.5, 11. Kinship (IO) Mukesh K 54.5 and 12. She’s A Bomb (7) H.M. Akshay 54.5.

1. ADVAIT, 2. THE LAST AVTAR, 3. OJAS MAXIMUS

3. BRAVE HUNTER PLATE (1,200m), 4-y-o and upward, rated 40 to 65 (Cat. II), 4.05: 1. Emerald Touch (5) Ashad Asbar 60, 2. Calababas (II) Ajay K 59.5, 3. Fly Tothe Stars (I) G. Naresh 59, 4. Top In Class (8) Md. Ismail 59, 5. Colt Pistol (12) Abhay Singh 58.5, 6. Turiya (9) Antony Raj 58.5, 7. Zuzza (IO) Kuldeep Jr. 57.5, 8. Greif (7) Akshay K 56, 9. Linda (4) Mukesh K 55, 10. Ayushman (4) Mukesh K 55, 11. Juramento (6) Surya Prakash 55 and 12. Nyanza (2) Rafique Sk. 53.

1. GREIF, 2. TURIYA, 3. CALABASAS

4. MEDCHAL PLATE (1,200m), 4-y-o and upward, rated 20 to 45 (Cat. III), 4.35: 1. Only My Way (I3) Afroz K 60, 2. Sunny Day (I) P. Ajeeth K 60, 3. Onslaught (3) Ashad Asbar 59, 4. Una Paloma Blanca (IO) Surya Prakash 57.5, 5. Nkalanzinzi (14) B.R. Kumar 55, 6.

Arthisha (II) Mukesh K 53.5, 7. Caraxes (2) Md. Ismail 53.5, 8. Star Councillor (6) Kuldeep Sr. 52.5, 9. Konaseema (7) Santosh Raj 51.5, 10. Opera Queen (4) H.M. Akshay 51.5, 11. The Divinely (5) Rafique Sk. 51.5, 12. December Caspian (8) Md. Ekram 51, 13. Hopping High (I2) B. Nikhil 51 and 14. Rate Of Interest (9) G. Naresh 51.

1. ARTHISHA, 2. ONSLAUGHT, 3. CARAXES

5. KHAMMAM PLATE (1,800m), 4-y-o and upward, rated 40 to 65 (Cat. II), 5.05: 1. China Town (5) P. Ajeeth K 60, 2. Bholi Punjaban (3) Surya Prakash 59.5, 3. Corte Madera (7) Akshay K 58, 4. Sangreal (6) Ajay K 55.5, 5. Andre (2) Antony Raj 55, 6. Perfect Light (I) B.R. Kumar 55 and 7. Pride Aside (4) B. Nikhil 50.5.

1. CORTE MADERA, 2. CHINA TOWN, 3. ANDRE

6. TELANGANA PLATE (1,600m), 4-y-o and upward, rated 80 and above (Cat. I), 5.35: 1. Truth (7) I. Chisty 65, 2. N R I Superpower (4) B.R. Kumar 55.5, 3. Reigning Beauty (6) Md. Ismail 52.5, 4. Cherie Chevalier (5)

Neeraj 52, 5. Last Wish (3) P. Ajeeth K 52, 6. Silver Act (2) B. Nikhil 51.5 and 7. Brooklyn Beauty (I) Md. Ekram 50.

1. CHERIE CHEVALIER, 2. N R I SUPERPOWER, 3. TRUTH

7. MALVADO PLATE (1,100m), 4-y-o and upward, rated upto 25 (Cat. III), 6.05: 1. Char Ek Char (I) Surya Prakash 61, 2. Dali’s Champion (6) Abhay Singh 61, 3. Noorian (8) Akshay K 61, 4. Pinatubo (3) Kuldeep Sr. 61, 5. Amboseli (IO) Uday Kiran 59.5, 6. Dhanadeepa (5) Mukesh K 59.5, 7. Always Special (2) P. Ajeeth K 58.5, 8. D Extreme (9) H.M. Akshay 56.5, 9. Iconic Star (4) Rafique Sk. 52 and 10. Niloufer The Great (7) Afriz K 51.5.

1. NOORIAN, 2. CHAR EK CHAR, 3. AMBOSELI

Day’s best: CORTE MADERA

Jackpot: 3, 4, 5, 6 & 7.

Mini jackpot: (i) 1, 2, 3 & 4, (ii) 4, 5, 6 & 7.

Treble: (i) 2, 3 & 4, (ii) 5, 6 & 7.

Tanala: All races.

Dyf completes a hat-trick of victories in the Golconda St. Leger

HYDERABAD: The seven-year-old grey horse Dyf, piloted by P. Trevor, etched his name in the record books by winning the Golconda St. Leger for the third time in a row at the Monday’s (March 23) races here.

The winner is owned by Mr. K.N. Dhunjibhoy and Mr. Z.K. Dhunjibhoy rep. Five Stars Shipping Co. Pvt. Ltd., M/s. Jiyaji Bhosale, Rishikesh Bhosale & Rama Seshu Eyunni. Adhiringajsingh Jodha trains the winner. Jockey Mukesh Kumar rode three winners on the day.

Originally scheduled to be held in October 2025, this classic race had been delayed due to an equine disease outbreak.

Trevor confidently settled Dyf in fourth position over the gruelling 2,800m trip.

Turning for home, he asked his mount for an effort and Dyf responded well to surge ahead and win in style.

1. OSMAN SAGAR PLATE (DIV. II) (1,100M): SHOOTING STAR (B.R. Kumar) 1, Cypress (Kuldeep Sr.) 2, Aquatone (Ashad Asbar) 3 and Pranava (B. Nikhil) 4. 1, 2 and 3-1/4. Im, 07.39s. ₹47 (w), II, 10 and 11 (p). SHP: 35, THP: 49, FP: 144, Q: 48, Tanala: 238. Favourite: Cypress. Owner: Mr. S. Pathy. Trainer: R.H. Sequeira.

2. YADADRI PLATE (1,100M): BUDDY (Mukesh Kumar) 1, Yali (Antony Raj) 2, Quattro (Santosh Raj) 3 and Trishika (Trevor) 4. 3-1/4, 2-1/4 and 2. Im, 05.44s. ₹73 (w), 14, 12 and 19 (p). SHP: 42, FP: 149, Q: 34, Tanala: 142.

3. OSMAN SAGAR PLATE (DIV. I) (1,100M): PETRA ACT (Mukesh Kumar) 1, Clarity (Ajay K) 2, Briar Ridge (Surya Prakash) 3 and Quality Warrior (Md. Ismail) 4. Not run: The Purpose. 2, 2-1/4 and 5-1/4. Im, 07.28s. ₹36 (w), 10, 12 and 14 (p). SHP: 37, THP: 41, FP: 210, Q: 73. Tanala: 650. Favourite: Roxane. Owners: M/s. Chandrasekhar Reddy Challuri, Boppidi Sham Sunder Reddy,

Srinivasa Rao Thota & Venkata Krishna Reddy Challuri. Trainer: Magan Singh.

4. SEA BIRD PLATE (1,100M): N R I HIGH POWER (Mukesh Kumar) 1, Sharanga (Antony Raj) 2, Foxy Girl (Afroz K) 3 and Lazarus (Rafique Sk.) 4. 5-1/2, 1-1/2 and 3/4. Im, 05.55s. ₹26 (w), 15, 14 and 19 (p). SHP: 37, THP: 37, FP: 105, Q: 46, Tanala: 201. Favourite: N R I High-power. Owners: M/s. Ravinder Reddy Thota, Suchit Jayraj Shah & Prabhakar Chowdary Tripuraneni. Trainer: D. Netto.

5. GOLCONDA ST. LEGER (GR. 3)



Memorable outing: Trevor, who rode Dyf to a third straight triumph, receiving his trophy from HRC chairman R. Surender Reddy in the presence of other officials. G. RAMAKRISHNA

(2,800M): DYF (COUGAR MOUNTAIN-SOAK) (P. TREVOR) 1, Ramiel (Win Legend-Angelique) (Antony Raj) 2, Get Lucky (Sedgefield-Santamarja Festa) (Mukesh K) 3 and Victor Hugo (Amperre-Edith Piaf) (Akshay K) 4. 3/4, 2 and 1-1/4. 3m, 07.66s. ₹19 (w), 12 and 32 (p). SHP: 49, THP: 68, FP: 108, Q: 84, Tanala: 1,191. Favourite: Dyf. Owners: Mr. K.N. Dhunjibhoy and Mr. Z.K. Dhunjibhoy rep. Five Stars Shipping Co Pvt. Ltd., M/s. Jiyaji Bhosale, Rishikesh Bhosale & Rama Seshu Eyunni. Trainer: Adhirajsingh Jodha.

6. DREAM GIRL PLATE (1,400M): KNIGHT REGENT (P. Trevor) 1, Blue Pantheress (B.R. Kumar) 2, Lifes Journey (G. Naresh) 3 and Sangreal (Ajay K) 4. 2-1/2, 1/2 and 4-1/4. Im 27, 13s. ₹11 (w), 10, 18 and 16 (p). SHP: 43, THP: 32, FP: 36, Q: 47, Tanala: 116. Favourite: Knight Regent. Owner: Mr. C. Aryama Sundaram. Trainer: L.V.R. Deshmukh.

7. POCHARAM PLATE (1,600M): GENIE (Md. Ekram Alan) 1, Anemoi (Surya Prakash) 2, N R I Star (Trevor) 3 and Desert Sultan (Md. Ismail) 4. Not run: Secret Option. 2, 2-1/2 and 2. Im, 42.59s. ₹50 (w), 12, 20 and 10 (p). SHP: 65, THP: 31, FP: 213, Q: 160, Tanala: 752. Favourite: Take A Breath. Owner: M.A.M. Ramaswamy Chettiar Of Chettinad Charitable Trust. Trainer: K. Satheesh.

Jackpot: 70%: ₹1,038 (436 tkts.) & 30%: ₹19 (1,620 tkts.).

Mini jackpot: 10, 316 (6 tkts.). Treble: (i) 913 (36 tkts.), (ii) 89 (444 tkts.).

ASIAN COLLEGE OF JOURNALISM

Bloomberg

ACJ Postgraduate Diploma in Integrated Multimedia Journalism

ACJ-Bloomberg Postgraduate Diploma in Business and Financial Multimedia Journalism

ADMISSIONS OPEN

Class of 2026-27

www.asianmedia.org

Asian College of Journalism

#youacjonlyonce



GETTY IMAGES & B. JOTHI RAMALINGAM

R. Kaushik

Last year, it was Corbin Bosch, the South African all-rounder. This year, the list has grown longer by one, for now – Blessing Muzarabani, the towering Zimbabwean paceman who had a wonderful T20 World Cup, and Dasun Shanaka, the all-rounder who led Sri Lanka in the same tournament which concluded earlier this month.

We are talking about the late shift of players from the Pakistan Super League to the Indian Premier League. It isn't just a late shift, it's about severing one contract at the last minute to sign a more lucrative deal to be a part of inarguably the most visible franchise-driven T20 competition in the world.

From 2025 onwards, there has been an overlap in dates between the PSL and the IPL. Last year, that was necessitated by Pakistan hosting the Champions Trophy in February-March, though the tournament was also played in Dubai. This year, the PSL had to be postponed from its pre-2025 window owing to the T20 World Cup, which ran in India and Sri Lanka between February 7 and March 8.

The only window available for the Pakistan Cricket Board to conduct the PSL coincided with the IPL; the PSL is due to start this Thursday, two days before the IPL kicks off at the M. Chinnaswamy Stadium with defending champions Royal Challengers Bengaluru locking horns with 2016 winners Sunrisers Hyderabad.

Bosch, part of the Diamond category, had been picked up by Peshawar Zalmi for PSL 2025 before he moved to Mumbai Indians as an injury replacement for fellow South African Lizaad Williams. Understandably miffed at this late 'desertion', the PCB slapped a one-year ban on the now 31-year-old, making him ineligible to play in PSL 2026.

Not that it has made any real difference to the right-arm pacer and hard-hitting batter, considering he is part of the MI roster this year too.

Bosch did it first

Following in Bosch's footsteps are Muzarabani and Shanaka. Muzarabani was one of the standout players for Zimbabwe, who advanced to the Super Eight from a tricky Group B with an unbeaten record. Zimbabwe hadn't even qualified for the previous T20 World Cup, in the Americas in June 2024, but heralded their return to the competition with a stunning victory over Australia in their second group tie.

As if to show that the performance was no flash in the pan, they then subdued the home crowd and Sri Lanka's superstars in their final league clash to top their group and earn a shot at the West Indies, India and South Africa in the next stage.

Muzarabani took four for 17 against Australia, backed it up with two for 38 against the hosts and finished the competition with 13 wickets from just six outings. He was in the running to top the

chart, and it needed the genius of Jasprit Bumrah and a solitary wicket for Varun Chakaravathy in the final for the two Indians to get past him with 14 scalps apiece.

Long before the World Cup, Muzarabani had made a pitch for an IPL berth but went unsold at the auction. He had been a part of the RCB set-up during their title-winning campaign in 2025, signed up as a mid-tournament replacement for the WTC final-bound Lungi Ngidi, but did not play a game. Just as he was readying to extend his relationship with the PSL came a call from the Kolkata Knight Riders management, which sought his services instead of Mustafizur Rahman, the Bangladesh left-arm quick whom they let go in controversial circumstances earlier this year. There was no way Muzarabani was turning that offer down.

Shanaka has moved to Rajasthan Royals as a replacement for Sam Curran, the England all-rounder. In the closed season, Curran was one of two players – Ravindra Jadeja being the other – that five-time champions Chennai Super Kings traded out to Royals to acquire Sanju Samson, who would later go on to become the Player of the Tournament at the T20 World Cup.

Curran played a big part in England's march to the semifinals, but during the course of that campaign, he is learnt to have picked up a groin injury that ended his chances of representing a new IPL franchise.

Shanaka, 34, has limited IPL experience; he played three games for Gujarat Titans in 2023 and was a mid-season substitute for the injured Glenn Phillips last year without getting a match. Like Muzarabani, he too was ignored at the mini-auction ahead of IPL 2026 but a backdoor has opened up through Curran's injury and Shanaka has gratefully grabbed his chance.

Classed as an all-rounder, Shanaka is more of a hard-hitting batter who has been a reluctant bowler; he has a strike-rate of 143.13 in 283 20-over representative games (average 25.83) against 111 wickets, mainly because he averages only 1.2 overs per match.

Strong response expected

Like last year, the PCB hasn't taken kindly to these developments. Its chairman, the irascible Mohsin Naqvi, has again threatened legal action against the 'players who have left'. That the players left at very short notice itself would have been galling; their decision to dump the PSL for the IPL must be particularly infuriating, given the geopolitical tensions between India and Pakistan and the fact that Suryakumar Yadav refused to receive the T20 Asia Cup trophy from Naqvi, who is also the boss of the Asian Cricket Council.

As is often the case in such instances, opinion has been divided on whether Muzarabani and Shanaka this year, and Bosch before him, did the right thing. Their morals have been questioned when what is undeniable is that everyone's

morals are their own outlook and no one else has the right to impose them on someone else.

From the players' perspective, and one is only guessing here, to pass up the chance of being a part of the IPL landscape would have been unthinkable. Without a shadow of doubt, the reach and clout of the IPL are beyond parallel in the cricketing universe. It has opened hitherto invisible doors; its profile is immense, and while the money isn't shabby, it also provides a great opportunity to learn and grow as an individual and a cricketer.

More than just money

The tendency to view the IPL through the prism of financial gains alone is both myopic and convenient. Where else do you have the chance to pick the brains of the best in the business, either occupying the same dressing room or sitting in the opposition dugout? Where else can you savour the experience of playing in front of at least 35,000 spectators? Of learning to cope with noise, pressure and expectations? Of furthering one's education as a cricketer?

It was once said that the English County firmament was the ideal finishing school but that has long passed into history. Admittedly, even till the start of the millennium, a tryst in England at the highest first-class level was an immense learning experience but that is no longer the case.

The IPL has become a finishing school of sorts, and while it is easy to dismiss that remark as facile because it is 'only' a 20-over tournament, let's not forget which format has come to be the flavour of the sport globally. While we can continue to romanticise Test cricket and hope that it survives the very genuine threat of T20 cricket, it is the latter which has caught the imagination of a larger audience.

It's a truism that can't be wished away; gradually, international careers are becoming shorter as more and more professionals are plunging into franchise leagues. Who's to blame them because while we might attach patriotic and nationalist mores, these are players trying their best to eke out a livelihood within the contours of their limited shelf lives.

Muzarabani and Shanaka, and perhaps a couple more who are still expected to make the cross-border move, might use this line of thought to justify their actions though they will also be aware of the risk they run of being called 'mercenaries' by those who hold a divergent point of view. To leave a team, any team, in the lurch at the last minute and therefore not honouring one's word is far from ideal unless the circumstances are pressing and the exit unavoidable.

Those so inclined will argue with justification that there was nothing pressing or unavoidable about their shift

from the PSL to the IPL, and that their decision has been influenced merely by 'greed'. To misquote – for the sake of propriety – a popular saying, opinions are like a nose, everyone has one. And therefore, this is a debate that cannot be settled satisfactorily, one way or the other.

A change on the cards?

Perhaps, the PSL will smell the coffee and revert to its previous timeline that ensured the tournament ran ahead of the IPL and therefore there was no danger of late pullouts and moves to the bigger league. Or maybe it won't if ego comes in the way and the PCB continues to believe in the power of the PSL which, it has said, has become so big, vibrant and productive that the Pakistan board is no longer dependent on the International Cricket Council for financial clout.

The PCB has projected Marnus Labuschagne, Steve Smith and Glenn Maxwell, the Australian trio, as being the overseas poster boys of this edition, arguing that their presence has lifted the profile of the tournament. Maybe it has, but it must not be forgotten that former captain Smith went unsold at the IPL auction or that the underachieving Maxwell, perhaps reading the obvious writing on the wall, chose to not even throw his hat in the ring.

This isn't about which is the bigger, stronger, more influential and powerful league because that is not even a debate. But if one does want to debate the pros and cons of Muzarabani and Shanaka's decisions, they can do so till the cows come home and still not arrive at a satisfactory conclusion. Because that's how it is sometimes.

THE GIST

From 2025 onwards, there has been an overlap in dates between the PSL and the IPL

The IPL has become a finishing school of sorts, and while it is easy to dismiss that remark as facile because it is 'only' a 20-over tournament, let's not forget which format has come to be the flavour of the sport globally

The PCB has projected Marnus Labuschagne, Steve Smith and Glenn Maxwell, the Australian trio, as being the overseas poster boys of this edition, arguing that their presence has lifted the profile of the tournament



Text & Context

THE HINDU

NEWS IN NUMBERS

Rejection rate of Right to Information applications in 2024-25

3.26 in per cent. The rejection rate of Right to Information (RTI) applications has decreased to 3.26 per cent in 2024-25, the Centre has said. If an applicant receives no reply to an RTI within the prescribed time or is aggrieved by the public information officer's decision, they may file appeals before the CIC, Union Minister Jitendra Singh said. PTI

Number of people killed due to rains in Kenya in March

81 Torrential rains continued to pound Kenya as flash floods killed at least 81 people this month, authorities said Sunday. Flash floods also destroyed around 1,200 hectares of farmland and swept away crops. Over 3,000 families have been forced from their homes in the community of Nyakach, with some sheltering in eight evacuation centres, locals said. AFP

Number of AC e-buses to be deployed in 116 cities by 2027

10,000 On Monday, the government informed the Rajya Sabha that 10,000 air-conditioned e-buses would be provided to 116 cities across 26 States and UTs by the end of 2027 under the PM-eBus Sewa Scheme, and a new scheme would be launched thereafter to provide another 35,000 e-buses. PTI

Number of airlines that exited India in the last decade

11 As many as 11 airlines exited the market in the last 10 years due to financial stress, non-availability of aircraft and other internal issues, according to the government. Minister of State for Civil Aviation Murlidhar Mohol told the Rajya Sabha on Monday that the aviation sector is deregulated, and airlines operate based on commercial considerations. PTI

Persons displaced in Ethiopia's Tigray over the past three years

1 In million. More than 1,300 people have died from hunger in displacement camps in Ethiopia's volatile Tigray region over the past three years, a local official told AFP on Monday. A civil war between the federal government and forces from the northern Tigray region in 2020-2022 killed at least 600,000 people according to African Union estimates. AFP
COMPILED BY THE HINDU DATA TEAM

Follow us [facebook.com/thehindu](#) [X.com/the_hindu](#) [instagram.com/the_hindu](#)

Path ahead for Nepal's new leadership

After securing a historic mandate in Nepal's polls, Balendra Shah and the RSP face the task of navigating the West Asia conflict and managing ties with India, China and the U.S. While capitalising on old-guard fatigue proved an effective electoral strategy, the new leadership now faces a test in international relations

WORLD INSIGHT

Bibek Raj Kandel

In the noisy, crowded landscape of Nepali politics, the rise of Prime Minister-designate Balendra Shah and his party, the Rastriya Swatantra Party (RSP), represents a rare political anomaly. While veterans of the 2008 republic traded barbs, the rapper-engineer-turned-mayor bypassed traditional campaigning for a "monastic" silence. His victory in Nepal's post-Gen Z parliamentary election on March 5 secured a historic mandate for an alternative force he joined a mere six weeks before the polls. Throughout the campaign, Shah spoke for barely thirty minutes, avoided media interviews and notably never once asked for a vote.

His unapologetic critiques of the political establishment during his tenure as Kathmandu's mayor, mirrored a generation exhausted by stale ideological party politics. In a nation with a median age of twenty-five, Shah's reputation as a disciplined, clean reformist promising better governance became a viral mandate. His calculated silence mirrored these frustrations, positioning him as the ultimate outsider for an electorate eager for results.

Beyond domestic politics

While capitalising on domestic old-guard fatigue served Shah as a winning electoral strategy, Nepal's hard geopolitical reality remains stubbornly unchanged. In Nepal, political shifts rarely remain purely domestic, often prompting debates about foreign influence given its geography wedged between the rivalries of India and China.

Yet, Shah, however has sought to counter this by projecting an image of a staunch nationalist. As mayor, his symbolism was deliberate: hanging a "Greater Nepal" map in his office as a direct retort to the "Akhand Bharat" mural in India's new Parliament House, and



Balendra Shah with children and supporters during a door-to-door election campaign in Nepal. AFP

briefly banning Indian films. Simultaneously, he signaled caution toward Beijing by dropping a China-backed industrial park from his election manifesto. By distancing himself from large-scale geopolitical projects, Shah reframed the narrative, asserting a sovereignty that felt local, visible, and unapologetically independent.

Balancing ties with India and China

Historically, Nepal's politics followed rigid ideological scripts. The Nepali Congress, the country's oldest liberal force, leaned toward Delhi, while communist factions like CPN- UML maintained proactive affinities with Beijing. And at times, the ideological rhetoric from Kathmandu stretched far beyond the Himalayas, from debates over Venezuela's regime change to contentious political statements on the Ukraine war, issues largely peripheral to Nepal's own priorities. Under Shah, this era of predictable ideological signaling may finally be fading. His minimalist approach and by speaking less about the world's ideological battles, Shah's personality itself can be potent strategic asset to Nepal, but it is immediately replaced by a different kind of geopolitical

pressure that needs sustained diplomatic communique.

India remains Nepal's most consequential partner, linked by an open border, "Roti-Beti" social bonds, and accounting for a significant share of its trade, supplying virtually all of its petroleum, and emerging as the primary market for Nepal's burgeoning hydropower exports. Meanwhile, China has deepened its footprint through major infrastructure financing, such as \$216 million Pokhara International Airport. Intended as a regional gateway, its underutilisation is viewed in Kathmandu as a casualty of the broader India-China friction, particularly New Delhi's hesitancy to facilitate air routes for Chinese-financed infrastructure.

This is perhaps inaugural diplomatic crucible for Balendra Shah. Having invested heavily, Nepal cannot afford for such massive infrastructure to remain a "white elephant." The "monastic" outsider must now navigate a landscape where India is indispensable and China is influential. Meanwhile, Washington has pivoted from an aid partner to a high-stakes strategic interest partner, with recent post-election congratulations

explicitly hinting at "shared security goals."

But the first "baptism by fire" for the Shah administration may well lie in the volatile West Asia. With millions of Nepalese migrants' lives and critical energy lifelines tied to the Persian Gulf caught in an escalating US-Israel- Iran War, India's logistical depth as a regional first responder offers an indispensable synergy for contingency planning to Kathmandu. This is where Balen's nationalist doctrine must meet the hard reality of strategic pragmatism. The new leadership remains untested in conventional diplomacy.

An opportunity for India

This moment offers a rare opening for New Delhi to recalibrate. India must move past the coercive shadow of the 2015 blockade and what is widely perceived in Kathmandu as outdated impulse for political micromanagement. New Delhi must recognise this transition as a new opening for modern partnership that respects the domestic rise of 'Nepal First' politics. Shah's mandate mirrors India's own tectonic shift in 2014; in Shah, Nepal has found its "strongman" archetype, a leader whose personal charisma and promise of technocratic reform have dismantled a decades-old establishment.

In the end, Nepal's geopolitical reality remains unchanged even as its politics transform at home. India's proximity will always matter most, China's influence will remain structural reality, and world powers like the U.S. will continue to pursue its strategic interests with renewed rigor. Ultimately, Nepal's voters were not adjudicating between global strategies, but seeking domestic renewal. For Balendra Shah and the RSP, bashing the "old guard" is a potent domestic strategy, but it carries zero currency in the cold-eyed theater of international relations. (Bibek Raj Kandel is an analyst and AsiaGlobal Fellow at the University of Hong Kong and a graduate of Harvard Kennedy School.)

THE GIST

In the landscape of Nepali politics, the rise of Prime Minister-designate Balendra Shah and the RSP, represents a rare political anomaly. His reputation as a disciplined, clean reformist promising better governance became a viral mandate

Shah's personality itself can be potent strategic asset to Nepal, but it is immediately replaced by a different kind of geopolitical pressure that needs sustained diplomatic communique

Nepal's political shift opens a strategic window for India

The new government in Nepal extends an opportunity to fashion a forward-looking bilateral relationship

K.V. Rajan
Atul K. Thakur

The election results in Nepal have been described as a political earthquake. There has been an emphatic and comprehensive rejection of old leaders and established parties. A younger generation of professionals and tech savvy figures, enjoying the support of Gen Z activists is set to take over.

Challenges ahead

By giving the Rastriya Swatantra Party (RSP) a two thirds majority, Nepali voters have granted Balendra Shah and his government, a powerful mandate for Nepal's complete transformation. It now has a huge responsibility to answer wide-ranging expectations--enough jobs for the youth, reversing the migration for

work abroad, stimulate economic growth, and ensure good governance. It needs to be noted, however, that while voters have demonstrated their impatience with the old order and its decades- old insensitivity to their aspirations, this is not a positive vote for a clear-cut new agenda for reform, political or economic, since it was never spelt out and placed before them.

There is a real possibility of frustration and disillusionment that the new government will have to deal with as it settles down. The first warning shots were fired by the caretaker Prime Minister Sushil Karki even before the election, when she reminded the political class that the agitations of September 2025 had erupted because of the frustrations of people insisting on good governance, and a recurrence was inevitable if the situation lapsed into the same old pattern. Hopefully the people of Nepal will give

the new leaders enough time to address the country's problems.

Restructuring India-Nepal ties

For now, Nepal deserves every encouragement possible. India has been quick to extend it, without being loud or patronising. India has not been an issue during the election campaign. Its relationship with Nepal in recent years has focused on the right priorities -- development, infrastructure, digital connectivity, energy. It has played its cards well and can continue to capitalise on the existing goodwill as the new leaders in Nepal seek to respond to development needs of the people.

Restructuring of the India-Nepal relationship has been long overdue. For far too long it has been trapped in the shadows of the legacy of British India days. Hopefully India and Nepal will seize

every opportunity to fashion a forward-looking relationship based on today's realities and the immense potential for expanding cooperation. For this it will be necessary for policy makers on both sides to discard old mindsets, address long standing irritants with fresh approaches, and prioritise people-centric policies which can be delivered to keep pace with people's expectations and needs.

India also needs to look at the recent developments in Nepal as part of a wider regional phenomenon since happenings in Bangladesh, Sri Lanka and elsewhere also fall into the same pattern--agitations led by frustrated youth incidentally toppling pro-India political figures, demanding faster development and better governance. Labeling new political leaders being thrown up everywhere as anti-India just because of the legacies of the past does not seem justified, as seen from the pragmatic readiness shown in Bangladesh and Sri Lanka to cooperate with India, by parties and leaders once seen as unfriendly. Nepal could be a good partner for India in the evolving geopolitical scenario, if both countries try seriously to fashion a clear cut sub-regional strategy for rapid growth. (K.V. Rajan is former Indian Ambassador to Nepal and Atul K. Thakur is a policy professional. They are the authors of 'Kathmandu Chronicle: Reclaiming India-Nepal Relations'. Views are personal.)

THE GIST

The people of Nepal have granted Balendra Shah and the RSP a powerful mandate for Nepal's complete transformation. The government now faces the challenge of addressing the issues of unemployment and providing good governance

India has been quick to extend encouragement to the new leadership. Hopefully India and Nepal will seize every opportunity to fashion a forward- looking relationship based on today's realities

